



PARLIAMENTARY DEBATES

OFFICIAL REPORT

CONTENTS

FORMAL STATEMENT BY THE SPEAKER— [Col. 125]

VOTES AND PROCEEDINGS AND THE OFFICIAL REPORT— [Col.1]

STATEMENT—

Achievement of the Black Queens at the 2024 WAFCON— [Col. 4]

MOTIONS—

(a) Sixteenth Report on the President's Nomination for Appointment as Deputy Ministers— [Col. 39]

(b) Determination of the Urgency of the Social Protection Bill, 2025—[Col. 131]

(c) Mid-Year Budget Review, 2025— [Col. 161]

BILL — SECOND READING

(a) Social Protection Bill, 2025—[Col. 143]

ADJOURNMENT — [Col. 252]

Correction of errors of substance may be made only on the floor of the House with the permission of the Speaker. However, correction of typographical or grammatical errors which Members suggest for the Bound Volumes which will be compiled at the end of the Meeting may be clearly marked in the Daily Report, and the copy containing the corrections submitted at the Editor's Office, Parliament House, not later than four clear days after the publication of the Daily Report.

BOUND VOLUMES of the Official Report (each with a comprehensive Index) are issued periodically during the Session. There is no fixed subscription rate, but prices will be quoted on each publication.

*Published by the Office of Chamber Reporting
Parliament House, Osu, Accra.*

*Designed and Printed by the Publishing Department
Parliament House, Osu, Accra*

©2025 Parliament of Ghana.

THE
PARLIAMENT OF THE REPUBLIC
OF GHANA

SECOND MEETING, 2025

Tuesday, 29th July, 2025

*The House met at the Chamber of
Parliament at 3.03 p.m.*

[HON SECOND DEPUTY
SPEAKER, MR ANDREW
ASIAMAH AMOAKO, IN THE
CHAIR]

[PRAYERS]

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, kindly turn to the item numbered 5 — Correction of *Votes and Proceedings* and the *Official Report*.

**VOTES AND PROCEEDINGS
AND
THE OFFICIAL REPORT**

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, we would take the *Votes and Proceedings* of Monday, 28th July, 2025.

Page 1...12—

Mr Frank Afriyie: Mr Speaker, with respect, may I kindly call your attention to the item numbered 11 under the page in review. On the item numbered 11(a), “Security and Intelligence Agencies Bill”. The year of the Bill which is “2025” should be added at the end of it.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Very well. Table, kindly acknowledge that correction.

Yes, Hon Member for Effia?

Mr Isaac Boamah-Nyarko: Mr Speaker, on page 12, the first paragraph says:

“The House observed silence for a minute in memory of the departed legend.”

Mr Speaker, I suggest that we capture it as:

“The House observed a minute’s silence in memory of the departed legend”

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Very well, Hon Isaac Boamah-Nyarko, you are a lawyer, at times there is a certain way words are arranged, and this has been the standard way the House has always put this.

Hon Members, let us turn to page 13...15—

Mr Afriyie: Mr Speaker, just a minor but important correction. On the item numbered 3 (iv), the name should be “Michael”. As it stands now, it should be “a” before “e”, but now we have “e” before “a”.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Table, please acknowledge the corrections.

Page 16—

Mr Afriyie: Mr Speaker, on page 16, the item numbered 3 (xxiv), Mr Gideon Hammond, is the Deputy Director-General for the National Sports Authority. But “Sport” has been spelt without the “s”, therefore, it should be written as “National Sports Authority”.

Then again, on the same page, the item numbered 3(xxvii), Mr Bismark Aaron Parker, is a Public Relations Officer. But “Relation” has been written without the “s”. I pray that the Clerks-at-the-Table add “s” to the word “Relation”.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Thank you very much for your diligence. Table, kindly acknowledge those corrections.

Hon Members, let us turn to page 17...19—

Hon Members, in the absence of any further corrections, the *Votes and Proceedings* of Monday, 28th July, 2025, is hereby adopted as a true record of proceedings.

Yes, Hon Members, we turn to Statements. If the Minister for Sports and Recreation is here, I would yield the floor to him to make a Statement.

Minister, you can come to the podium, please.

STATEMENT

Achievement of the Black Queens at the 2024 WAFCON

Minister for Sports and Recreation (Mr Kofi Iddie Adams): Mr Speaker, I rise to address this august House, not just as a Minister, but as a proud Ghanaian, to commend the remarkable performance of Ghana’s senior women’s national football team, the Black Queens, who sit with us in the gallery today as history makers, having secured a bronze medal at the just ended 2024 Women’s Africa Cup of Nations (WAFCON) in Morocco.

Mr Speaker, the Black Queens arrived at the tournament with a modest fanfare but high expectations. Drawn into a competitive group, the team began their campaign with difficult loss to defending champions South Africa, followed by a draw against Mali. They rebounded emphatically with a resounding 4-1 victory over Tanzania, securing qualification to the quarter-finals.

Mr Speaker, in the knockout stage, they delivered a memorable performance, edging out a formidable Algerian side on penalties to reach the semifinals for the first time since 2016. Though they were narrowly defeated by the host nation, Morocco, in a dramatic 120-minute semi-final that ended in a penalty shootout, they regrouped and returned to face South Africa once more in the third-place playoff. Again, they emerged victorious, securing the bronze medal.

3.13 p.m.

Mr Speaker, this milestone was not achieved on the back of comfort or ease. The Black Queens endured a challenging path throughout the competition, including two back-to-back 120-minute matches and three penalty shootouts, all of which they approached with discipline, character, and tactical maturity. Their return to the WAFCON podium, for the first time since 2016, is not coincidental. It reflects the targeted investments and renewed focus on women's football. Significantly, both podium finishes in 2016 and now in 2025, have come under the leadership of President John Dramani Mahama. This, in no doubt, reaffirms the deliberate attention this Administration accords the women's sports development.

Mr Speaker, the Government of Ghana, through the Ministry of Sports and Recreation, fulfilled largely, every commitment to the Black Queens by providing comprehensive technical, logistical, and welfare support before and throughout the competition. From pre-camp preparations to the disbursement of what is due them. I would say that they lacked nothing under our watch. I personally showed a lot of interest in attending their games and training points, just to motivate them.

Mr Speaker, in saluting this achievement, it is important that we recognise the 24 gallant women who proudly wore the national colours and carried the hopes of our nation. They include:

Goalkeepers – Kerry McCarthy, Cynthia Fiindib Konlan, Afi Amenyaku, who saved those great penalties, both to send us to the semi-finals and also to give us the bronze.

Defenders –Ernestina Abambilla, Susan Duah, Josephine Bonsu, Portia Boakyee, Nina Norshie, Comfort Yeboah, Louisa Aniwaa and Anastasia Achiaa.

Midfielders – Grace Asantewaa, Nancy Amoh, Evelyn Badu, Chantelle B. Hlorkah, Jacqueline Owusu, Stella Nyamekye and Jennifer Cudjoe.

Forwards – Alice Kusi, Doris Boaduwa, Wasima Mohammed, Sherifatu Sumaila, Princella Adubea and Princess Marfo.

To these remarkable women, this House and the Nation say: *Ayekoo*. Their names will inspire the next generation, not only for what they achieved, but for how they carried themselves with dignity, strength, and unrelenting sense of purpose. There was so much sense of purpose in these players as they played 120 minutes back-to-back, but they continued to show strength.

Mr Speaker, these results required unity, both on and off the pitch. I acknowledge the entire technical team, ably led by Head Coach Kim Lars Björkegren — if Kim Lars is here, I salute him — the management group, and the Ghana Football Association, for their dedication, professionalism, commitment, and steering the ship. One person, our

former Colleague, Hon Betty Krosbi Mensah, who is my technical advisor, played a key role in getting this through, and I recognise her at this moment.

Mr Speaker, I further extend, on behalf of the Ministry and Government, our deepest appreciation to the Ambassador of Ghana to the Kingdom of Morocco, Her Excellency Mrs Charity Gbedawo, and the entire Diplomatic Mission. Their exceptional hospitality and logistical support were instrumental to the comfort and morale of the team and delegation. Indeed, considering the investment that is being made in Morocco, and the number of events that will be happening there, that Mission deserves further recognition and support.

Mr Speaker, we also celebrate the Ghana supporters who travelled at their own expense, and stood firm in the stance from start to finish, creating a home crowd atmosphere for the team throughout the tournament. Their passion and selfless commitment were a vital source of motivation for the Black Queens.

Mr Speaker, the performance of the Black Queens must serve as a national rallying point. This is the moment for state institutions, corporate Ghana, and the general public to move beyond symbolic praise and commit to sustained investment in women's sport. The Queens have not only proven their worth as athletes, but as ambassadors

of Ghanaian potential. This is not just about football; it is a powerful message that when we invest in our women and give them the platform, results will follow. For too long, women's football in Ghana has existed in the shadows. The Black Queens have broken that ceiling. Through sweat, unity, and excellence, they have earned the nation's attention.

Mr Speaker, the Ministry of Sports and Recreation remains committed to enhancing the welfare, training conditions, and development pathways for all national teams, including the Black Queens. This performance is a springboard for renewed investment in women's sports infrastructure and capacity building. The Government will continue to provide the platform and resources for our female athletes to excel at the highest level.

Mr Speaker, I invite all Hon Members, and indeed every Ghanaian, to rise and salute the Black Queens for the courage, discipline, and conviction they displayed throughout this tournament. Their journey ends with a bronze medal today, but it lays the foundation for gold tomorrow.

Mr Speaker, I thank you for the opportunity to make this Statement, and respectfully invite Members of the House to join me in welcoming and congratulating the Black Queens.

Black Queens, *Ayekoo*. Thank you very much. They did us proud. [*Hear! Hear!*]

Mr Second Deputy Speaker:

Thank you very much, Hon Minister for Sports and Recreation. Hon Members, the Statement to eulogise our gallant ladies has been read to us. I will now invite Members who are desirous to comment and congratulate our gallant ladies to do so.

Please, we would do it in such a way that nobody heckles anyone. Today, we have a lot of programmes. So, once you get the opportunity, please just be minded that we do not have much time. Let me begin with the Chairman of the Committee on Youth and Sports.

Mr Ricketts-Hagan — *rose* —

Mr Second Deputy Speaker:

Yes, Leader?

Mr Ricketts-Hagan:

Mr Speaker, I wanted to advert your mind to the fact that we want to do three comments from each Side, so that we can take other Businesses as well, because we have a lot of Business today.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker:

Very well. the Leader is suggesting we do three comments from each Side.

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu:

Mr Speaker, I do not know why we should cap the comments on the success that our women have chalked. So, I suggest that maybe we take four comments from each Side, and then Leadership, but three each would

limit it. I do not think the Minister for Sports and Recreation would be happy about that, that our women who have performed very well are here and we want to limit our comments to just three people from each Side. It can be short comments, but we should not cap it.

Mr Ricketts-Hagan: Mr Speaker, I would agree with him. We can take four comments from Side. In fact, we would have loved to take 10 or 20 comments, but for the sake of time.

3.23 p.m.

For the sake of time, we will go with the four.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker:

Very well.

Hon Members, we are doing four on each Side; then I will come to Leadership. But like I said, we do not have the luxury of time, so, please, just be minded. Nobody should comment beyond three minutes.

Yes, Hon Member for Ashaiman?

Mr Ernest Henry Norgbey (NDC — Ashaiman):

Mr Speaker, I rise to associate myself with the Minister for Sports and Recreation and, also with national pride and admiration, congratulate our women, the Black Queens of Ghana, who performed splendidly and spectacularly in faraway Morocco.

Mr Speaker, this is just more than a win on the pitch because it is a celebration of resilience and national spirit. The journey was full of challenges, as we are all aware. The Hon Minister made mention of it that they started on a bad note, but, at the end of the day, they came out with bronze and they were able to beat the ever-determined South African women's national team. Mr Speaker, the Black Queens have done Ghana proud. Let it be said that they were the first national team to qualify Ghana to the World Cup some years back and they continue to make Ghana proud.

Mr Speaker, as we speak in this Chamber, in faraway Nigeria, the President, Mr Bola Ahmed Tinubu, has rewarded the members of the women's national team with US\$100,000 each and US\$50,000 each to the technical team. He also gave the members of the team a three-bedroom apartment. Mr Speaker—

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, please—

Mr Norgbey: Let me just call on the Government, as well as the private sector, to invest in sports in Ghana, especially the women's sports because they continue to make us proud and everybody is happy about their achievements. All that we need is more investment in the sporting sector because that is the only thing that makes all of us happy. If the economy is bad and our national teams continue to win their tournaments and matches, Ghanaians and the youth will always be happy.

So, let me take the opportunity, once again, to congratulate our women, the technical team, the supporting union and everybody, including the Minister who has done a yeoman's job. It is true that Ghana is working. It is true that we are resetting Ghana. For over nine years, this is the first time we have qualified for the semi-final and we have gone ahead to win the bronze medal.

Mr Speaker, I thank you and I congratulate our women. May God bless us. They should continue to make Ghana proud.

Mr Isaac Boamah-Nyarko (NPP — Effia): Mr Speaker, let me join in commending the Minister for Sports and Recreation, Hon Kofi Adams, for making this Statement, acknowledging and praising the Black Queens of Ghana for this feat they have chalked.

Mr Speaker, ordinarily, Ghana stood as one of the best football countries in the world. When we come to Africa, there was no way when we talk about football, Ghana would not be mentioned as one of the top three. Now, from the Black Stars to the Black Queens—When women's football started developing in Africa, Black Queens of Ghana has remained one of the best female football teams in the whole of Africa.

In fact, the only country that Ghana had difficulty beating, ordinarily, was Nigeria. So, normally when we play African football, Ghana will qualify and play all the games and then it is

either we win or we lose to Nigeria. Those were the days when we had goalkeeper Memunatu Sulemana, Adwoa Bayor and Alberta Sackey, all playing quality football in this country. So, it came as a big worry to us, as a people, when we saw Ghana's football diminishing to the extent that even qualifying for such tournaments became a problem.

So, ordinarily, we would not have been here celebrating placing third, but because we are falling so low, in terms of football, it is important that the achievement of the Black Queens, today, ought to be celebrated. I am very happy, particularly, for this female team because I watched their progression through the group stages and I saw how tirelessly they fought for qualifying to the quarterfinals. Then, in the semi-finals, I was really hoping that, since we won by penalties in the quarterfinals, we would succeed in winning against Morocco during the semi-finals, but, unfortunately, we lost and here we are with the bronze.

Mr Speaker, it is interesting to note that two of our female players got called into the top 11. After every tournament, they nominate team of the tournament and two of our players were nominated: Grace Asantewaa and Portia Boakye and it is important that we congratulate and acknowledge them. Though football is a teamwork, anytime we have two of our members, at the end of a tournament, getting appreciated as part of the team of the tournament, we need to appreciate them.

Mr Speaker, in winding up, I want us to invest more in women's football. This is because the team we see today are a group of people who have come from various football teams, but there is very little support for female football across the country. The regional football associations do not have the support and the female football teams that play in the regions do not get the support.

So, Mr Speaker, since we do not have much time, I want to join in congratulating our female team and we wish them well in the future. Thank you for the opportunity, Mr Speaker. *[Hear! Hear!]*

Hajia Laadi Ayii Ayamba (NDC — Pusiga): Thank you very much, Mr Speaker, for giving me the opportunity to associate myself with the Statement ably made by the Minister.

Mr Speaker, I am so proud of the Black Queens. It has been a long time that we have waited and looked on and, today, they have actually made us proud, not for themselves and not for only we women in Parliament here, but all women and girls in Africa and the whole world.

The first day I watched the Black Queens and it looked like it was not going to be in our favour, I became very sad. I said, "No, not again". Then, I realised that they went back, picked up the pieces, and made sure that it never became like they cannot do it; they agreed and teamed up.

They put together the teamwork that they have been taught to build.

Their officers and leaders—And I learned that, even in this Chamber, for now, in the gallery, we have their assistant coach, who is with them. I know that they picked it together because listening to the names, they were not playing a game like it is for Ama, Serwaa, Hawa or Yakubu. They played it as a team; they fell, but they did not remain. They got up and picked it up, and did us proud.

I am continuing to hope and pray that, as the Minister has come to read this Statement, we will put our heads together, ensure that we also support them in our little way and that we will appreciate and will continue to forge ahead.

The technical team should not get discouraged and listen to the fact that others have been given more. After all, we are not the same types of countries; we are individual countries. If they got bronze today, there is nothing that can tell us that we will not be able to get gold one day. So, let us continue praying, working, urging forward and be determined, and ensure that one day, even if it is not them, they would have encouraged others to come up, and then we will get that gold medal.

3.33 p.m.

Mr Speaker, thank you very much for the opportunity and I would also like to thank the Minister and I say, well done to the team. [*Hear! Hear!*]

Ms Gloria Owusu (NPP — Trobu): Mr Speaker, I want to use this opportunity to congratulate the Black Queens of Ghana. They have made us proud and I am very happy that the Black Queens of the nation is here today. As a nation, we must support them. I hear the Nigerian President, President Tinubu, has congratulated the Super Falcons and donated money to them. I am encouraging our President, His Excellency John Dramani Mahama, to also encourage our Black Queens; they have really made us proud. *Ayekoo* to them.

Mr Speaker, I thank you for the opportunity. [*Hear! Hear!*]

Mr Emmanuel Kwasi Bedzrah (NDC — Ho West): Mr Speaker, I rise to associate myself with the Statement made by the Hon Minister for Sports and Recreation, Mr Kofi Iddie Adams. Let me commend our gallant Black Queens for doing us this great honour by lifting, at least, not all the trophies but the bronze trophy, after a decade of us being in the drought. When, as a country, we were thirsting for just one medal, even if it is sand that they can bring to Ghana, we did not see it. But, today, we are here celebrating them because they brought bronze to this country. [*Hear! Hear!*] God bless you.

Mr Speaker, this did not come on a silver platter. We must commend the Government of Ghana, especially His Excellency, for fulfilling all the obligations that needed to be fulfilled.

By giving the Black Queens, the team managers and all the people who needed to be supported what they needed for this great honour to come to this country, we must salute His Excellency the President for this great honour as well.

Mr Speaker, sports unite us as a nation. In fact, when one travels outside this country and they are asked where they come from, when they mention Ghana, the first thing they say is “Oh! that great football nation”. Indeed, Ghana is a great football nation. The likes of Abedi Pele, Mohammed Polo and all the many others who have done us this honour.

Mr Speaker, I have been told that during the tournament, these our young sisters received a lot of honours. Some were given the best player of the day and others, the best player of the tournament. This alone shows that we have a future for this nation.

Mr Speaker, having said that, when our sisters walked in, I was talking to a Colleague here and I asked, are they women or young girls? I see them as young ladies. That means that in the next few years, we will still have this team playing for us and I want to recommend to this House that we should have a fund. This House must also support them and give them something before they leave this place today. [*Hear! Hear!*]

Mr Speaker, instruct the Clerk to Parliament to do them the honours,

that this House has recognised them for playing and winning bronze for this nation.

With these few words, Mr Speaker, I thank you.

Mr Nana Agyei Baffour Awuah (NPP — Manhyia South): Mr Speaker, I want to join my Colleagues in commending our glorious Black Queens; they have done really well. They have brought joy and excitement to the nation. I say to them, *ayekoo!* Mr Speaker, while commending them, I would also want to commend the Minister for his contribution and for all the things he did to make this real, as well as the Government; we commend them.

Mr Speaker, it is important that going forward, we reduce the politics involved on such occasions. There is always the risk of people taking partisan lines the moment we bring in politics, which takes away the shine that this occasion brings. It is on this note that very respectfully, I would want the Minister to reconsider the Statement, particularly, where he said the feat is unprecedented. I do not mean to take away the feat chocked by these women. However, because this is a house of record, we need to make sure that the records are aligned.

Mr Speaker, in addition to the bronze, historically, the women have done so well to the extent that they have also won silver medals. In 1998, 2002 and 2006, they won a silver medal. Thus, it may seem that this feat

may then not be unprecedented. So, Mr Speaker, very respectfully, let the record reflect that this is not the first time such glory has come.

Mr Speaker, in conclusion, I am calling on the Minister—*[Uproar]*—

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, please, let us give him hearing. Please, I beg of you.

Mr Baffour Awuah: Mr Speaker, in conclusion, I am calling on the Minister to advert his mind to the Affirmative Action Act by ensuring that these glorious Black Queens have parity in terms of their earnings as much as what the Black Stars earn. We should also give them something closer. The Affirmative Action (Gender Equity) Act, 2024 which was passed by this House – luckily for us, the Minister is a Member of this House—We need to enforce it. The situation where the Black Stars earn so much money, while the women earn very little is unfair and breaches the spirit and letter of the Affirmative Action (Gender Equity) Act, 2024.

So, Hon Minister, very respectfully, the Black Stars are given huge bonuses; let us give our women huge bonuses for the group stage. *[Hear! Hear!]*—Mr Speaker, when the Black Stars qualify from the group stage to the second round, they are paid huge bonuses. In accordance with the Affirmative Action (Gender Equity) Act, 2024, let us give our women huge bonuses. *[Hear! Hear!]*—If the Black Stars had won even bronze—

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, please, wind up for me.

Mr Baffour Awuah: Mr Speaker, if the Black Stars had won even bronze, we would not just give them celebratory speeches in this House, we would have given them huge money. Let us ensure that the women are given huge money and houses, so that their lots are not made worse.

Thank you very much, Mr Speaker. *[Hear! Hear!]*

3.43 p.m.

Ms Lawrencia Dziwornu (NDC — Akuapem South): Thank you, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity to contribute to the Statement ably delivered by the Minister for Sports and Recreation. As the only standing female Member of the Committee on Youth and Sports—*[Hear! Hear!]*—I am with so much pride and immense joy for the Black Queens on achieving the bronze medal for our nation. The Black Queens demonstrated so much resilience, grit and determination at the WAFCON tournament and at every stage of their performance, they accelerated or advanced with their determination.

Mr Speaker, this is worthy of commendation. They have inspired a lot of young girls in our nation who dream of wearing the national jersey someday. Therefore, I add my voice to the many voices here to congratulate them on bringing at least the bronze medal to our country. I

dare say that our national women's team have performed better in recent times than their male counterparts and therefore they deserve all the support that they need to be able to advance in the next WAFCON tournament and bring the trophy to Ghana.

Mr Speaker, I am calling on the Minister for Sports and Recreation, our Committee, the Government and all other stakeholders to increase the budget allocated for women's football and prioritise their funding. This is because if we rightly invest in them, I believe in the next tournament, they will lift the cup and bring it home.

Mr Speaker, on this note, I congratulate the team on their great achievement. I congratulate the head coach, Kim Lars Björkegren, the deputy coach, the technical team and all the people who supported them in winning this medal for the nation. I say bravo to them. We are so proud of them. They should continue to do great exploits. We are believing that when the Black Queens represent us at the world stage, they will do excellent and bring glory to this nation. Congratulations to them once again. [*Hear! Hear!*]

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, it is unfortunate. We will take the last one from the former Minister for Youth and Sports, then I will come to Leadership.

Mr Mustapha Ussif (NPP — Yagaba-Kubori): Thank you so much, Mr Speaker. Let me thank my

successor, Hon Kofi Adams, for the Statement and also for bringing our Black Queens to this august House. Let me join the millions of Ghanaians who have sent congratulatory messages to our female national team, the Black Queens, for their remarkable performance in the Women's Africa Cup of Nations (WAFCON), 2025 in Morocco.

Mr Speaker, defeating the defending champions, South Africa, who brought the very best of all the players in the continent, to the third place in the tournament is a no mean achievement. The players, the technical team, the Ghana Football Association (GFA), led by my good friend, Mr Kurt Edwin Okraku, the Ministry led by the Minister, and all the directors there need to be commended for their wonderful work. Anytime there is coordination between the GFA, the Government and the corporate bodies, we see success. I want to urge corporate institutions to support not only the Black Stars but the Black Queens as well.

Mr Speaker, the Black Queens' performance in Morocco did not just happen by accident. It is as a result of many factors including meticulous planning by the GFA and also promotion of women's football. I have been fortunate to have worked very closely with the GFA and I know what they have put in in terms of promotion of women's football and I want to commend them for that.

Mr Speaker, the Government has also done her best. Government upon government have contributed by supporting women's football. Just last year, we all witnessed the Black Princesses being the champions of Africa in the African Games which was held here in Ghana. And most of the players here are products from the Black Princesses. Anytime players graduate from junior teams to the senior national teams and they play together, we chalk success. And I want to urge the GFA to keep graduating players from the junior national teams to the senior national teams so that they can be winning medals for our country.

Mr Speaker, we should not also forget that during COVID-19, for the first time H.E. Nana Addo Dankwa Akufo-Addo ensured that—*[Uproar]*—all women Premier League players were paid stipends and most of these players are beneficiaries of those stipends. Also, most of the women Premier Club games are played on the numerous AstroTurfs constructed by H.E. Nana Addo Dankwa Akufo-Addo and the result is the successes that we are talking. I would like to urge the Government to continue to make sure that the initiative of getting every district a befitting sports facility does not become a thing of the past. We should ensure that it is kept in place.

Thank you so much, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity. *[Hear! Hear!]*

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Thank you very much. Hon Members, I am now coming to Leadership and I will take two each from each Side. We would have a Lady at each Side, then I will come to the main Leaders.

So, let me start with Hon Patricia Appiagyei and come to Hon Comfort Doyoe and then the Leaders.

Deputy Minority Leader (Ms Patricia Appiagyei): Thank you very much, Mr Speaker, for this opportunity to congratulate our Black Queens for making us so proud. As I stand here, I must tell you, I feel very proud that commencing the tournament, I had to stand in and make a Statement, and create an awareness that the Black Queens need the support that is required for them to win this tournament. Unfortunately, they could not come with gold, but bronze is equally good. And I believe that if we pay more attention to the success of this particular team, there is always going to be an opportunity for them to bring us gold.

Mr Speaker, I would like to mention that I as an individual watched a number of their tournaments, and I felt so encouraged and felt that we have to indulge the entire Ghanaian team, especially the Ministry of Sports and Recreation to pay particular attention to the development of the Black Queens, because their performance was simply splendid. It was an issue of a national pride. It was an issue that we believe made our country and each

and every one in Ghana stand so tall to show that we are Ghanaians.

They are our ambassadors and I am appealing to the Ministry and to the Government that at their next tournament, it does not have to take us to come here and make an appeal before they are properly and carefully supported financially. We need to encourage them morally and spiritually. Every effort that is required to ensure the success story of the Black Queens is what we require at this point in time.

Mr Speaker, I believe that the gender equity issue is really at play here. I believe that with your support and the entire nation's support, we will be able to also showcase a female side of soccer which we can actually be so proud of. It is our intention to name all the players and give them personal commendation to ensure that these ladies of ours are well remunerated.

3.53 p.m.

I think each one deserves to be given some handsome amount of money to encourage them because it is done for the Black Stars. Why can we not do it? Whatever we have been doing for our Black Stars must be done for our queens and it is important.

Mr Speaker, I want to appeal that this is not an issue that we should show political colours. Whatever is being said here is to raise high the flag

of Ghana. You look on our tables and each one of us is having the flag of Ghana because we feel very proud where our Black Queens have taken us to. So, in every respect, I would like to say that it is important that we all come together, propose what is best for the promotion of the Queens to do far better than they have done but I would say, *ayekoo* to them, I do not even know what to say. They did very well; they made us proud and I was very happy watching them and I can look at the faces up there and tell them what each one did because I am a very good supporter of women's soccer and I am also a very good supporter of the national soccer.

With these few words, Mr Speaker, I would like to thank you for this opportunity and pray that, the Hon Minister do more for the Black Queens. Thank you very much and I would like to also commend our lady, Alice Kusi, from Manso Nkwanta Constituency and this is coming from her own Member of Parliament, Hon Fokuo, — [*Hear! Hear!*]— he has taken cognisance of her and what she has been able to do, and achieve. Congratulations to all of them. [*Hear! Hear!*]

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Thank you. Yes, let me now turn to Hon Comfort Doyoe.

First Deputy Majority Whip (Ms Comfort Doyoe Cudjoe): Thank you, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity to add my voice to the Statement made by the Minister for Sports and Recreation.

Mr Speaker, first of all, I would like to thank the Minister for Sports and Recreation for his dedication, commitment, and thank Hon Betty Crosby for also supporting our women because anytime she gets closer, she always speaks about them; how we should support them, and how we should run and look for people to come and support them to go higher.

Mr Speaker, my ladies in sports should look into my face —[*Hear! Hear!*]— I am telling them today, that they should not wait for anybody. Where they have reached, they should invest in themselves. Whatever they get today, they should invest it. Age is just a number. They should just believe in themselves and invest more to ensure they get higher and higher and higher — [*Hear! Hear!*]— They can make it. Today, they have made it to bronze, but with more effort, they will bring gold —[*Hear! Hear!*]— I will encourage them not to relax when it comes to training. They should not wait for their captain before they train. Anywhere they find themselves, in their bedrooms, in their washrooms, where they take their rest or train. They should continue training because before a woman can get higher, they have to work double or triple of what the men are doing before they are recognised. So, let me encourage them that the women of Ghana are proud of them — [*Hear! Hear!*]— We celebrate them today— [*Hear! Hear!*]— We cherish them— [*Hear! Hear!*]— and we thank them for making us proud — [*Hear!*

Hear!]— We are looking up to them as women and we are looking up to them for more victory. We want them to change the narrative. Make us proud. Our prayers are with them and we always remember them.

Our plea to the Confederation of African Football (CAF) and the Federation of International Football Association (FIFA) is that whatever they are doing for the men, they should do it for the women. We know that men get more opportunities than the women, so they should consider us and also put us in their good books and make sure whatever the men are benefiting, our ladies in sports should also benefit. Not in Ghana alone, but the whole world. We are calling CAF and then FIFA to make sure they open a good chapter for women to also be encouraged to do more. But despite all that, they should encourage themselves, feel proud of themselves, make sure they get to the top. They should make sure they get to the sky so that if they are falling, they fall on the tree but if they target the tree, they fall on the ground.

So, congratulations once again. I say *ayekoo* to all women who are supporting them. *Ayekoo* —[*Hear! Hear!*]

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Thank you very much. Let me now turn to the Minority Leader.

Minority Leader (Osahen Alexander Kwamena Afenyo-Markin): Mr Speaker, permit me to

stand on behalf of the Minority Caucus to also add a collective voice, in response to the Statement by our respected Colleague and Minister for the subject matter on this floor.

Mr Speaker, permit me to precede the comment with what we have by way of our national pledge:

“I promise on my honour to be faithful and loyal to Ghana, my motherland. I pledge myself to the service of Ghana with all my strength and with all my heart. I promise to hold in high esteem our heritage won for us through the blood and toil of our fathers and I pledge myself in all things to uphold and defend the good name of Ghana so help me God”.

Mr Speaker, our Black Queens lived up to this pledge and they deserve every commendation. Mr Speaker, since we started the Ninth Parliament, this is the first time that we are seeing our national flag being displayed in this Chamber and it is a sign that through football, we can come together as a nation. Mr Speaker, what they have done is commendable.

Let me again on behalf of the Caucus commend their coach. We saw on television how our young ladies celebrated him. Congratulations to the coach. The entire technical team, I say *ayekoo*. And the Ghana Football Association (GFA) led by its president, I say to him also, *ayekoo*.

4.03 p.m.

Mr Speaker, our Colleague who was nominated and approved for the sector, if things had gone bad, I am sure by this time his name would be out there with people calling for his head. My respected Colleague and Brother, Kofi Iddie Adams, congratulations. He has done well, and I wish him well.

Mr Speaker, it is important to state that this is a moment of shared national pride. This is not a partisan issue. This is the reason Hon Mustapha Ussif, who previously occupied that seat, had the opportunity to make a national statement in his own comments by saying that we do not have to make this a partisan matter. Some foundations were laid, and it is being continued.

Indeed, our ladies have demonstrated that they have the resilience of our country in them, and that is what made them excel. Mr Speaker, playing against a host team does not come easily, and they held their own with Morocco with a score of 1-1 until the penalty shoot-out.

Mr Speaker, again, I am aligning with the earlier submissions of our Friend and Colleague, Hon Vincent Ekow Assafuah, the Ranking Member for the Committee on Youth and Sports, some days back, when he called on all of us to do away with the partisanship and move with one voice to support our Queens. Mr Speaker,

many years ago, the Queens were training in Winneba, at the Winneba Sports College. And those were the days when the Black Queens had come to the limelight and were training and making our country proud.

Mr Speaker, sometimes, parents may not want their female children to get into football. But, today, everything is open. We should encourage them to move in that direction if indeed, that is their talent. I add my voice again on behalf of the Caucus to what our respected Colleague, Hon Comfort Doyoe Cudjoe, said that it is our hope that in future, they will not just come with anything less, but they will come with gold. There is every promise, and I think Hon Doyoe is right in saying that.

Mr Speaker, while at it, let me encourage our Minister to push for more sports infrastructure, and if he needs the support of this House, we are ever ready, at least on our Side. We are ready to provide the necessary support in terms of advocacy. All we can do is advocate to support him in sports infrastructure. We do not have to relegate women's sports to the background. Women in sports must be encouraged in all spheres, not only in football.

Mr Speaker, that said, the Minority Caucus often refers to itself as the mighty Minority. But on this occasion, it is clear that so far, we have been hearing words of

commendation, but the actual tangible cash support is yet to come. We are humble, but proud to say that we are the first to publicly acknowledge the industry of the Black Queens by donating GH¢100,000 cash to the Black Queens. *[Hear! Hear!]*

Mr Speaker, we are not pledging GH¢100,000. We are giving a cash support of GH¢100,000 now. And Deputy Minority Leader, being the senior woman among us, has been handed the cash to meet the team outside and hand it over to them, so that the media can capture it.

Mr Speaker, I thank you so much for giving us this opportunity.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Thank you so much.

Hon Members, silence, please. Let me now turn to—

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, the Minister asked for evidence. He is here. We do not just talk, we act. *[Hear! Hear!]* Mr Speaker, one, two, three, four and five. *[Uproar]*

[Minority Leader displays bundles of GH¢200 notes]

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, we want all our women to move out and hand over money to them.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: No, Hon Leader. Hold on, let us finish.

Let me now invite the Hon Deputy Majority Leader to give the concluding comment, please.

Deputy Majority Leader (Mr George Kweku Ricketts-Hagan): Thank you, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity to add my voice to what has been said.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, please.

[Some Minority Members chant: "Ricketts, do something before you die."]

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, please!

Mr Ricketts-Hagan: Thank you very much, Mr Speaker.

Mr Speaker, we are not dying yet. I would like to add my voice to what Minority Leader has just said and what others have said in terms of our sisters who have performed excellently in the 2024 Women's African Cup of Nations that just took place in Morocco and for bringing us back a medal, in this case a bronze. Today is a bronze. Tomorrow, we will know it is silver and then after, it will be the gold. It will eventually happen.

Mr Speaker, but it tells us what a country needs to do if that country is serious about sports. And it is about targeted investment in the areas of sports that we want to excel in. What the Black Queens have done is clear evidence that if we put in the targeted investment, we will get the results.

And that is what has been demonstrated today.

Mr Speaker, as we are saying, this is something that we all have to celebrate as a nation.

4.13 p.m.

I agree with the Minority Leader that sport is actually one thing that brings people together. It brings communities, countries and the world together and we must do more in this area to make sure that we excel in sports.

Mr Speaker, when we focused on women's football, we are beginning to see the result. There are other women disciplines that we need to look at this as an example and invest our moneys there. I want to thank the Minister for Sports and Recreation for the job that he has done so far and the results that we are getting. I would like to thank the team and all the people who worked with the Black Queens to make today possible in terms of us celebrating.

Mr Speaker, I was not sure, in one minute, whether I was in the Chamber of Commerce or Bank of Ghana—*[Laughter]*—We, on this Side, and the Government will continue to support the Black Queens and sports in this country to get us to a level that we should be. We congratulate our Black Queens and we will continue to engage them.

Mr Speaker, anything that anyone does or any group does is encouraging to support the Black Queens. Whether we do it here or you do it outside or you do it in their camp, it is all welcome. The most important thing, at the end of the day, is to come together to collectively improve sports in this country for all of us.

Mr Speaker, with these few words, I thank you.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, let me give the Minister one minute to wind up.

Mr K. I. Adams: Mr Speaker. I wish, on behalf of the Ministry, to thank this House for joining us to celebrate the Queens. Indeed, they have made a statement and that statement is important.

Mr Speaker, I want to announce even ahead of time before the Bill gets here that His Excellency the President, through Cabinet, has given approval for establishment of a sports fund and that Bill will be coming to the House very soon. I urge Members that when it comes, we should give it the necessary support and, possibly, even look for other sources that will make the fund stronger to be able to support the Queens, the Princesses and all others, so they can achieve a lot more. We wish to thank the Queens and the Queens are also thankful to all Hon Members for what they have done.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Thank you to all of you who made comments. I just want to add my voice to say congratulations to you, our ladies, for so gallantly preserving the image of Ghana outside the shores of our country. When I listened to the comments, most of them focused on how to support the women sports in general, not only football but all other sporting disciplines. So, I urge the Ministry to take special interest in the women's sports.

On that note, let me, respectfully, ask the gallant ladies to rise from my left-hand side at the Public Gallery for the cameras to capture them.

[The Black Queens and members of the technical team rose to be acknowledged]

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: They are at the Public Gallery and we are proud of them and we hope they would do more for Mother Ghana. So, on that note, let me also announce that they are here with their Executive Council (Exco) members, led by the president of the Ghana Football Association (GFA); I have seen him here, as well as Nana Sarfo Oduro. They are all here to lend support to the ladies. You are all welcome. So, you may resume your seat now. Probably, you may descend for Ms Patricia Appiagyei to present the gift of the Minority to you.

Hon Members, we also have, at the Public Gallery, Holuta Aflakpe D/A Basic School; they are 75 in number.

They are led by Maxwell Dagadu, who is the chief inspector of schools, and the school is located in the Ho West Constituency. So, you are welcome.

[Pupils of Holuta Aflakpe D/A Basic School were acknowledged]

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Again, we have Acherensua Senior High School (Achisco). They are led by Mr James Asamoah, who is a teacher, and the school is located in the Asutifi South Constituency. They are 67 in number.

[Students of Acherensua Senior High School were acknowledged]

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: The third school is Asante Gold Bibiani Limited Basic School. They are also led by William Baah Gyansah, who is the administrator of the school, and the school is located in the Bibiani-Anhwiaso-Bekwai Constituency. They are 57 in number.

[Pupils of Asante Gold Bibiani Limited Basic School were acknowledged]

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Then, the last school is Success Reform Institute. They are also led by Kwaku Boafo Amponsah, who is the headteacher, and the school is located in the New Juaben South Constituency.

I see the Member for New Juaben South here. Is the school also located in the north? Both Members of New

Juaben South and North are here, so, please, take care of them. You are all welcome; we wish you well and you may resume your seat now.

[Students of Success Reform Institute were acknowledged]

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: The Member of Parliament for Bibiani-Anhwiaso-Bekwai is here and I hope he will meet the pupils and take good care of them. He is here; he just got up on his feet.

Leadership, are we taking the Appointment Committee Report now?

Mr Ricketts-Hagan: Yes, Mr Speaker, we will go to the item numbered 10 at page 3 on the Order Paper.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, let me invite you to page 3 and take the item listed 10. Let me now invite the Chairman of the Appointments Committee.

MOTIONS

Suspension of Order 104(1)
Chairman of the Committee (Mr Benard Ahiafo): Mr Speaker, I beg to move:

That notwithstanding the provision of Order 104(1) of the Standing Orders which requires that a motion shall not be debated until at least two sitting days have elapsed after the notice to move the motion is given,

the motion for the adoption of the Sixteenth Report of the Appointments Committee on His Excellency the President's nominations for appointment as Deputy Ministers may be *moved* today.

First Deputy Minority Whip (Mr Habib Iddrisu): Mr Speaker, I second the Motion.

Question put and Motion agreed to.

Resolved accordingly.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: We move to Motion number 11. Yes, Chairman?

4.23 p.m.

MOTION

Sixteenth Report on the President's Nomination for Appointment as Deputy Ministers

Chairman of the Committee (Mr Bernard Ahiafor): Mr Speaker, I beg to *move*:

That this honourable House adopts the Sixteenth Report of the Appointments Committee on His Excellency the President's nomination for appointment as Deputy Ministers.

Mr Speaker, in doing so, I submit the Reports of the Committee.

Mr Speaker, I would urge the *Hansard* to capture the entire Report as having been read, as I indicate the conclusion and the recommendations to the House.

Introduction

On Wednesday, 9th July 2025, His Excellency, the President of the Republic, John Dramani Mahama, pursuant to Article 79(1) of the 1992 Constitution, formally notified Parliament of his nominations for appointment as Deputy Ministers. The nominees were as follows:

1. Ms Dorcas Toffey, MP, Deputy Minister-designate for the Ministry of Transport;
2. Mr James Gyakye Quayson, MP, Deputy Minister-designate for the Ministry of Foreign Affairs;
3. Mr Mohammed Adams Sukparu, MP, Deputy Minister-designate for the Ministry of Communication, Digital Technology and Innovations; and
4. Prof Grace Ayensu-Danquah, MP, Deputy Minister-designate for the Ministry of Health.

In accordance with Order 217 of the Standing Orders of Parliament, the Rt Hon Speaker subsequently referred these nominations to the Appointments Committee on 17th July 2025. The Committee was tasked to thoroughly consider the suitability and qualifications of the nominees and to report its findings to the House for further parliamentary action.

Reference Documents

In examining the nominations referred to it, the Committee relied on the following key documents:

1. The 1992 Constitution of the Republic of Ghana;
2. The Standing Orders of Parliament; and
3. Curriculum Vitae (CVs) submitted by the nominees.

Consideration of the Referral

Pursuant to Standing Order 217(10), the Committee ensured transparency and public participation by publishing the names of the nominees in the national newspapers. This allowed members of the general public to submit memoranda and express views regarding the suitability of the nominees. In addition, the Committee sought and reviewed Confidential Reports from the Ghana Police Service and the National Intelligence Bureau (NIB) to ascertain the nominees' backgrounds. Further, each nominee was required to provide tax status reports from the Ghana Revenue Authority (GRA).

On Friday, 25th July 2025, the Committee held a public hearing to formally deliberate on the nominations. Adhering to established parliamentary procedures, each nominee subscribed to the Oath of a Witness and subsequently responded to inquiries from Hon Members.

Questions posed to the nominees covered their professional and educational qualifications, competencies, suitability for public office, specific policy priorities, and matters of national significance relevant to their proposed ministerial portfolios.

Having carefully examined all submitted documents and responses provided by the nominees during the hearing, the Committee presents the following comprehensive report and recommendations.

Ms Dorcas Toffey
Deputy Minister-Designate,
Ministry of Transport

Background

Ms Dorcas Toffey was born on 4th May 1975 in Jomoro, Western Region, and hails from Bonyere in the Jomoro Municipality. She commenced her basic education at Ideal Preparatory School, Takoradi (1981–1986), before proceeding to Nkroful Agricultural College (1986–1991), where she earned her Ordinary Level Certificate. She holds a Certificate in Dental Hygiene (1997) from Medix School, Atlanta, Georgia, USA, a Certificate in Real Estate (2005) from Metro Brokers Academy, Atlanta, and a Diploma in Branding and Customer Service Management (2013) from Vision Consultancy Training, Atlanta. Further enhancing her credentials, she obtained a Certificate in Public Relations and Advertising Marketing (2019) and a Certificate in Public Speaking and

Communication (2020), both from Ghana Institute of Journalism, Accra. In the same year, she earned a Bachelor of Science in Marketing from Knutsford University, Accra. Her postgraduate education includes a Master of Business Administration (MBA) from Accra Business School, commenced in 2022, and a Master of Science (MSc) in Energy and Sustainability Management (2024) awarded jointly by Universidad Católica de Murcia (UCAM), Spain, and Regent University College, Ghana.

Ms Toffey has built an extensive and varied professional career. In 2002, she founded and mentored Kids Smile Inc. Day Care in Atlanta, Georgia. She subsequently served as Founder and Chief Executive Officer of Topeka Properties, Atlanta (2004–2013), worked as a Realtor at Metro Brokers, Atlanta (2005), and as a Real Estate Agent and Associate Broker with Strong Tower Realty, Atlanta (2007–2013). Upon returning to Ghana, she served as Chief Executive Officer and Country Representative at Nano Fix IT Solutions, Accra (2017–2021) and as Chief Executive Officer of Sebastian Closet, Accra (2018–2023).

Politically, Ms Toffey successfully contested the Jomoro Constituency parliamentary seat in 2020, subsequently serving as the Member of Parliament (MP) for the constituency. Within Parliament, she has been actively involved in oversight, legislative, and

representative roles, serving as a member on various committees including the Population Caucus, Committee on Gender, Children and Social Protection, Committee on Government Assurances, Committee on Trade and Industry, and Committee on Lands and Natural Resources. From July 2024 to January 2025, she held the position of Deputy Ranking Member of the Committee on Lands and Natural Resources.

Ms Toffey has been actively involved in international parliamentary conferences, workshops, and training programmes, notably attending the 10th Annual Athens Democracy Forum, Athens; the 12th Consultative Assembly of Parliamentarians on the International Criminal Court and Rule of Law (CAP-ICC) in Buenos Aires; and the First Ordinary Session of the National Assembly of Côte d'Ivoire, Abidjan.

She has received several recognitions and awards including the Special Recognition Award during the 30th Anniversary Celebration of Annor Adjaye Senior High School (2003); Outstanding Humanitarian Contribution Award from the National Association of Nzema Students-Ghana (2004); Champion of Development Award from Annor Adjaye Senior High School (2004); Outstanding Contribution Award from St Anthony Catholic Church, Tikobo No. 1 (2024); and Exceptional Contribution Award from the Jomoro Municipal Education Directorate (2024).

Beyond these honours, Ms Toffey has significantly contributed to community development, particularly in education, health, and infrastructure within the Jomoro Municipality. She facilitated the creation of accessible roads linking farming communities to markets and economically empowered over 4,000 women and youth through credit facilities and apprenticeship training. In 2018, she donated a brand-new ambulance to enhance emergency medical response and established scholarship programmes to support academically talented but financially challenged students in her constituency.

Ms Toffey is a Christian and a mother of three. She is proficient in English, Nzema, Fante, Twi, and French, and her interests include reading, singing, travelling, and volunteering.

Responses to Questions

Contributions to the Ministry

The nominee indicated her readiness to inject fresh energy and innovative ideas into the Ministry of Transport. She emphasised the need to enhance stakeholder engagement and improve accessibility for all segments of the population, reinforcing her commitment to making the transport sector more responsive to the needs of Ghanaians.

Promoting Gender Equity

The Deputy Minister-designate affirmed her strong commitment to

advancing gender equity within the Ministry of Transport, recognising the significant underrepresentation of women, particularly within port operations. She pledged her support for initiatives aimed at creating greater opportunities and advancing the roles of women in the transport sector.

Release of Seized Excavators

On the issue of the recent seizure of excavators, the nominee acknowledged the gravity of the situation and informed the Committee that the President had tasked three ministries to investigate and resolve the matter. She expressed confidence in the capacity of these ministries to conduct a thorough investigation and deliver an effective and satisfactory outcome.

Road Accident Prevention Strategies

The nominee presented comprehensive strategies aimed at addressing the alarming rate of road accidents in Ghana, noting that about 80 per cent of these incidents are attributable to human error. Her proposed solutions included improving emergency response systems, the installation of speed-monitoring cameras at strategic locations, and the strict enforcement of road traffic regulations. These targeted interventions would collectively reduce reckless driving and significantly improve road safety.

Adoption of Electric Buses

The Deputy Minister-designate underscored the vital role of electric buses in the future of Ghana's transportation system, highlighting their cost-effectiveness and positive environmental impact. She committed to actively supporting efforts to expand the fleet of electric buses and indicated her preparedness to collaborate closely with the substantive Minister to promote their adoption throughout the country.

The nominee was further asked if she believes the current number of electric vehicles in the country is sufficient to support the frequent transportation. She mentioned that out of the 100 electric vehicles that were ordered on procurement, only 10 were delivered, and out of those 10, only four are currently on the road; the rest six have various mechanical problems. She also noted that those issues were being resolved following successful contact with the supplying company.

The nominee further mentioned that there is the need to sensitise the public about the environmental benefit of using the electric vehicles, and also work with the Minister to identify other companies to procure more of the electric vehicles into the country.

Railway Sector Revitalisation

In addressing queries about recent industrial action in the railway sector

and delays in operationalising the Tema-Mpakadan railway line, the Deputy Minister-designate assured the Committee that operationalisation is imminent. She affirmed her commitment to proactively addressing the challenges facing the railway sector to ensure its efficiency and sustainable service delivery.

Addressing Encroachment on Transport Facilities

The nominee identified encroachment on transport facilities as primarily an administrative challenge. However, she assured the Committee of her full support and cooperation with the substantive Minister to tackle all encroachment issues decisively, thereby safeguarding the integrity and functionality of critical transport infrastructure.

High Port Charges

Acknowledging the considerable impact of high port charges and congestion on businesses and individuals, the Deputy Minister-designate committed to addressing these challenges. She assured the Committee that upon approval, she would closely collaborate with the substantive Minister to identify and implement practical strategies aimed at enhancing the efficiency and cost-effectiveness of port operations.

Enhancing the Road Traffic Act

Responding to concerns regarding the effectiveness of the current Road

Traffic Act, the nominee expressed readiness to work in tandem with the substantive Minister to introduce impactful measures. She emphasised her commitment to legislative and regulatory reforms designed to improve road safety and significantly reduce road traffic accidents.

Working Relationship

Addressing questions about her working style and interpersonal relationships, the nominee acknowledged perceptions that she might appear unapproachable or unfriendly. She clarified that these perceptions often arise from misunderstandings of her personality, describing herself as consistently affable, approachable, loving, and caring. She affirmed her dedication to maintaining cordial and constructive relationships with colleagues, subordinates, and constituents, thereby fostering a positive and collaborative working environment.

Road Safety Advocacy

On the question of promoting road safety advocacy among Members of Parliament, the Deputy Minister-designate strongly supported the proposal for parliamentarians to become active road safety ambassadors within their constituencies. She recognised the influential position held by Members of Parliament, noting their unique ability to educate constituents and promote a culture of safety and responsible behaviour on the roads.

Land Management and Encroachment

Given the nominee's prior experience as a former Deputy Ranking Member of the Committee on Lands and Natural Resources, the Committee raised concerns about her capacity to handle issues related to land management and encroachment. In response, she acknowledged these concerns as primarily administrative in nature. She assured the Committee that, upon approval, she would effectively leverage her expertise by working collaboratively with the substantive Minister to address and resolve these persistent challenges.

Financial Support to Women in the Constituency

Regarding her reported provision of financial assistance to approximately 4,000 women within her constituency, the nominee explained that she facilitated a loan guarantee arrangement through a banking institution, notably on an interest-free basis. This intervention significantly enhanced economic empowerment, providing essential financial assistance to these women to support their businesses and livelihoods.

The Issue of Citizenship

The nominee was questioned about matters relating to her previous dual citizenship status. She respectfully declined to elaborate further, indicating that the matter had already

been conclusively settled by the court. She expressed her preference not to revisit the issue, while expressing empathy and hoping that others would not have to endure a similar experience.

Waiving of Port Penalties for Older Vehicles

The Committee raised the issue of the need to control or waive port penalties imposed on the importation of older vehicles. The nominee acknowledged the importance and relevance of the issue. She committed to proposing suitable measures and discussing viable solutions, highlighting, however, that ultimate decisions would be taken in consultation with the substantive Minister and the President.

Construction of Railway Infrastructure

Asked about her plans regarding the development of railway infrastructure, specifically the construction of a railway line from Jomoro to Accra, the nominee responded affirmatively. She assured the Committee that upon approval, she would actively engage with private sector stakeholders to revitalise and expand the railway network, demonstrating her commitment to enhancing Ghana's transportation infrastructure.

Enforcing Weighbridge Restrictions

The Committee enquired about her intended approach to the enforcement of weighbridge restrictions, particularly concerning overloaded trucks. In response, the nominee affirmed her support for stringent enforcement and indicated she would actively collaborate with the substantive Minister on this issue. She also committed herself to personally obtaining first-hand insights through direct engagement, rather than issuing directives solely from the confines of an office.

Engaging More Women within the Public Transportation System

In response to questions about her commitment to increasing female representation within public transportation, specifically in driving roles, the nominee expressed unequivocal support. When asked about backing initiatives aimed at achieving a target of 30 per cent female recruitment in transportation roles and organisations, she affirmed her willingness, upon approval, to work closely and proactively with the substantive Minister to promote and realise this goal.

Inclusivity in Transport Policy

With reference to provisions for persons with disabilities in the Revised National Transport Policy, the nominee was asked how she intends to support the Minister in ensuring that transport policies

prioritise inclusivity and sustainability especially for the marginalised and vulnerable groups in rural communities. She acknowledged the concern and promised to work with the Minister, when approved, to look into the challenges and implement what policy will work best.

Recommendation

Having thoroughly reviewed the nominee's qualifications, professional experiences, and responses to the Committee's inquiries, the Committee, by **consensus**, respectfully recommends to the House the approval of **Ms Dorcas Toffey** for appointment as Deputy Minister for Transport.

Hon James Gyakyé Quayson
Deputy Minister-Designate for
Foreign Affairs

Background

Hon James Gyakyé Quayson was born on **9th October 1952** in Assin Fosu, Central Region, Ghana, and hails from Assin Bereku. He is a Christian, married, and blessed with six (6) children. The nominee is proficient in English, Fante, and Twi languages.

He commenced his primary education at **Penworth Preparatory School, Accra (1958)** before proceeding to **Mfantsipim Secondary School, Cape Coast**, where he successfully obtained his **Ordinary Level Certificate in 1969**. He subsequently earned a **General**

Education Teaching Diploma from Advanced Teachers Training College, Winneba. Further advancing his education abroad, he obtained a **Diploma in Instrumentation and Nuclear Engineering (1984)** from **George Brown College of Applied Arts and Technology, Canada**. Additionally, he earned a **Bachelor of Arts (BA) degree in Political Science and Sociology (1996)** from the **University of Toronto, Canada**, and a **Master's Degree in Urban Planning and Community Development (2002)** from **York University, Canada**.

Hon Quayson has extensive experience as a public servant and legislator, currently serving his second term as **Member of Parliament (MP) for Assin North**. He is an active member of the **National Democratic Congress (NDC)**, demonstrating over three decades of dedicated engagement with Ghanaian communities both domestically and abroad. His multidisciplinary academic background in **Instrumentation Engineering, Education, Political Science, Sociology, and Social Work**, complemented by his advanced degree in **Urban Planning and Community Development**, significantly enriches his suitability for diplomatic roles.

As a principled, people-centred leader, Hon Quayson has consistently demonstrated strong communication skills, policy insight, and a firm commitment to diplomacy, national unity, peace, and global engagement.

His substantial international exposure and broad professional network within political, economic, and social circles position him effectively to support the Minister for Foreign Affairs in promoting Ghana's national interests globally.

In Parliament, Hon Quayson has served diligently on multiple Committees in the 8th and 9th Parliaments, notably the **Committee on Local Government, Committee on Privileges, Committee on Security and Intelligence**, and the **Committee on Economy and Development**.

Throughout his career, he has actively participated in various conferences and training programmes aimed at enhancing his professional and diplomatic capabilities. Notably, he participated extensively in National Democratic Congress and diaspora-oriented conferences, gaining valuable networking opportunities and insights. Furthermore, his participation in **Settlement and Integration Workshops** in Canada, and the **Local Government Planning and Social Policy Forum** in Toronto, enriched his understanding of effective integration strategies, local governance, and social policy development.

Hon Quayson has received numerous recognitions for his exemplary service and leadership, including the **Ghanaian and Canadian Organisation for Community Service Award**, as well

as honours from the **Assinman Association** in recognition of his outstanding leadership and philanthropic contributions.

In his leisure time, Hon Quayson is actively involved in mentorship and community service, demonstrating his enduring commitment to societal advancement. He enjoys reading and is deeply passionate about public speaking, regularly using these avenues to engage in meaningful socio-political discourse.

Responses to Questions

Inspiration to Return Home and Serve His People

Hon Gyakyey Quayson attributed his motivation to return to Ghana and serve his community primarily to the profound influence of his late mother and the late President John Evans Atta Mills. He recounted a significant personal conversation with his mother in 2008, during his residence in Canada, in which she encouraged him to return home and dedicate himself to alleviating the suffering experienced by members of his community.

Specific Impact in Social Services

Highlighting his direct contributions towards improving public welfare, Hon Quayson emphasised his efforts in significantly addressing the electricity deficit in the Assin North Constituency following his election as Member of Parliament. He noted that he successfully spearheaded the

installation of approximately 2,500 streetlights across various communities within the constituency. This achievement was accomplished through a combination of personal resources and supplementary allocations provided by the Ministry of Energy to Members of Parliament.

Working Under a Younger Minister

When queried about potentially serving under a younger Minister, Hon Quayson responded diplomatically, acknowledging the cultural importance of respect for elders within African society. He affirmed the existence of a cordial and mutually respectful relationship with the substantive Minister. He further indicated his intention to sustain and enhance this collaborative dynamic, emphasising that the Minister's success would directly reflect his own success, underscoring their joint commitment to achieving the Ministry's goals.

Visa Fees Refund Policy

In response to concerns raised about the practice of non-refundable visa fees charged to Ghanaian applicants whose visa applications are rejected, the nominee agreed that this matter warrants critical review. He expressed reservations about the fairness of current administrative policies, indicating his concern that foreign embassies might be unduly profiting from African applicants. Hon Quayson committed to working

closely with the Minister to re-evaluate these policies, aiming to safeguard the interests and dignity of Ghanaian citizens seeking visas abroad.

Diaspora Engagement and Dual Citizenship

The nominee emphasised the importance of simplifying visa processes and actively reintegrating Ghanaians abroad, highlighting their substantial economic and intellectual contributions to the nation. Hon Quayson advocated for a thorough review of the existing Dual Citizenship Amendment Bill, pledging to work closely with the substantive Minister towards its refinement. He assured the Committee that facilitating visa applications for the Ghanaian diaspora would be among his priorities, enabling them to return home, invest, and meaningfully participate in Ghana's development.

Support for Deportees

Addressing concerns regarding the treatment of deported Ghanaian nationals, Hon Quayson proposed the establishment of dedicated support mechanisms within Ghanaian embassies, aimed at ensuring the safety, dignity, and effective reintegration of vulnerable deportees. He specifically highlighted critical areas such as New York, Toronto, and the United Kingdom, acknowledging the substantial challenges faced by Ghanaian citizens abroad. The nominee pledged to actively

collaborate with the substantive Minister to enhance support systems and ensure that the welfare of deported nationals is adequately protected.

Embassy Closures and Staff Reassignments

In response to inquiries about staff redeployment following the temporary closure of the Ghanaian Embassy in Washington DC, Hon Quayson acknowledged that he had not yet received detailed briefings on the situation. He assured the Committee that, if approved, he would urgently seek comprehensive briefings, follow up on the issue, and ensure that effective and clear policies are established to manage embassy closures, staff reassignments, and related diplomatic personnel matters efficiently.

Decentralisation of Passport Processing Services

On concerns about limited access to passport processing services, particularly in the northern regions of Ghana, the nominee outlined the Ministry's ongoing efforts towards decentralisation. He indicated that the Ministry plans to establish at least one passport application centre in each region, with additional centres allocated to densely populated areas. He further noted that improved courier services would be utilised to enhance passport delivery and minimise travel-related risks. Hon Quayson stressed that no Ghanaian should have to travel excessive

distances to obtain a passport, reaffirming the Ministry's commitment to addressing this critical public concern.

Advocacy for Dual Citizenship

Reiterating his strong advocacy for dual citizenship, Hon Quayson underscored its importance in maintaining diaspora engagement. He emphasised that dual citizenship facilitates continuous connections between Ghanaian nationals living abroad and their homeland, thereby significantly contributing to national development. He urged the creation of a supportive legal and administrative environment, enabling Ghanaians residing abroad to freely return, invest, and actively participate in national development efforts.

Combating Youth Migration through Sahel Routes

Hon Quayson agreed to coordinate closely with Ghanaian embassies in key African transit countries to proactively engage vulnerable Ghanaian youth abroad, aiming to discourage them from undertaking dangerous migration journeys through Sahel routes. He emphasised the importance of enhancing local communication campaigns to effectively inform young people about the risks and perils associated with illegal migration. Additionally, he stressed the necessity of creating viable local economic opportunities and alternatives to encourage the youth to thrive within Ghana's borders.

Independent View on LGBTQ+

When asked about his stance on LGBTQ+ issues, Hon Quayson articulated his independent perspective, firmly rooted in his cultural and religious convictions as an African. He expressed reservations regarding the LGBTQ+ movement, highlighting his concern about its potential negative impacts on societal norms and values. Despite residing in Canada during the legalisation of LGBTQ+ rights there, he emphasised that he never supported or endorsed the movement, instead prioritising and upholding the cultural and religious fabric of his community.

24 Hour Economy Policy and Initiatives

Regarding the implementation of the 24-hour economy policy at the Ministry of Foreign Affairs, Hon Quayson stated he had not yet been briefed on specific plans or initiatives in this area. However, he acknowledged the strategic importance of the Ministry in attracting investments and highlighted the necessity for aligning its operational strategies with Ghana's broader economic and foreign policy framework.

Infrastructure Development

On infrastructure development, Hon Quayson outlined his considerable contributions within his constituency, particularly in educational infrastructure.

He facilitated the construction of two new schools and undertook renovations of six existing schools. These projects were funded through a combination of the Common Fund, his personal resources, and support mobilised from family, friends, and the local District Assembly. Notable examples include school projects in the communities of Zambori and Abotari, demonstrating his strong commitment to improving educational facilities and outcomes.

Individual Empowerment Initiatives

The nominee highlighted his dedicated efforts towards individual empowerment within his constituency, particularly emphasising the economic empowerment of women. He successfully facilitated vocational training programmes benefiting over 200 women, providing them with essential equipment such as sewing machines and hair dryers to enhance their economic independence. Furthermore, he supported men by facilitating access to basic vocational skills training and assisted them in obtaining driving licences, significantly improving their employment opportunities and socio-economic standing.

Legacy of Parental Contribution

Hon Quayson attributed significant aspects of his political success and community engagement to the foundational contributions of his father in the Assin area. His father's legacy included constructing

secondary schools and training colleges, recruiting local citizens into the Police Service, and establishing police stations. Building on this foundation, Hon Quayson expressed a commitment to leveraging his position to facilitate greater recruitment opportunities for his constituents in security services, thus enhancing their economic stability and continuing his father's legacy.

Capacity Building in Diplomacy

Although acknowledging that he lacks formal diplomatic training, Hon Quayson expressed strong confidence in his ability to quickly adapt to diplomatic roles, drawing upon extensive leadership experience with African communities in Ontario, Canada, spanning over 12 years. He underscored that this substantial practical exposure has equipped him with critical skills, experience, and insights that would be highly beneficial to Ghana's diplomatic efforts. He assured the Committee that his unique blend of domestic and international experience would enable him to effectively support Ghana's diplomatic missions and objectives globally.

Challenges in the West African Sub-Region

The nominee was asked how he would support the Minister to address key challenges within the West African sub-region particularly within the ECOWAS framework to strengthen regional cooperation,

promoting peace and security and addressing cross border issues. He noted that Ghana has regardless of the Sahel break away has taken the role of initiating dialogue and diplomacy with the Sahel countries. He noted that as Deputy to the Minister, he will tow the policy line of the Government to ensure peace prevails within the sub-region.

Balancing Relationship with Global Powers

When asked whether he was aware of Ghana's non-aligned foreign policy, the nominee responded in the affirmative and added that it is the reason Ghana has not taken any side in any matter.

The nominee was further asked how he would support his Minister to ensure Ghana's foreign policy remains independent while maximizing benefits from partnerships with these powers, particularly in the area of trade and investment agreements. He mentioned that any attempt at this balancing act should be in line with executive policy which should be an inter-sectorial implementation. He explained that it has to be in line with Government's agenda and a collaboration of all sectors. He further noted that Ghana will remain non-aligned by not leaning on any side.

He promised to keenly follow the directives of the Ministry as it collaborates with the Executive to ensure that maximum benefit is achieved for the country without

jeopardising our relationship with other countries and the global powers.

Climate Change and Diplomacy

The nominee was asked what strategies he would support the Minister to pursue in order to position Ghana as a leader in environmental diplomacy, secure climate finance, and ensure that international partnerships address Ghana's specific climate vulnerabilities. The nominee stated that green energy is the way to go. He explained that Ghana should invest its resources in climate sustainability sectors such as electricity generation and transportation.

He added stressed the need to invest in green energy as it will help reduce if not eliminate the adverse effects of climate change such as diseases and natural disasters.

Fosu Immigration College as a Platform for Development

The nominee was asked whether he intends to leverage the Fosu Immigration College as a platform for development and was further requested to explain how he plans to address existing gaps within the institution to strengthen its connection with young people and enhance their empowerment. He responded in the affirmative and explained that he intends to not leverage only the Immigration College, but also, the Police Service, the National Fire Service and the Prison Service, to help youths in the

community since they seem to always be short changed.

Global Unilateralism and Ghana's Position

The nominee was asked to share with the Committee how Ghana is likely to be affected by the unilateral decision of some global powers, and what strategies he believed Ghana can adopt to provide economic empowerment and social services for its people. He emphasised that Ghana continues in the non-aligned policy which makes it stands strong in such situation. He added that Ghana needs to position its resources such that it can attract investors who would be ready to partner with Ghana and not interfere in its internal affairs. He explained that when Ghana is able to realign itself to add value to its raw materials, it will be able to create employment opportunities for its citizens and also sustain social services for its people.

Systemic Weaknesses Identified in Ghana's Polity

The nominee's opinion was sought on some key systemic weaknesses he has observed in the Ghanaian polity. The nominee noted that partisan politics is one of such weaknesses. He explained that many Ghanaians supports party agenda to the detriment of nationalism and added that Ghanaians must move away from such ideology and embrace nationalism.

He bemoaned the challenge of governments abandoning uncompleted projects of previous governments to commence new ones which is a loss to the country. He added these issues put a toll on the national purse.

He was further asked whether there is a need for collaboration to help change the mindset of the youth towards development. The nominee responded in the affirmative and alluded to the Resetting Agenda of the Government. He explained that the resetting should be a holistic one to include attitudinal resetting which will drive the nation towards development.

Boosting Investor Confidence

The nominee how he would persuade investors to consider investing in the country, particularly in the light of concerns over potential losses due to underlying challenges in the economy. The nominee stated that investor confidence is measured by the performance of the economy. He explained that a strong economic foundation would put the country in a better light. He alluded to the policies being implemented by the Government such as addressing the external debts, boosting confidence in the legal system, and strengthening administrative processes are some of the strategies being implemented to build investor confidence. He noted that he would assist his Minister to bring to fruition these strategies in order to bring more investors into the country.

Social Intervention Programmes by Past Government

The nominee's opinion was sought on whether the many social intervention programmes introduced by previous governments should be allowed to go to waste. He noted that social interventions are necessary for every society but to the extent that it becomes a major source of support for communities is a big challenge. He noted that the youth need to be empowered and opportunities provided them to wean them off and reduce pressure on these interventions and resources applied to other important sectors of the economy.

Recommendation

Having examined the nominee's qualifications, experiences, and responses to the Committee's inquiries, the Committee, **by consensus**, recommends to the House the **approval of Hon James Gyakye Quayson** for appointment as **Deputy Minister for Foreign Affairs**.

Hon Mohammed Adams Sukparu

Deputy Minister-Designate for Ministry of Communication, Digital Technology and Innovation

Background

Hon Mohammed Adams Sukparu was born on 6th January, 1985 in Bouti, in the Upper West Region of Ghana. His early education began at Sorbelle Primary School (1993–

1999), followed by Sorbelle Junior Secondary School (1999–2002), where he obtained his Basic Education Certificate Examination (BECE). He continued to Bolgatanga Technical Institute (2002–2005) for his senior secondary education.

He pursued higher education at the University of Professional Studies, Accra, where he earned a Diploma in Business Studies (2009–2010). From 2013 to 2015, he studied at Wisconsin International University, Accra, graduating with a Bachelor of Arts in Business Studies (Marketing). He later obtained a Master of Business Administration (MBA) in Corporate Governance (2018–2020) from the University of Professional Studies.

In Parliament, Hon Sukparu has served on several Committees across the 8th and 9th Parliaments, including as Deputy Ranking Member on the Judiciary Committee, and as a Member of the Works and Housing Committee, Public Accounts Committee, Committee on Land and Natural Resources, Committee on Lands and Forestry, and the Committee on Government Assurance.

Professionally, he brings a wealth of experience from the private sector. He served as Transport Senior Officer at DHL Global Forwarding, Accra (2006–2010). He is also the Founder and Managing Director of MAS Premium Limited (established in February 2009), and Wisode Freight Limited (founded in January 2011). He has served as Managing Director of Moh-Aariz Engineering Limited

since December 2015. He completed his National Service as a Project Officer at MAS Premium Limited (August 2019–September 2020).

Politically, the nominee has been an active figure within the National Democratic Congress. He has served as a member of the National Communication Team since 2021, contributing to the party's strategic messaging. He also played a key role on the National Youth Working Committee (2023–2024), and supported youth and student advocacy groups, particularly the Tertiary Institutions Network (TIEN), between 2012 and 2018. From 2012 to 2016, he served as a principal financier for political activities in the Sisala West Constituency.

His engagement in international fora includes participation in the Offshore Technology Conference in Houston, Texas (May 2025); the APNODE Annual Conferences in Benin (2024) and Morocco (2022); and the India Council for Cultural Relations (ICCR) Programme (2022), underscoring his exposure to global governance, innovation, and cultural exchange platforms.

In his personal life, Hon Sukparu enjoys playing football and watching documentaries.

Responses to Questions

High Cost of Data and Rapid Depletion

The nominee acknowledged persistent concerns over the high cost and rapid depletion of data bundles in

Ghana. He noted that despite recent price adjustments following engagements between the Minister and Telecommunication Operators, public dissatisfaction remains high. He informed the Committee that the Minister had directed the National Communications Authority (NCA) to undertake a comprehensive investigation into the matter. The nominee confirmed that the investigation is ongoing and that its findings would inform further ministerial decisions and policy actions.

Non-Operational Rural Telephony Sites

Responding to concerns about non-functional telecommunication sites under the Rural Telephony Project, the nominee expressed his firm commitment to supporting the substantive Minister in ensuring these sites are fully activated. He pledged to assist in achieving universal telephone connectivity in underserved and rural communities, emphasising its role in bridging the digital divide and promoting inclusive socio-economic development.

Enhancing Performance of AirtelTigo

On revitalising AirtelTigo to make it more competitive alongside MTN and Telecel, the nominee clarified that such interventions fall within the remit of government policy. He reiterated that his role, if approved, would be to support the Minister in the implementation of executive

directives, aimed at fostering a vibrant and competitive telecommunications landscape.

Strategy on Artificial Intelligence

In relation to Ghana's national strategy on Artificial Intelligence (AI), the nominee confirmed its existence and acknowledged its importance. He pledged to work closely with the Minister to review and strengthen the strategy to ensure it is fit for purpose. He further indicated that advancing AI in Ghana would require strong collaboration across government agencies, private sector stakeholders, and academic institutions, with the aim of positioning Ghana as a leading AI hub in Africa.

Poor Network Quality

On concerns regarding network instability and poor service quality, the nominee stated that the Minister had instructed the NCA to allocate additional spectrum to telecommunication operators. He assured the Committee that noticeable improvements in network quality and stability were expected by the end of the fourth quarter of the year, ultimately enhancing customer experience and public trust in the sector.

Vision for the Transformation of the Ministry

When asked how he intends to contribute to the transformation of the

Ministry, the nominee emphasised that he shares both the competencies and strategic vision of the sector Minister. He affirmed that his primary role, if approved, would be to support the Minister in implementing the President's transformational agenda, particularly in resetting key economic sectors such as telecommunications. His overarching goal, he noted, is to contribute meaningfully to national development and enhance the quality of life for all Ghanaians.

Delays in Operationalisation of 5G Network

Responding to concerns over delays in the rollout of the 5G network, despite the existence of a contractual agreement with an implementing partner, the nominee acknowledged the lag and noted that the entity is yet to commence operations. He referenced a press briefing by the Minister, which indicated that the failure to begin operations by the end of the year could result in the revocation of the contract or licence. The nominee assured the Committee that, if approved, he would thoroughly acquaint himself with the details of the agreement and provide the necessary support to address and resolve the matter.

Relationship with the Minister

When asked how he would manage a situation where the substantive Minister prefers limited delegation, the nominee noted that he enjoys a

long-standing professional relationship built on mutual trust and respect with the Minister. He expressed confidence in their ability to collaborate effectively, leveraging their combined experience and complementary strengths to advance the Ministry's objectives and deliver on the government's policy commitments.

Harnessing Nominee's Energy to Support the Ministry

On how he would channel his energy to support the Ministry's work, the nominee observed that the Communications sector is both vast and complex, demanding dedicated and capable leadership. He pledged to complement the Minister's efforts through his personal commitment, energy, and expertise, ensuring the successful execution of government policies aimed at advancing digital inclusion and driving socio-economic transformation.

Bridging the Internet Access Gap

In response to concerns about the internet access gap affecting over four million Ghanaians, the nominee highlighted the ongoing Rural Telephony Project spearheaded by the Ministry. He indicated that approximately 2,016 sites are at various stages of development, and committed to supporting the Minister to ensure the project's effective implementation. He underscored that the initiative is critical to bridging the digital divide and ensuring equitable

access to communication services across the country.

Promoting ICT in Northern Communities

The nominee placed strong emphasis on expanding ICT access in northern Ghana, stressing the pivotal role of the Ghana Investment Fund for Electronic Communications (GIFEC) in this regard. He noted that, under the directive of the Minister, GIFEC is conducting a nationwide assessment to identify schools and communities without ICT resources. This effort aims to enable the targeted distribution of digital tools to promote digital literacy, innovation, and entrepreneurship in underserved areas.

Support for National Roaming Initiative

On the subject of national roaming, particularly within the ECOWAS sub-region, the nominee praised the initiative as a progressive step toward seamless cross-border communication. He committed to supporting the substantive Minister in continuing its implementation, citing the significant economic and social benefits such a policy would bring to individuals, businesses, and regional integration.

Tackling Online Impersonation

Addressing concerns over the online impersonation of public figures, including Members of Parliament, the nominee stated that

the Cyber Security Authority is currently collaborating with digital platforms to identify and eliminate fake accounts. He noted that the Authority is reaching out to public officials to verify their official online accounts, a move intended to reduce impersonation cases and protect the reputation and integrity of public officeholders.

Extending Telecommunications to Underserved Areas

The nominee underscored the urgent need to expand telecommunications infrastructure to underserved and rural areas, noting that approximately 70 per cent of rural dwellers still lack access to reliable telecom services. He reaffirmed that GIFEC has the mandate to improve rural connectivity and pledged, if approved, to support the Rural Telephony Project to achieve universal access and promote inclusive socio-economic development.

Strengthening GIFEC's Mandate

Responding to concerns about the limited legislative scope of GIFEC's parent Act, the nominee acknowledged an ongoing effort to strengthen and reposition GIFEC as a driver of Ghana's digital transformation. He indicated that a new bill is currently being drafted and reviewed to expand GIFEC's mandate to include the broader digital economy. He pledged to support the Minister in fast-tracking the bill's submission to Parliament, recognising its potential

to significantly enhance the effectiveness of digital policy implementation.

Clarification on Nominee's Employment History

In response to questions regarding compliance with parliamentary standing orders on holding offices of profit, the nominee confirmed that he had previously held leadership positions in Moh-Aariz Engineering Limited, MAS Premium Limited, and Wisode Freight Limited. He clarified that he had obtained approval from the Eighth Parliament to retain these roles while serving as a legislator. For the Ninth Parliament, he has formally reapplied for clearance, has stepped down as Managing Director, and currently serves only as a shareholder, in compliance with parliamentary rules.

Bridging the Digital Divide Between Urban and Rural Communities

The nominee acknowledged the stark digital disparity between urban and rural communities in Ghana, where only 34per cent of rural households have internet access compared to 68per cent in urban centres. He reaffirmed his commitment to supporting the President's digital policy agenda, which is focused on bridging this divide through inclusive and problem-solving digital initiatives. He emphasised the strategic importance of this agenda in promoting national development and

improving the livelihoods of Ghanaians in all regions.

Scaling Up Digital Skills Across the Workforce (Coding Programme)

On the issue of low digital literacy, the nominee stated that the Ministry is already implementing a policy to train one million Ghanaian youth in basic digital skills. He pledged to support the Minister in ensuring the full and effective implementation of this initiative, especially for young people and women. He expressed confidence that this intervention would play a significant role in enhancing employability, boosting productivity, and preparing the workforce for a digitally-driven economy.

Recommendation

Having duly examined the nominee's qualifications, professional experience, and responses to the Committee's enquiries, the Committee, **by consensus**, recommends to the House the approval of **Hon Mohammed Adams Sukparu** for appointment as **Deputy Minister for Communication, Digital Technology and Innovations**.

Prof Dr Grace Ayensu-Danquah Deputy Minister-Designate for Health

Background

Dr Grace Ayensu-Danquah was born on 10th May 1967 in Essikado, in the Western Region of Ghana. She

began her basic education at Chapel Hill Preparatory School (1974–1980), continued at Holy Child School, Cape Coast (1981–1984), and completed her Ordinary and Advanced Level Certificates at Archbishop Porter Girls' Secondary School, Takoradi (1984–1986).

Her tertiary education and professional career were largely based in the United States of America, where she pursued advanced studies in health and medical sciences. From 1988 to 1990, she studied Operating Accounting at Pace University, New York, and later pursued a Bachelor of Science in Biological Sciences (with a minor in Religion) at the University of Southern California (1992–1995). She subsequently earned her Doctor of Medicine (M.D.) from the University of Wisconsin (1995–1999) and completed a Master's in Public Health (MPH) at Johns Hopkins University in 2000.

Dr Ayensu-Danquah is a board-certified surgical specialist, having obtained certification from the American Board of Surgery (2009) and the American College of Surgeons (2010)—both of which she continues to maintain.

Her early professional experience in Ghana began with national service at Job 600 (1986–1987) and as a Community Health Care Assistant (1987–1988), promoting healthcare in rural Ghana. In the United States, she worked in various medical roles, including Patient Care Technician at

St. Jude's Medical Center (1992–1995) and Laboratory Assistant at the Los Angeles County Museum of Natural History (1993). She completed her Post-Graduate Year 1 internship at USC Medical Center (2001–2002) and underwent specialist surgical training at Providence Hospital, Michigan.

In 2004, she established the Healing Hands Foundation, a non-profit humanitarian organisation that undertakes global medical missions to underserved populations. Since 2006, she has practised as a humanitarian surgeon, providing surgical care to communities lacking access. She also completed a Burn and Reconstruction Fellowship (2006–2007) at UC San Diego Medical Center and served as a surgical specialist at both Barstow Community Hospital (2007–2010) and Anne Arundel Medical Center (2010–2011).

From 2015 to 2024, she served as a Member of the Technical Advisory Committee on Vaccines and Biological Products at the Food and Drugs Authority (FDA), Ghana. She has also contributed to academia, serving as a Professor of Surgery at the University of Utah's Center for Global Surgery and at Ensign Global College (since 2019), as well as Adjunct Professor of Surgery at Cape Coast University Hospital. In 2021, she founded the Sage Medical Centre, a specialist hemodialysis and surgical facility in Accra. Between 2023 and 2024, she served as Country Director for Project HOPE and USAID Ghana.

She was elected to Parliament in 2024, representing the Essikado-Ketan Constituency in the Ninth Parliament of the Fourth Republic.

Her research portfolio includes studies on malaria eradication in West Africa, the impact of internet use on surgical outcomes, and investigations into HIV/AIDS transmission, prostate cancer prevalence in Sub-Saharan Africa, and other major public health concerns.

She has participated in several international conferences, including the 39th Annual Meeting of the American Burn Association (2007) and the American College of Surgeons Clinical Congress (2011, 2016, and 2023). She also participated in the Sirleaf Johnson Amujae High-Level Leadership Forum in Kenya (2023) and Rwanda (2024).

Dr Ayensu-Danquah holds certifications in Basic Life Support (BLS), Advanced Cardiac Life Support (ACLS), Advanced Trauma Life Support (ATLS), and Burn Life Support. She is licensed to practise medicine in both California and Maryland (USA) and holds generalist and specialist licenses from the Ghana Medical and Dental Council.

She is affiliated with several professional organisations, including the American College of Surgeons, International College of Surgeons, Ghana College of Physicians and Surgeons, Women in Surgery, and the California Surgical Association. She

also holds memberships with the American Burn Association, American Medical Association, Detroit Surgical Association, Washington DC Area Surgical Association, and Orphan Medical Network International, and is an alumna of the Johns Hopkins School of Public Health.

Hon Ayensu-Danquah is married with children and enjoys volunteering, travelling, and dancing.

Responses to Questions

Key Measures in Reducing Maternal Mortality

The nominee affirmed her strong commitment to working with the Minister for Health to identify and implement effective strategies to reduce maternal mortality across Ghana. She emphasised the importance of beginning with Community-based Health Planning and Services (CHPS) Compounds, while also advocating for a multi-faceted approach that addresses systemic causes of maternal deaths and improves access to quality healthcare services at the community level.

Addressing the Shortage of Doctors, Nurses, and Midwives

In response to the shortage of health professionals, particularly in underserved regions, the nominee commended the resilience and dedication of Ghana's health

workforce, who continue to serve under challenging conditions. She informed the Committee that the Minister for Health had already facilitated the return of approximately 10,000 doctors and was in the process of engaging more nurses and allied health professionals. The nominee pledged her support to ensure the deployment of additional medical personnel and facilitate the absorption of unemployed nurses, thereby strengthening healthcare delivery nationwide.

NHIS and Public Perception of Value

When asked how she would address the public's reluctance to register for the National Health Insurance Scheme (NHIS), the nominee highlighted the MahamaCares policy, which provides supplementary funding for financially vulnerable individuals. She stressed the urgency of encouraging wider enrolment, especially in light of data indicating that 40–43 per cent of Ghanaians die from chronic diseases. According to her, registering under the NHIS is critical for ensuring access to timely and affordable care for chronic and non-communicable diseases.

Tackling Unemployment Among Health Workers

Addressing the issue of unemployed health workers, the nominee cited Ministry figures showing that over 15,000 healthcare

professionals had been employed in the preceding six months. She also drew attention to ongoing efforts to upgrade diploma nurses to degree level, thereby enhancing their competencies and employability. The nominee stressed the importance of continuous professional development and capacity-building initiatives to ensure a robust and responsive healthcare workforce.

Expanding NHIA vs Introducing a Medical Trust Fund

In response to concerns that the NHIA could have been strengthened rather than introducing a new Medical Trust Fund, the nominee clarified that the proposed fund is not a replacement but a complementary scheme. She explained that the Trust Fund is designed to provide financial support for patients with chronic illnesses that require expensive, long-term care. Using cancer patients as an example, she explained that while the NHIA would cover basic care, the Medical Trust Fund would absorb the additional cost burden. She described the initiative as a game-changer and a life-saving policy that would be widely welcomed by the Ghanaian populace.

Utilisation of Experience to Address Challenges in the Health Sector

The nominee underscored her extensive expertise in health education, clinical medicine, and surgical care, which she pledged to

leverage in support of the Minister for Health. She stressed the importance of collaborative problem-solving and teamwork in addressing the multifaceted challenges within Ghana's health sector, noting that technical competence must be coupled with strategic leadership to yield effective and sustainable outcomes.

Labour Unrest and Its Prevention

On the matter of recent labour unrest, particularly among nursing professionals, the nominee acknowledged the seriousness of the issue and indicated that the Minister has already initiated efforts to resolve the impasse. She noted that some concessions have been granted, and a significant number of nurses have already been processed for remuneration and placement. The nominee emphasised that going forward, effective communication and structured negotiation mechanisms will be critical in preventing similar disputes and maintaining industrial harmony within the health sector.

Attaining a High Level of Education in America

In response to questions about her impressive academic achievements in the United States, Dr Ayensu-Danquah attributed her success to discipline, dedication, and sacrifice, including the willingness to forgo comfort in pursuit of long-term goals. She highlighted the formative role of her upbringing and commitment to

excellence, underscoring the importance of prioritising education as a foundation for national development.

Challenges in Healthcare Accessibility

Addressing the issue of healthcare accessibility, particularly in the Western Region, the nominee described it as one of the most pressing challenges in Ghana's health system. She commended the government's introduction of free basic healthcare policy, which she believes will significantly enhance access. She further advocated for the equipping of CHPS Compounds and rural health centres with appropriate preventive and protective services to decongest referral hospitals. She noted that building health facilities alone is insufficient unless they are complemented by qualified personnel and quality services.

Shortening Turnaround Times of Diagnostics in Public Health Facilities

Responding to concerns over delays in diagnostic results in public health facilities, as compared to the private sector, the nominee attributed the disparity primarily to ineffective management practices. She stressed that clinical expertise alone does not equate to managerial competence, and called for the deployment of professional health administrators in public facilities. Furthermore, she advocated for the training of biochemical engineers and the

extension of equipment warranty periods to ensure faster diagnostic processes and timely replacement of faulty devices.

Measures to Support Women with Fistula After Birth

Drawing from her own medical experience, the nominee narrated her involvement in addressing postpartum fistula since 2012. She pledged to collaborate with the Minister to mobilise qualified surgeons to provide free corrective surgeries for affected women. She noted that while fistula repair is not inherently complex, it demands specialised techniques and dedicated expertise, and assured the Committee of her commitment to expanding access to this vital intervention for vulnerable women.

Medical Negligence and Standards

Professor Ayensu-Danquah acknowledged that medical negligence remains a significant challenge within Ghana's healthcare system. She emphasised the need to improve the foundation of medical training, particularly in the early exposure to core sciences such as anatomy and biochemistry. The nominee advocated for a restructured approach to pre-medical and pre-clinical education, and expressed optimism that the establishment of a biomedical engineering school at the University of Ghana would play a key role in enhancing quality and standards in the sector.

Telemedicine and Mobile Clinics

On the issue of healthcare accessibility, the nominee highlighted the importance of bringing healthcare services closer to the people. She referenced the mobile clinic initiative introduced during President John Mahama's first term, suggesting that these units be enhanced with telemedicine infrastructure to support remote diagnostics and consultations. She stressed that telemedicine should be integrated into mobile medical units rather than treated as a stand-alone platform.

Professional Practice and Ethics

Responding to questions about her professional affiliations, the nominee clarified that her work with various institutions in Ghana has been primarily pro bono, motivated by a humanitarian commitment to strengthening the national health system. She confirmed her registration status with the Ghana Medical and Dental Council, including her license number and payment of all relevant dues. She also explained that her academic title of "Professor" was legitimately conferred under the United States academic system, based on qualifications, scholarly publications, and teaching experience.

Ambulance Service and Health Insurance Funding

Regarding the state of ambulance services in rural areas, the nominee

acknowledged the urgent need for improvement. She expressed reservations about the National Health Insurance Scheme (NHIS) directly funding ambulance services, noting that ambulance operations require a distinct and sustainable funding model. She committed to working with the Minister to examine the existing funding mechanisms, with the goal of ensuring an efficient and well-resourced emergency response system.

High and Low Moments in Parliament

In reflecting on her parliamentary experience, Hon Ayensu-Danquah noted that her high moments included participating in the legislative process, particularly the passage of bills. She reported having experienced no low moments during her six-month tenure in Parliament and stated that she had not encountered any discomfort or intimidation from minority members.

Verification of Content on Social Media

The Committee sought clarification on the origin of a particular social media publication. The nominee responded that she could not verify its authenticity without supporting evidence. She further indicated that her official Facebook account is “metaverified”, unlike the account associated with the questionable content.

Earning of Professor Title

The nominee confirmed that she is a Professor of Surgery at the University of Utah, having fulfilled the academic requirements of defending two theses and publishing extensively. She clarified that the conferment of the professorial title is based on a combination of qualifications, scholarly output, and teaching record, reflecting her longstanding commitment to academic excellence and medical education.

Transition from the United States to Ghana's Medical Field

Describing her transition from the U.S. medical system to Ghana, the nominee explained that she undertook a written examination and an oral examination administered by three senior Ghanaian surgeons. She also participated in an ethics class as part of the licensing process and was officially conferred with generalist and specialist licenses by the Ghana Medical and Dental Council on 27th January 2014.

Payment of Taxes from All Companies Owned

The nominee confirmed that she is fully compliant with tax obligations, and holds a clearance certificate from the Ghana Revenue Authority (GRA). She also clarified that although she owns several companies, including Sage Medical Centre, she has never drawn remuneration from them. She

reiterated that her involvement in these enterprises is primarily charitable and service-oriented.

Medicine as a Passionate Field

Dr Ayensu-Danquah affirmed that medicine is her true passion, despite her earlier academic foundation in the arts and humanities. She reiterated her unwavering commitment to the health sector and expressed a strong desire to contribute meaningfully to Ghana's healthcare system. She highlighted her extensive clinical, academic, and humanitarian experience as evidence of her dedication to improving health outcomes for all Ghanaians.

Moral Behaviour during Second Cycle Education

Responding to claims alleging inconsiderate or disrespectful conduct during her time at Archbishop Porter Girls' Secondary School, the nominee strongly refuted the assertions. She noted that she served as the Entertainment Prefect, a leadership role typically entrusted to students of good conduct and sound character. She described herself as respectful, composed, and intelligent, and emphasised that her record and reputation reflect these attributes.

Balancing Technical Guidance with Ministerial Adherence

The nominee acknowledged the importance of providing technical expertise and guidance in health policymaking. At the same time, she

emphasised her respect for ministerial hierarchy and her readiness to work in harmony with the Minister for Health. She assured the Committee of her commitment to aligning her technical contributions with the government's broader policy agenda to ensure seamless execution of health interventions.

Interventions to Transform Maternal Mortality Outcomes

Hon Ayensu-Danquah highlighted the urgent need to implement comprehensive and targeted interventions to reduce maternal mortality, especially through early identification of high-risk women. She stressed the role of Free Primary Health Care and the Ghana Medical Trust Fund (Mahama Care) in alleviating financial barriers to care. According to her, the Trust Fund is central to improving health outcomes and reducing preventable maternal deaths across the country.

Advocate for Prevention, Emergency Response, and Rehabilitation

The nominee stressed the importance of a robust emergency response system, which must include well-trained personnel and properly equipped facilities. She underscored the value of preventive healthcare, not just as a cost-effective strategy, but also as a means of reducing the burden of emergencies. Additionally, she advocated for stronger rehabilitation services, ensuring that patients receive comprehensive post-

emergency support to recover fully and reintegrate into society.

Combating Infectious Disease

Recognising the persistent threat of infectious diseases, the nominee called for a multi-faceted national strategy to prevent their spread. She proposed enhancing surveillance systems, improving inter-agency collaboration, and expanding community education and vaccination programmes. She also emphasised the importance of public trust and participation in achieving successful disease control and prevention.

Addressing Inefficiencies in NHIS Policy

The nominee acknowledged that despite various reforms, the National Health Insurance Scheme (NHIS) still faces coverage and delivery challenges. She reaffirmed her commitment to supporting the Minister in reforming and expanding the scheme, particularly through the integration of the Ghana Medical Trust Fund, which she believes will bridge service gaps and improve access to healthcare for all citizens.

View on Integrated Disease Surveillance

The nominee was asked how she intends to leverage her training in an integrated healthcare system to implement a similar system in Ghana. She endorsed the implementation of integrated disease surveillance

systems as an essential public health strategy. She emphasised the need for improved data collection, inter-sectoral coordination, and rapid response mechanisms. By strengthening these systems, she believes Ghana can significantly enhance early detection and containment of outbreaks, thereby safeguarding national health security.

Gender Parity in Combating Tuberculosis

The nominee acknowledged the significant impact of tuberculosis (TB) on women, particularly in terms of stigma and access to care. She emphasised the need for targeted interventions to support women affected by TB, including community outreach and education. The nominee highlighted that the free primary health care program aims to identify and support high-risk women in communities, addressing their specific health needs. She stressed that this program will facilitate access to essential health services, reducing barriers faced by women in rural areas.

Recommendation

Upon thorough examination of the nominee's qualifications, extensive professional experience, and responses to the Committee's inquiries, the Committee, **by consensus**, recommends to the House the approval of **Dr Grace Ayensu-Danquah** for appointment as **Deputy Minister for Health**.

Conclusion and Recommendation

In accordance with Article 79(1) of the 1992 Constitution and Order 217 of the Standing Orders of Parliament, the Committee duly considered the nominations submitted by His Excellency the President. Following a thorough evaluation of the nominees' qualifications, professional experiences, and responses to questions, the Committee finds that each of the nominees has demonstrated competence, insight, and readiness to assume their respective roles.

The Committee, therefore, by **consensus**, recommends to the House the **adoption** of its report and the **approval** of the following nominees for appointment as Deputy Ministers:

- i. **Ms Dorcas Toffey** – Deputy Minister for the **Ministry of Transport**;
- ii. **Mr James Gyakye Quayson** – Deputy Minister for the **Ministry of Foreign Affairs**;
- iii. **Mr Mohammed Adams Sukparu** – Deputy Minister for the **Ministry of Communication, Digital Technology and Innovations**; and
- iv. **Prof Dr Grace Ayensu-Danquah** – Deputy Minister for the **Ministry of Health**.

Respectfully submitted.

Mr Speaker, we urge the House to unanimously approve these nominations.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, the Motion has been moved; let me invite the Hon First Deputy Minority Whip to second the Motion.

First Deputy Minority Whip (Alhaji Habib Iddrisu): Thank you, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity to second the Motion.

The Chairman of the Appointments Committee, who is also the First Deputy Speaker, has highlighted a lot of work that the Committee did. The Committee received *curricula vitae* (CVs) from the four Nominees. The Committee went through the constitutional requirements in vetting them to ascertain whether they are qualified to be Deputy Ministers of the various Ministries they have been designated for.

Mr Speaker, even in being the President of the Republic, the Constitution has made it clear; the benchmark is being a Member of Parliament. All the four Nominees are Members of Parliament: Ms Dorcas Toffey, the Deputy Minister-designate for the Ministry of Transport, is a second-term Member of Parliament; Mr James Gyakye Quayson, the Deputy Minister-designate for the Ministry of Foreign Affairs, is also a second-term Member of Parliament; Mr Mohammed

Adams Sukparu, the Deputy Minister-designate for Communication, Digital Technology and Innovations, is also a second-term Member of Parliament, and Prof Dr Grace Ayensu-Danquah, I think is a first-term Member of Parliament of this House.

Mr Speaker, as the Chairman presented, this Report is by consensus. The Minority will not in any way stand against the President constituting its Government. It is long overdue. We all know what went through the mind of the President of the Republic, H. E. John Dramani Mahama, and it took him more than months to bring these four names to be able to make up the 60 Ministers that he promised.

The President promised Ghanaians that he would give us 60 Ministers and Deputy Ministers. Today is 29th July, which is more than half of the year into his Administration and yet, the 60 Ministers are not in place. Now that this House will approve these appointments, I think it will go to complement and make another—What we will hear is that another campaign promise has been fulfilled, but it is long overdue, Mr Speaker.

Mr Speaker, I think the Appointments Committee did a thorough work. At the end of the day, we have heard conflicting Reports about some of the titles of some of the Nominees on the Report, even though Parliament has not been officially informed. I think that next time, the

Appointments Committee should do more to be able to ascertain the title.

Mr Speaker, sometimes one says, I am a professor or a doctor or a lawyer, but if you look at the Constitution very well, the benchmark in being a Minister of State is being a Member of Parliament. And what is the requirement in being a Member of Parliament? So, sometimes the big titles we attach to our names, is not what we actually have to. If one does not have a title, they do not need to force it. What one can deliver on their work and mandate is what matters. The titles are not really important.

Mr Speaker, now, some fake titles are too many in the system and for that matter, we need to look at it properly, so that when we are addressing people, we would address them very well.

Mr Speaker, we have a lot of people: the First Deputy Speaker is a lawyer; he has never said that he is a Professor of Law or a Doctor of Law. He is a lawyer and he is doing that very well. The able Leader of the 87th Infantry Battalion, the mighty Minority, Osahen, is a lawyer of good standing and that we know. But, sometimes, when one has not attained a title—From my little understanding, in academia, professorship is a promotion from PhD.

Professor is just a promotion from PhD. If one is not and they are still in an acting capacity or an acting professor, it is not a problem. So, Mr

Speaker, what I am saying is that because there are reports—We heard how they went through—Many of them were questioned about their academic portfolio and at the end of the day, we are heard universities issuing things and other things.

4.33 p.m.

Yes, we all agree that we are approving the four nominees, but I am encouraging and appealing to Members of Parliament and other Civil Society Organisations that title is not what matters.

Mr Speaker, one might be a professor in health, but when we come on the floor of Parliament and we are talking about health matters, it is not the professorship that the person puts in there. It is how the person understands things that the person will use. Mr Speaker, one might be a professor of agriculture or education, but we are not always going to be talking about education on the floor of Parliament. So, the fake titles are too many now in the system, Mr Speaker.

Mr Speaker, I will urge the House to approve the President's nominees: the Deputy Minister-designate for Transport, Ms Dorcas Toffey; the Deputy Minister-designate for Foreign Affairs, and the Deputy Minister-designate for Communication, Digital Technology and Innovations.

Mr Speaker, these fake titles in the system are as a result of some people wanting to imbibe the New Patriotic

Party (NPP) because we are professionals; we are academics and we know the birth of their party. So, they do not have to always try to steal titles when the need does not arise. So, Mr Speaker, I rise to second the Motion and I urge the House to approve the President's nominees of the Deputy Ministerial portfolios. Thank you, Mr Speaker.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, let us be tolerant. If somebody says something that is not good, I will be on point to ask the person to withdraw. Please, let us be tolerant.

Question proposed.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Leadership, how many do you think we can take?

Mr Ricketts-Hagan Mr Speaker, two from each Side is my suggestion. Or again, I will go with the Second Deputy Minority Whip to do three from each Side and then Leadership because of the time frame.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, please, we have a lot to do today, so let us all appreciate what we are doing.

So let me start from—but please again, do not go beyond five minutes. I do not want to cut anybody. Let me give the floor to the Hon Member for Pusiga.

Hajia Laadi Ayii Ayamba (NDC — Pusiga): Thank you Mr Speaker for the opportunity to support the Motion on the floor.

Mr Speaker, I wish to first of all thank His Excellency John Dramani Mahama for in the long run, fulfilling the promise of getting us the 60 Ministers. Mr Speaker, there is no need to rush. If one rushes, he will crash. So, if His Excellency John Dramani Mahama saw it worthwhile to hang on for six months and in the seventh month, he comes in with the four people to make up the 60, so be it. We still hope for the best.

Mr Speaker, all four appointees demonstrated that they were worth it and whether we accept it or not, they exhibited it during the vetting. Mr Speaker, Hon Dorcas Toffey is one of the women who appeared before us. She exhibited her worth. She was on point and made us understand that she knew where she is going to and that she can work. She also knew very well that she is going to be a Deputy Minister and not a Minister. She is someone who is actually going to support her Minister to do the work.

When it came to her personal issues, she made it clear that yes, and I quote her partially, “Chairman, I have suffered. I have really suffered, but I do not want to talk about it, and I hope that nobody suffers like me. But it was nothing pleasant”. She made it clear that once she has gone through it and is all right, she is quite fine and does not want to talk about it.

That is someone who is worthy of leadership. I congratulate her on her performance on that fateful day.

Mr Speaker, Hon James Gyakyere Quayson responded to his questions explicitly and also ensured that he stayed within his limits. He was also asked about the issue of what happened to him. We were all in this Chamber when we saw the back and forth of his—he is the only MP so far that we have seen to have been sworn in two times because of what happened. Eventually, we all trooped to Assin North and now he has come back as a Member of Parliament; he also stated the same thing.

Mr Speaker, he went on to say that we should look at the issue of dual citizenship and not completely throw it off or see it to be an evil thing or something that is not the best. I think that it is worth looking at. We should all be very conscious of that and beware that if someone has a problem today, it could be us another time.

Mr Speaker, with Hon Sukparu, he was explicit. He made all of us laugh; he was down to earth, went through and we all realised that he was successful.

Now came the almighty Prof Dr Grace Ayensu-Danquah. Mr Speaker, this is a lady who had to stand her ground. She was determined, exhibited her wit, knowledge, resilience, patience and tolerance and made everyone understand that, yes, after all, she can go through whatever

she has been going through. She was not only a professor by the title that she put there as “Prof”, neither is she a doctor by gaining that doctorate, but she is someone who is down to earth and is worth it and she actually exhibited it.

Mr Speaker, once we do not have time, I will say and urge this House that we should, together, just as has been put by the Committee, by consensus, ensure that they go through. I thank you very much for the opportunity.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Thank you very much. Yes, let me go to Hon Matthew Nyindam.

Mr Matthew Nyindam (NPP — Kpandai): Thank you, Mr Speaker, for this opportunity to also support the Motion in approving the four Deputy Ministers who were vetted, sometime last week, that was last Friday.

Mr Speaker, just like Colleagues have all said, these four Deputy Ministers, which includes Deputy Minister-designate for Transport, Deputy Minister-designate for Foreign Affairs, Deputy Minister-designate for Communication, Digital Technology and Innovations, and the Deputy Minister-designate for Health are Colleagues that we all know. We have worked with them for a period of time. I personally took interest in listening to the vetting that took place and also participated in one of those sessions.

Mr Speaker, they all acknowledged and accepted that they are going there as Deputy Ministers to assist their Ministers. As we all know, the Constitution does not give Deputy Ministers their role. They will have to wait and then get some kind of delegation from their Ministers to be able to function well.

My plea to these Deputy Ministers-designate is that, just like they have acknowledged that they are going to assist, they should go and assist their Ministers very well. Today, if they get approval, we will not be too happy to hear that they are struggling with their various Ministers. They should go and serve them well; listen to them, help them, so that at the end of the day, the various Ministries that they are going to will work effectively and then Ghana as a whole will benefit.

4.43 p.m.

Mr Speaker, I also want to encourage their Ministers, in as much as they are supposed to come and assist them, they should also give them room to operate. They should use them; they should tap into their wisdom. They should not just say because they are the Ministers, they have all the knowledge. Mr Speaker, this does not help nation building. And if you listen to—Some time pass, most Deputy Ministers are better staying in this House because when they go to their Ministries, the Ministers do not even recognise them. When such things happen, Mr Speaker, it wastes everybody's time

because we spend precious time, vet these Deputy Ministers, give them the opportunity to go to the Ministry and unfortunately, they are not being used.

I therefore want to encourage and to urge their Ministers to try as much as possible to give them room to operate or learn something under them so that as a nation, we can all benefit.

Thank you, Mr Speaker, for this opportunity.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Yes, let me go to the Hon Member for New Edubiase.

Mr Abdul-Salam Adams (NDC — New Edubiase): Thank you, Mr Speaker for the opportunity to contribute to the Motion and to congratulate the Nominees on their nominations to their various Ministries. Mr Speaker, the role of Deputy Minister is clear. The role is to support and complement the Minister.

Mr Speaker, listening to the Nominees, it was clear that they were under no illusion that that was their role and I hope they carry the same sentiments and temperament to the Ministry and avoid the tension that sometimes we hear characterise the relationship between Ministers and their Deputies.

Mr Speaker, I was particularly happy with the nomination of the

Deputy Minister for Health. Usually, when Ministers for Health are appointed, health practitioners expect that they have someone who is in practice, someone in the health field to be Minister. So, when Hon Akandoh was appointed, I think those were some of the issues that were raised. So, it was important for the President to have someone with experience and Dr Grace Ayensu has a lot of experience as a surgeon. Mr Speaker, she carried herself in glory at the vetting. I am sure she will complement the Minister to do what is expected of them at the Ministry.

Mr Speaker, Hon Sukparu definitely is young and is going to a Ministry that is led by one of the youngest Ministers. I am sure they will complement each other. Hon Sam George and Hon Sukparu are alike in some ways. For them, what you see is what you get and they are very confident young men. I am sure they will lead the Ministry of Communication, Digital Technology and Innovations in glory.

Mr Speaker, again, the Hon Gyakyie Quayson is a perfect fit for the Ministry of Foreign Affairs and I am sure he will complement Hon Okudzeto Ablakwa with his experience. Mr Speaker, even in the face of adversity, I am sure you had encounters with Hon Quayson when he was being dragged in court. Mr Speaker, even in those moments, he was calm and collected and was very patient with the processes and I am sure that is the kind of temperament

we need at the Ministry of Foreign Affairs at a time of a turbulent international politics. Mr Speaker, his appointment also was in fulfilment of the promise by the President during the by-elections to his Constituents. So, we also have to thank the President for keeping to his promise to the people of Assin North.

Mr Speaker, Hon Toffey promises to bring renewed energy and refreshment to the Ministry of Transport. I am sure she will do just that. Mr Speaker, I want to congratulate them and implore the House to support this Motion. Thank you, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Thank you very much.

Nobody from this Side. Let me go to the Hon Member for Evalue-Ajomoro-Gwira.

Mr Kofi Arko Nokoe (NDC — Evalue-Ajomoro-Gwira): Thank you, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity to contribute to the Motion on the Floor. Mr Speaker, first of all, we must start by commending the President for keeping to his words of limiting the number of Ministers. Mr Speaker, that is a remarkable achievement and I am not surprised that even in this Budget, the Minister for Finance was able to put to light that within this space of six months, the debt saved by this country is GH¢113 billion. And I know that limiting the number of Ministers to 60 is a contributing factor and so we

must salute His Excellency John Dramani Mahama for such a wonderful policy. This is an indication to future Presidents that there is no going back and that we must share the feelings of Ghanaians and to ensure that every decision that we take must reflect positively in the lives of the people.

Mr Speaker, on the Nominees, I think, like has been said already, they fit perfectly and then it tells us a story that no matter how difficult it gets, one must be tough.

In the case of Hon Gyakyie Quayson, my Brother has said it all. He went through the worst times. We know as Members of Parliament, leading about 70,000 constituents and to be dragged to court almost every week, Mr Speaker, is not easy, but he stood firm. He was calm and he prevailed. Mr Speaker, even during his vetting, he told us that no matter how long it takes, just stay calm and things will work out.

Mr Speaker, for Hon Dorcas Toffey, happens to be a neighbour in Nzema, which is Jomoro and Evalue-Gwira and she did so well. Even with the mentioning of the number of electric vehicles that was imported into the country and the number, which was 10 with only four working indicates that whatever policy we are implementing, we must ensure that we go through it thoroughly to ensure that the taxpayers' money is put to good use.

For my Brother, Hon Sukparu, I believe that he will do a wonderful job.

For Dr Grace Ayensu-Danquah, also from the Western Region, we know that her contribution to the Ministry of Health will be positive and yielding for the country.

Thank you.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Thank you so much. Should I come to Leadership?

Alright, let me give the last one to Hon Member for Kwesimintsim.

Mr Philip Fiifi Buckman (NDC — Kwesimintsim): Thank you very much, Mr Speaker. I would also want to, congratulate the Nominees and also congratulate, in fact, the Committee for expeditious work that they did.

Mr Speaker, looking at the various appointees, it is conspicuous that H.E. John Dramani Mahama saw the ability and the capability of them before appointing them. I would not want to waste our time by mentioning their names, but at least let me talk about the ladies amongst them, how they were able to expressly come out to answer the questions that were posed to them.

Mr Speaker, the tenacity they showed in answering questions. Mr Speaker, in our part of the world, if somebody, especially a woman, is

assertive, it is taken as insolence and this is what came up, especially with something from one school that came up that one of them was insolent in school even at that time. But she was able to come out to explain herself, to show to the whole world that it was not that she was insolent, but she was assertive and even became a school prefect of the school. Mr Speaker, let me use the opportunity also to comment—Entertainment prefect. Yes, a prefect of the school. An entertainment prefect is a prefect of a school.

Mr Speaker, let me also use the opportunity to commend the Ranking Member.

4.53 p.m.

In fact, he used the opportunity to clear some ideas that were in the minds of people, especially in respect of Prof Grace Ayensu-Danquah, and it is commendable. It was very commendable when he took the opportunity to apologise to the Doctor that even if there was a perception of him maligning her or something, he apologised and the apology was taken in good faith.

Mr Speaker, save that, some of us think that at that particular point in time, that private issue with the school should not have come to the fore, but in all, I would want to humbly join all Members here to approve the Nominees by H. E. John Dramani Mahama. Thank you very much, Mr Speaker.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Let me now come to Leadership—Yes, Leader, I will give him the opportunity, but the fact of the matter is that when I turned, there was nobody up on his or her feet.

Deputy Minority Leader (Ms Patricia Appiagyei): Thank you, Mr Speaker, for this opportunity to support the Report ably presented by the Appointments Committee on the nomination of our four Members of Parliament who have been recommended to take the Deputy Ministerial position.

Mr Speaker, I would like to thank the President for upholding his commitment for women by appointing two additional women in his last lap of appointees. I continue to remind the President that he has still not fulfilled the 30 per cent women's representation required by the Affirmative Action Act, and I pray to him to keep to his promise and ensure that he gives us women, the 30 per cent representation he promised.

Mr Speaker, we in the Appointments Committee vetted and we had the opportunity to have a good discussion with all the Nominees.

I would like to congratulate our Hon Member, Ms Dorcas Toffey, on her appointment as a Deputy Minister-designate for Transport. Ms Toffey is a philanthropist, a woman of substance and she is very passionate about the well-being of constituents, especially the Jomoro constituents.

The Nominee appeared before the Appointments Committee with admirable composure, clarity, and conviction. She demonstrated an impressive depth of understanding of issues confronting our nation's transport sector, ranging from the challenges of urban congestion and public transport, from the modernisation of railway infrastructure and maritime development. Her responses were well-researched, policy-driven, and reflective of her readiness to serve with competence and integrity and her readiness to serve as a Deputy Minister. She inspired confidence in her vision for transforming Ghana's transport landscape in line with our national development goals. Hon Toffey exemplifies the strength, brilliance, and the rising influence of Ghanaian women in governance. She brings to the role not only her legislative experience, but also a passion for inclusive development, emphasising safety, accessibility, and innovation in transport policy.

Mr Speaker, we as a Committee were particularly encouraged by her commitment to improve road safety, supporting local transport unions, and enhancing ports and operations to boost trade and mobility. Her performance at the vetting was in every respect a testament to her preparedness for that higher office. And as a woman, I was particularly impressed with her commitment to advancing gender equity within the Ministry of Transport, and I believe that if she is given the nod, she will

uphold her pledge to create greater opportunities for women in transport.

Mr Speaker, I would like to also add my voice in commending Hon Prof Grace Ayensu-Danquah, the Deputy Minister-designate for Health. Ms Ayensu, or Prof, as most people call her, is a trailblazer and a role model for women and girls. She really exhibited that given the opportunity, she will rise and ensure that her presence in leadership will affirm the commitment to gender equity and the vital inclusion of women in the national decision making. Permit me to place on record the Committee's collective admiration for the Nominee's outstanding performance during her vetting. She answered questions with confidence and ensured that any form of misunderstandings that have arisen out of any perception were clarified.

Mr Speaker, I also move on to Hon James Gyakye Quayson. He appeared before the Committee with confidence, humility, and a deep sense of national duty. He exhibited a remarkable grasp of the core pillars of Ghana's foreign policy, regional integration, economic diplomacy, diaspora engagement, and multilateral co-operation. My only regret was that Hon Gyakye Quayson was totally disconnected with the details of the Ghana education curriculum and therefore, was not very well abreast of what happens over here. I must say his responses were lucid, measured, and forward-thinking, reflecting both his academic background and international

exposure. It was evident to all Members of the Committee that he brings to the Ministry of Foreign Affairs not only a strong understanding of diplomacy and international law, but also represents a genuine source of mature advice for the Minister for Foreign Affairs.

Mr Speaker, at a time our sub-region is grappling with security threats, migration crisis, and shifting geopolitical alliances, Hon Quayson's mature world view and calm statesmanship will be of immense value to the Ministry and to Ghana's positioning in the world stage.

Then I come to our last nominee in the person of Hon Mohammed Adams Sukparu. He conducted himself with exemplary poise and maturity during the vetting process. His performance was not only commendable but also inspiring, especially considering the complex and fast evolving nature of the digital economy.

5.03 p.m.

Mr Speaker, I would like to end here and accordingly add my voice that we, in the Committee, with consensus, will recommend to the House to approve the four Nominees who have been appointed by His Excellency the President. Mr Speaker, so, with these words, I recommend that the House support in approving the Nominees accordingly.

I thank you very much.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: I will take the Minority Leader and, then, the Deputy Majority Leader and we bring it to a close.

Minority Leader (Osahen Alexander Kwamena Afenyo-Markin): Mr Speaker, I rise to speak to the Report which is the Sixteenth Report of the Appointments Committee.

Mr Speaker, while in substance I have nothing to add to the content of the Report, of course, the Colleagues who appear before us are all Members of Parliament and they qualify under Article 78 appointments. Mr Speaker, I want, however, for *Hansard* to register some few views that the Minority Caucus have. When we vet, our duty is to enrich governance. The Minority does not get into the vetting with the aim to embarrass, never.

Mr Speaker, we watched the vettings of this House in 2001 and 2005 when the Speaker was the Minority Leader. I urge some of our critics to watch those videos and the long hours that the then Minority Leader spent on the nominees of Kufuor's Government. Mr Speaker, again, if you watch the video of the Hon Haruna Iddrisu era with Hon Muntaka, his Chief Whip, you realise that every single Cabinet Minister or nominee went through proper long hours of vetting. For some nominees, it took more than two days.

Mr Speaker, I was a Deputy Majority Leader and what I did was

that when the Minority were going through their questions, I would take notes and come back to do what I call re-examination, so that we fix it. Mine was not to make noise and obstruct. My Deputy has not taken it upon herself to be asking many questions as per the records we know, but we often come under attack. Sometimes, Mr Speaker, when we are climbing, I do not know whether these thugs are brought in by certain people, but they would physically be pushing us. It was not only me but my Colleagues. We have experienced it and we know that, in Parliament, we have CCTV cameras. Can this be reviewed to see what we go through? Sometimes, they openly threaten us. These things happen.

Mr Speaker, I want this Ninth Parliament to record this: that this is the Parliament that the Minority has been most magnanimous. Let the record reflect and let people check it. Mr Speaker, there are nominees who we did not even proceed with one week or two weeks of adverts. Some were nominated and, the same day, they were vetted. Sometimes, as politicians, let us be fair with the way we treat one another. When the Minority reaches out and cooperates with Majority and now they say that they have, on record, been able to get their nominees through, they should not turn around and let people use social media to attack and threaten us. It is not right.

Mr Speaker, the Minority here are not civil society organisations

(CSOs). We are political leaders like them; only yesterday, I was there with my Colleagues and today we are here. Our job is not to come and put roadblocks to obstruct their Government; they must be fair.

Mr Speaker, having addressed that point, I want to come to this very emotional matter that I want to speak to. Last week, I was on my hospital bed. I was unwell and while watching television, I saw Afenyo-Makin being pounded and I felt very sad. Mr Speaker, because the Hon Member for Kwesimintsim spoke to this issue, I want to reiterate it. Mr Speaker, in this House, on very good days, we all share jokes. Sometimes, we yell at each other and call ourselves names, but they are on lighter notes. It was on that note, that day, my respected Colleague, Grace Ayensu-Danquah, got up and I knew it was a usual heckling because, at times, she comes to sit at the Frontbench to heckle me. I do not take it personally. We close and we stand outside to talk. We joke and we share. We have *esprit de corps* and I respect her. Mr Speaker, that day, I thought I was using my usual jokes that Hon Zanetor has to be appointed. It was the usual thing.

Mr Speaker, the following day, we spoke. Hon Dorcas Toffey, Hon Gyakyee Quayson and my good self, met in the new offices that has been given to the Leadership. We sat there and we talked as adults and she told me that there were some social media posts which is not hers and I said that if she is offended, she should tell me.

I will apologise to her. I thought we were joking. Even that same afternoon, she came here. Jerry is here. The videos are there. We spoke nicely; I called her because I thought we are a family, only to see a certain non-government organisation (NGO) attacking me that I am attacking women. I said how? We are a family. For those who know me in this Chamber, we do the politics all right, but I have character. There is no way I would attack a Colleague and they allowed this thing to go into the records, attacking me as if I disrespect my Colleagues.

Mr Speaker, that day, when the opportunity came, I said, today, my style and my approach in this House would be different. If Members cannot take a joke, I will not, because sometimes, I feel we are all affable. We get on well with one another and we all know, but I had to bring that matter to a closure by saying, Colleague, if, indeed, it has turned out that you are offended by the thing that we all discussed so happily, I am sorry. Let the record reflect it, but going forward, we know how we would approach things in this House.

Mr Speaker, reputation is all we have as Colleagues. I know my humble beginnings and I know what I have gone through in life. I will be the last to seize any Leadership opportunity to undermine somebody. I know what I have suffered for and I know what I have gone through. When my party was in power, I was not even a Committee Leader. I was a

Backbencher and there were juniors who were leaders in Committees. I took it and hoped for a future, so I will be the last person to undermine anybody because if you move patiently with hard work, heavens will open up to you. That is my belief.

Mr Speaker, as a Catholic Christian, I am not perfect, but I will never undermine a Colleague, particularly so when it is a woman. I am a husband. Would I be happy if somebody does that to my wife? I am a father; would I be happy if somebody does that to my daughter? So, I will not do that; I will not. Mr Speaker, I am so much emotional on this matter, but I pray that heaven brings closure to this and it will not repeat itself.

5.13 p.m.

Mr Speaker, that said, the Nominee, Hon Grace Ayensu-Danquah, is somebody I admire. I admire her because if one looks at her records, she started as an arts student in her O-Level and A-Level; for somebody who, if one looks at her results, has become a medical doctor, this is somebody to admire and I respect and admire her. She knows that. It is the reason we are, by consensus, dealing with this Report and saying that we do not need to take a vote.

Mr Speaker, the Hon Member for Kwesimintsim also said something about a statement being made about the Nominee, Hon Grace Ayensu-

Danquah. Mr Speaker, because we are working for records, I want to clarify that as a practice, whenever the Committee is seized with Nominees, the Committee writes to authorise agencies for character reference.

So, Hon Member for Kwesimintsim, it is not me, Afenyo-Markin, who was reading something from somewhere. The document was from an authorised source, her previous school, and that was what we had received; it was not me. The same report had some good news. She had some positive remarks coming from some of her referees. So, I wanted to give her the opportunity to say something to clear it; not to embarrass her. That should not be my style. I wanted her to have the opportunity to clear the issue, so that we could put it to a peaceful rest. That is what was done.

So, Colleagues, let us understand the work we are doing. Sometimes, we are also at pains. When one is supposed to vet, they are not to embarrass their Colleague and Colleagues should also note that it is not every nominee that we vet. Some of them come and we say, it is all right, so we should please move on. I never vetted any of the Regional Ministers. Has the record forgotten that one? Even the four Nominees, how many of them did I spend time on? Let us not get into the public space to destroy the reputation of people who are really enriching good governance and enriching democracy.

Mr Speaker, I want this to be on record. When Hon Akandoh was a Deputy Ministerial Nominee, it took the support of the Minority in 2015 to back him; today, he is the Minister for Health. It was the then Minority, we were on this Side, who spoke in favour of that nomination, when he was under attack from his Side. *Hansard* would bear me out.

So, we are not here to obstruct their Government. We are here to do our job just as they did when they were in opposition: to hold their feet to the fire, be constructive in what we are doing, and to be objective and fair. And I think that is what we have been doing. Even in situations where we disagree with them. In their time, they took secret ballots on nominees whom they were opposed to, but in our time, even when we are opposed to it, we do not take them through secret ballots.

Colleagues, let us—[*Interruption*]—No, I need to take this off my chest. I mean no ill when dealing with Colleagues. I know we are all a family and I believe I deserve that equal treatment. Colleagues who have lived here long enough know me. It is about me and I care about it. We are a family and please, let us move together in that spirit as a family, so that the peace of this House can be protected.

That said, Mr Speaker, I am not opposed to the recommendation by the Committee and I, therefore, encourage Colleagues to let us all, by consensus, support this, so that they can go and support their Ministers.

Mr Speaker, with that said, I thank you so much.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Thank you very much. Majority Leadership, yes?

Deputy Majority Leader (Mr George Kweku Ricketts-Hagan): Thank you, Mr Speaker, and I would like to thank the Chairman of the Committee for the Report.

Mr Speaker, four Members of this Parliament, Ms Dorcas Toffey, Mr James Gyakyé Quayson and—

Mr Nyindam — *rose* —

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Leader, go ahead. Hon Matthew, I gave you the opportunity to comment on—

Mr Ricketts-Hagan: Mr Speaker, Hon Adams Sukparu and Hon Grace Ayensu-Danquah were vetted on 25th July and they all discharged themselves well. It became very clear, at the vetting, that they all understood what their roles were going to be by supporting their Ministers in the Ministries that they have been designated.

Mr Speaker, as has been said by those who spoke before me, they discharged themselves very well and demonstrated some knowledge, of course, they do not know it all, of the areas that they are going to. They made it very clear that they were actually going to support their

Ministers. They were not going there to be policy makers, but to support the policies of the Minister.

I would like to single out Prof Ayensu-Danquah, for instance, who really displayed her knowledge of medical science. Of course, she is a doctor and a professor, so she demonstrated a good knowledge of some of the things that we wanted answers to and how she will be able to support the Minister in executing his duties if she gets the nod.

Mr Speaker, I heard the Minority Leader trying to express his feelings on the issue that took place, where he ended up apologising, which I think is a fantastic thing that he did to the lady. And it is not surprising that as a Committee, we finalised by saying that we agree by consensus for our Colleagues to be approved to do the job that H. E. John Dramani Mahama has designated them to.

Mr Speaker, with these few words, I will also add my support to the Chairman of the Committee that this House approves Ms Dorcas Toffey, Mr James Gyakye Quayson, Mr Adams Mohammed Sukparu, and Prof Grace Ayensu-Danquah by consensus and unanimously.

Thank you very much, Mr Speaker.

Question put and Motion agreed to.

5.23 p.m.

Mr Ahiafor: Mr Speaker, thank you very much for giving me the opportunity. Mr Speaker, on behalf of the Nominees; Ms Dorcas Toffey, Mr James Gyakye Quayson, Mr Mohammed Adams Sukparu, Prof Dr Grace Ayensu-Danquah, I thank the Committee for doing a very thorough work in vetting them and unanimously recommending them to the House for approval. I also thank the House on their behalf for unanimously approving them.

Mr Speaker, let me exclusively thank the Minority Leader, Osahen Alexander Kwamena Afenyo-Markin and to say that at vetting, we should not be cross-examining but we should be vetting the people. We should not be re-examining, but we should rather vet them. So once again, I thank everybody who was involved in the exercise on behalf of the Nominees and also on behalf of His Excellency, the President of the Republic of Ghana, His Excellency John Dramani Mahama.

Mr Speaker, I thank you for the opportunity.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Thank you very much, Chairman. Hon Members, on behalf of the House, let me also extend our congratulations to our own Colleagues. They have made us proud and we wish them well. On that note, we thank you once again.

Yes, Hon Members, we have so many things to do at the moment. Let me yield the seat to the First Deputy Speaker. We will do it in turns and I will come back. So, Leadership, are we doing the debate now? So, we will turn to the debate and all the rules are already there.

5: 26 p.m. — [HON FIRST DEPUTY SPEAKER, MR BENARD AHIAFOR, IN THE CHAIR]

FORMAL STATEMENT BY THE SPEAKER

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, before making progress, let me make this formal communication from the Rt Hon Speaker, Alban Sumana Kingsford Bagbin. It is a formal statement of the Rt Hon Speaker on the need for Members of Parliament to participate in the Pan-African Rally for Debt Cancellation organised by International Trade Union Confederation (ITUC)-Africa and the Trade Union Congress, Ghana, on 25th July, 2025.

Introduction

Hon Members of the House, I bring to your attention a significant invitation extended to this House by the African Regional Organisation of the International Trade Union Confederation (ITUC)-Africa, in partnership with the Trade Union Congress, (TUC), Ghana. This invitation seeks the participation of the Speaker and Members of

Parliament in the upcoming Pan-African Rally for Debt Cancellation, which will take place on Friday 29th August, 2025, on the sidelines of the African Conference on Debt and Development, (AfCoDD). The event is being held under the theme: “Reparations and Reparative Justice for an African Financial Architecture and Transformation”. I have reflected on this invitation and I consider it worthy of support by this august House.

Background: The Debt Crisis in Africa and Ghana.

Hon Members, as we all know, Africa’s debt burden has grown to alarming levels in recent years. According to the African Development Bank, Africa’s total public debt surpassed US\$1.8 trillion in 2023, with over 22 African countries at high risk of debt distress or already in distress. Ghana is said to be among those nations, and we know our debt situation, which prompted a domestic debt restructuring programme and a need to negotiate with bilateral and multilateral creditors under the G20 Common Framework. Ghana’s public debt reached GHC658.6 billion by the end of 2024, equivalent to 68.3 per cent of Gross Domestic Product (GDP), despite significant domestic fiscal consolidation efforts. The burden of debt servicing consumes a considerable portion of our national revenue, limiting our fiscal space to invest in education, healthcare, infrastructure and job creation. (Bank of Ghana Summary of Economic and Financial Data, May 2024).

As a result, ordinary citizens bear the brunt through inflation, currency depreciation, rising cost of living and austerity measures imposed under international support programmes. The social impact is palpable and immediate; school feeding delay, stalled infrastructure projects, rising youth unemployment, among others.

Call for Parliamentary participation.

Hon Members, the organisers of the rally, ITUC-Africa and TUC Ghana, have formally invited the Speaker and this honourable House to be part of this critical moment. The Pan-African Rally for Debt Cancellation forms part of the broader continental campaign aimed at raising public consciousness, enhancing civic education and mobilising African populace around the urgent need to confront the escalating debt burden afflicting the continent.

5.33 p.m.

It is more than a public procession; it is a continental clarion call for justice. It recognises that the current debt architecture is unsustainable and structurally unjust, often entrenching dependency rather than enabling development.

The rally presents an opportunity to deepen public awareness and education on African debt crisis and by so doing mobilise citizens and institutions across the continent to demand more tangible reforms. This would potentially propel conversations

and action towards building a new Africa financial architecture rooted in equity, sustainability, and justice.

The rally, in the form of peaceful procession, is scheduled to begin at Obra Spot, Kwame Nkrumah Circle, and proceed through some principal streets of Accra, eventually converging at the Black Star Square.

Conclusion

I invite you, Hon Members, to show your support towards this cause. May we present a strong message of solidarity and leadership from Ghana's legislature, reinforcing our collective commitment to addressing the root causes of Africa's debt crisis and pursuing meaningful transformation.

Hon Members, our participation in this rally will reaffirm the resolve of this parliament to advocate for economic justice, transparency, and sustainable development. Let us, therefore, lend our collective voice and presence to this noble cause, one that speaks directly to the aspirations of the people we represent.

Hon Members, I thank you for your attention.

Mr Ayariga: Thank you very much, Mr Speaker, for the Communication.

I agree with the Rt Hon Speaker that debt cancellation is a matter that Africans must be fighting for and we as legislators must lend our support to

civil society groups as they rally to the clarion call for debt cancellation. Many of our countries are struggling with mounting debts, and in most cases, most of our incomes get spent on servicing not even our main debts, but the interest on our debts, even before we come to the debts themselves, leaving no room for investments in infrastructure and investments in social services such as education, healthcare delivery, and critical needs of our societies. If only the developed world could cancel some of the debts, I believe some room will be created for our economies to do better.

I will urge colleagues to listen to the Rt Hon Speaker's call on us to join civil society and march and demonstrate our support for the call on the developed world to begin to cancel the debts. Ghana benefited from debt cancellation in the past, and indeed, it helped the government at that time. And I believe that at this critical stage where this government has demonstrated a commitment to fiscal discipline and is working so hard to live up to its debt obligations, the international community and the creditor world should actually begin to think about giving us some leverage by cancelling some of the debts.

So, I thank the Rt Hon Speaker for his Communication to us.

Mr Speaker, on that note, I think that the House wants to continue with the debate on the Motion on the Mid-

Year Budget and the approvals that are needed.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: We agreed to take the Motion 12 and 13 before we come to the debate.

I think we are taking the Motion 16.

Mr Ayariga: Chairman of the Subsidiary Legislation Committee.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: No, we are taking the Motion 14, 15, and 16. Mr Speaker. The Social Protection—

Ms Patricia Appiagyei: Mr Speaker, I thought we came to an agreement. Our members are poised to take the debate, and we have an understanding that we are going to do the debate before we take the Social Protection—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: At Conclave, we agreed, based on which the Second Deputy Speaker was to start, I will come and do the Communication and the Motion and then he will come back to do the debate.

Ms Appiagyei: I believe that when we start with the Social Protection Bill, we should spend some time on it.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: We are only taking the determination of the urgency and the Second Reading. The Consideration Stage will be done tomorrow.

Ms Appiagyei: All right. Thank you very much.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: The Motion numbered 14. Chairman of the Committee.

MOTIONS

Suspension of SOrder 104(1)

Chairperson of the Committee (Rev Helen Adjoa Ntoso): Mr Speaker, I beg to *move*:

That notwithstanding the provisions of Standing Order 104(1) which require that a Motion shall not be debated until at least two sitting days have elapsed after the notice to move the motion is given, the Motion for the adoption of the Report of the of the Committee on Gender, Children and Social Welfare, under determination of the urgency of the Social Protection Bill, 2025.

Ranking Member of the Committee (Ms Adelaide Ntim): Mr Speaker, I beg to second the Motion.

Question put and Motion agreed to.

Resolved accordingly.

Determination of the Urgency of the Social Protection Bill, 2025

Chairperson of the Committee (Rev Helen Adjoa Ntoso): Mr Speaker, I beg to *move*:

That this honourable House adopt the Report of the Committee on Gender, Children and Social Welfare, under determination of the urgency of the Social Protection Bill, 2025.

Mr Speaker, in doing so, I present the Committee's Report.

Introduction

The Social Protection Bill, 2025 was laid in Parliament on Monday, 28th July, 2025 by the Hon Minister responsible for Gender, Children, and Social Protection, Ms Agnes Naa Momo Larney (PhD). The Rt Hon Speaker referred the Bill to the Committee on Gender, Children and Social Welfare for consideration and report.

The Rt Hon Speaker further directed the Committee to determine whether the Bill was of an urgent nature, and should be taken through all the stages in one day in accordance with Article 106(13) of the 1992 Constitution and Order 160 of the Standing Orders of Parliament.

The Committee, having regard to the referral made by the Rt Hon Speaker, met with the Hon Minister responsible for Gender, Children and Social Protection and officials of the Ministry on Monday, 28th July, 2025 to determine the urgency of the Bill.

Reference Documents

The Committee made reference to the following documents during its deliberations:

- i. The Constitution of the Republic of Ghana, 1992.
- ii. The Standing Orders of Parliament.
- iii. Social Protection Bill, 2025.
- iv. Ghana National Social Protection Policy, 2015.

Observations/Recommendations Provision of a Legal Framework for Social Protection Programmes

The Committee observed that there have been various attempts by the Ministry to facilitate the promulgation of a social protection law, since the formulation and launch of the Ghana National Social Protection Policy in December, 2015. Successive Parliaments of the Fourth Republic took decisive steps to pass the Social Protection Bill; but were unable to do so prior to the expiration of their tenure.

The Bill had been introduced in Parliament on 27th June, 2025 and referred to the Committee on Gender, Children and Social Welfare for consideration and report. The Committee has considered the Bill, and undertaken wide stakeholder consultations with civil society organisations and the general public,

leading to amendments which the Attorney-General has integrated into the Bill currently before the House. Hence, the need to withdraw the earlier Bill and relay for further referral to the Committee.

Given extensive stakeholder engagements on the Bill over the years and the need for Ghana to, as soon as practicable, enact a social protection law in fulfilment of its international obligations under Goals 1 and 10 of the Sustainable Development Goals and the African Union Social Policy Framework for Africa, it is necessary that the Bill be considered by the House under a certificate of urgency.

Conclusion

Considering the potential impact of this Bill to provide relief for vulnerable groups in Ghana, the Committee believes strongly that taking the Social Protection Bill, 2025 under a certificate of urgency is justified, and we urge prompt consideration and passage of this critical legislation.

In light of the fact that the Bill would provide appropriate institutional arrangements for the management of funds released for social interventions, deferring passage of the Bill till the next Meeting may further deepen the plight of the vulnerable. The Committee, therefore, recommends that the Social Protection Bill, 2025 be considered under a certificate of

Determination of the Urgency of the Social Protection Bill, 2025

urgency to ensure its passage, as soon as practicable, for the benefit of Ghanaians.

Respectfully submitted, Mr Speaker.

Thank you.

5.43 p.m.

Ranking Member to the Committee (Ms Adelaide Ntim): I rise to second the Motion on the Floor. This is an important Bill. As indicated in the Report, various governments have implemented social protection programmes such as Ghana Poverty Reduction Strategy, the National Social Protection Strategy, the School Feeding Programme and the Livelihood Empowerment Against Poverty Programme (LEAP).

Unfortunately, Mr Speaker, these programmes were only implemented as policies without necessary legal backing. Mr Speaker, there is a need to provide laws to regulate the delivery of social protection services. I, therefore, urge the House to join me in adopting the Committee's Report.

I thank you, Mr Speaker.

Question proposed.

Mr Isaac Boamah-Nyarko (NPP — Effia): Thank you very much, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity to contribute to this particular Motion.

Mr Speaker, the Committee has submitted its Report, trying to justify

the need for us to pass the Bill under a certificate of urgency. It is becoming a worrying trend in this House where the need to pass legislation under certificates of urgency, which is supposed to be something that is not the norm, is becoming the norm.

I am saying this, Mr Speaker, because there is good reason legislations and Bills have to pass through all the needed processes before we pass them into the House. I have read the Report from its cover page up to the end. Mr Speaker, 1.0 deals with introduction, 2.0 deals with reference documents, and 3.0 goes to observations and recommendations. Where is the justification in this Report that calls for the Bill to be passed under a certificate of urgency?

So, when we come into this House and we are being made to just go through Motions to pass Bills under certificates of urgency, when we have not necessarily justified the need for the Bill to be passed under certificates of urgency, then it is worrying. There is always a difference between the importance of a Bill and the need to pass the Bill under a certificate of urgency. I agree with the Committee that this is an important Bill. It is important that we amend or review it and then get the Bill done. But in the Reports that I have, there is no proper justification for it to be passed under a certificate of urgency.

So, I am worried, and this is why I want to bring Leadership's attention

to this, that they should let us get Bills to go through due Consideration Stages and let us pass them through the normal regular channel of passing legislations and not use numbers. Numbers are not enough to pass Bills under certificates of urgency. We need to do thorough work, because under certificates of urgency, we are doing it within a day. We are forced to pass legislations in a day, but that is not good enough. Members would have to engage with their constituents.

I am from the Effia Constituency. When Bills come, I have a module where I want to engage my constituents. Three Bills have passed through here over the last couple of weeks, and all of them are run through certificates of urgency. How do I get the time to brief, engage my constituents get their opinion on what I need to do in terms of contributing to these Bills that we are passing? With that said, Mr Speaker, of course, this is a House and it has to make determination based on all our collective views, so I defer it to the House. Yes, I agree that it is important for us to look at the Bill, but I am not of the view that this should necessarily be passed under a certificate of urgency.

With that, Mr Speaker, I am so grateful for giving me the opportunity.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, ordinarily I am not supposed to do this, but I need to bring it to the fore that sometimes

these things are occasioned by the convenience of the House. This Bill was duly *gazetted* on 2nd May, 2025. After 14 days, it was introduced and referred to the Committee on Gender, Children and Social Welfare.

Hon Members, the Committee came out with numerous amendments to the Bill, and the advice was that the amendment should be integrated leading to the withdrawal of the Bill. So, it cannot be true that the public is not given adequate notice and Members of Parliament are not also given adequate notice. So certain impressions are not very good for our record; that is the fact. Yes? —

The fact is that this Bill has been introduced after the constitutional imperative in Article 106 has been satisfied. Now, under Article 106 (13), it talks about explanatory memorandum and 14 days *Gazette* prior to the introduction of the Bill. But this Bill had been *gazetted* on 2nd May, 2025 and introduced in this House after the 14 days' constitutional mandatory period has elapsed and referred to the Committee. It is the Committee's amendment that necessitated the withdrawal of that particular Bill and a new one being introduced, and that introduction is under a certificate of urgency. So, nobody can claim that the actual Bill—It is just for the sake of convenience, going through numerous amendments being carried out on the Floor, that is why all these exercises are being undertaken.

Determination of the Urgency of the Social Protection Bill, 2025

So, this House had notice of this particular Bill from its first introduction, but not the second introduction. And then the constitutional imperative in Article 106(2) has also been complied with. So, that is why I am saying that, it is for the convenience of the House that we are at the stage that we are now.

Yes, Majority Leader?

Majority Leader (Mr Mahama Ayariga): Now our proceedings are broadcasted live on national television. This morning, I was listening to radio, I think *Citi FM*, and I heard a caller requesting that they watch our proceedings, but sometimes they do not understand. They asked a panellist on the *Citi FM* if he could help with explaining what happens in Parliament so that they can understand the proceedings. So, I just thought to use this opportunity to explain these developments where we come under certificate of urgency.

Ideally, what has always happened is, when it is laid and referred to a Committee, the Committee goes to work on it then the Committee recommends amendments. The amendments are ordinarily advertised. Sometimes when the amendments are many and they are advertised, the next thing is that it is referred to a Winnowing Committee.

5.53 p.m.

This is because when the amendments of the Committee are

many and individual Members of Parliament also introduce many amendments, then, in order to manage the amendments and not waste the time of the House because we have to take the amendments one after the other, you refer it to the Winnowing Committee. At the Winnowing Committee, we try to reduce the number of amendments and get to a reasonable number and bring it back to the House and take whatever we have agreed on through the Consideration Stage.

Mr Speaker, very often, I also find out that the amendments are so many even after winnowing that I think the best option, as Leader, is to recommend that Minister withdraws the Bill, sends it to the Office of the Attorney-General and Ministry of Justice, let them reconcile all the amendments into an intelligible Bill and bring it back. Then we will withdraw the old Bill and introduce a new Bill with all the amendments that have been agreed upon, which the Office of the Attorney-General has worked on. When that happens, it becomes unfair to that Bill to let it go through another 14-day *Gazette* notification, lay, refer it back to the Committee because the Committee has really worked on it.

So, it is not that we are rushing the Bills through with the use of certificate of urgency, but it is because we have in fact worked on the Bills to a certain level of detail, so if it is brought back, it is just wasting the time of everybody.

Mr Speaker, indeed, this Bill, if my memory serves me right, came in the last Parliament and it was sent as far as the Consideration Stage. It was because towards the end of the life of that Parliament, there was so much disagreement and litigation that led to the Parliament not sitting until election time. So, several Bills that we should have finished before the expiry of the life of that Parliament were not finished. So, the Minister came and met the Bill and because the life of that Parliament had elapsed, she had to bring it back.

But in fact, we had worked on it in the last Parliament. But even then, I advised her to get the Committee to still look at it because there could be new developments and new policy initiatives that she would want to inform the final rendition of the Bill. So, last week, they had a retreat as a Committee; they worked on it and they reported to me that they had so many recommendations for amendments and I then advised them that if that is the case, they should go to the Office of the Attorney-General and Ministry of Justice and let them incorporate the amendments, make sure that every amendment is consistent with the principles of the Bill and earlier clauses of the Bill because they are the experts. We can make amendments here, but if we do not allow them to look at it, we may make amendments that will contradict earlier provisions, even subsequent provisions or even undermine the very principle informing the Bill that is before us.

Mr Speaker, that was what happened, so the Office of the Attorney-General and Ministry of Justice redrafted the Bill to capture all the amendments proposed by the Committee and it was brought and laid. I, then, recommended that they should take it through a certificate of urgency because we cannot afford to go back. As you know, we are going on recess on Friday, so if we would have to do another *Gazette* notification and another Consideration Stage, we will be overtaken by time. So, I plead with the Hon Members that these are the circumstances and the facts. I believe that the Bill has been around for so long that interest groups that have wanted to make an input have had a fair opportunity to make an input.

On that note, I urge Colleagues that we allow the Report on the certificate of urgency to be approved, so that—The Report on the determination of certificate of urgency does not mean that if, at this stage, Hon Members have an amendment, they cannot introduce it. It just means that the time-bound procedures for advertising should be abridged, so that we can move with some speed. So, Members can still introduce amendments if they have some, but let us take it with some speed that will enable us to pass it before we go on recess on Friday.

Thank you, Mr Speaker.

Deputy Minority Leader (Ms Patricia Appiagyei): Mr Speaker, we want to thank the Majority Leader for

Determination of the Urgency of the Social Protection Bill, 2025

offering such an explanation. I think it brings clarity to the issue. I think the Hon Member has had a fair understanding of what is going on. But my question is, at the nick of time, does he think that we can go through all the Motions, considering the fact that we have all these debates to undertake and also have other issues to look at? I am sure he is concerned because of the time allocation to look at such an important Bill and that is the reason, maybe, he is raising concerns about it, not just because he does not want to do it. It is a Bill that is very important—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, the indication is that we are not doing the Consideration today.

Ms Appiagyeyi: Thank you.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, I think I have the sense of the House to pose the Question.

Question put and Motion agreed to.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Now, Hon Member, we will take the Motion numbered 16 at page 4.

Hon Minister for Gender, Children and Social Protection, you may move the Motion numbered 16.

BILL — SECOND READING

Social Protection Bill, 2025

Minister for Gender, Children and Social Protection (Dr Agnes Naa Momo Lartey) (MP): Mr Speaker, I beg to *move*:

That the Social Protection Bill, 2025 be now read a Second time.

Chairperson of the Committee (Rev Helen Adjoa Ntoso): Mr Speaker, I rise to support the Motion and I urge that *Hansard* captures the Report in its entirety.

Introduction

The Social Protection Bill, 2025 was laid in Parliament on Monday, 28th July, 2025 by the Hon Minister responsible for Gender, Children, and Social Protection, Ms Agnes Naa Momo Lartey (PhD), in accordance with article 106 of the 1992 Constitution.

Pursuant to article 106(4) of the 1992 Constitution and Order 237 of the Standing Orders of Parliament, the Bill was referred to the Committee on Gender, Children and Social Welfare for consideration and report.

Deliberations

The Committee and the Leadership of the Committee on Constitutional and Legal Affairs met with the Hon Minister for Gender, Children and Social Protection and other officials of the Ministry and considered the Bill. Officials of the Office of the Attorney-General and Minister for Justice were in attendance to assist in the deliberations.

The Committee is grateful to the Hon Minister and all other

stakeholders for their input and support during deliberations on the Bill. The Committee hereby submits its report in accordance with Order 166 of the Standing Orders of Parliament.

Reference Documents

Committee referred to the following documents during its deliberations:

- i. The 1992 Constitution of the Republic of Ghana
- ii. The Standing Orders of the Parliament of Ghana
- iii. The Social Protection Bill, 2025
- iv. Ghana National Social Protection Policy, 2015

Background

The Ghana National Social Protection Policy defines Social Protection as a range of actions by the State and other parties to provide relief for vulnerable and impoverished populations. These actions include policies to decrease vulnerability through labour market development, risk reduction and improved access to social interventions.

The Social Protection Bill, 2025 seeks to promote access to social protection services by chronically poor and vulnerable persons through specific institutional arrangements. The rationale for promulgation of a social protection statute is in

consonance with Chapter Six of the 1992 Constitution of Ghana, which guarantees the well-being of citizens through the provision of adequate means of livelihood.

Ghana's obligations under the United Nations Sustainable Development Goals and the African Union Social Policy Framework require implementation of strategies and mechanisms to provide for the marginalised in the country and minimise circumstances that impair well-being.

Accordingly, successive governments have implemented social protection programmes to improve living conditions of the chronically poor, socially vulnerable and economically at-risk persons. These programmes include the Ghana Poverty Reduction Strategy; the National Social Protection Strategy, 2007; the School Feeding Programme; the Livelihood Empowerment Against Poverty Programme; and the Labour Intensive Public Works Programme.

Social protection programmes in Ghana have, over the years, been implemented as policies without the necessary legal force. The passage of the Bill into law would, therefore, provide a legislative framework to regulate the delivery of social protection services. The implementation of the law would ensure continuity and equity in the discharge of roles at the national and sub-national levels by relevant actors in the social protection structure.

Purpose of the Bill

The purpose of the Bill is to promote access to social protection, provide social protection services to specified persons and establish and specify institutional arrangements to ensure social protection.

Summary of Provisions in the Bill

The Social Protection Bill, 2025 is sectioned into sixty-seven (67) clauses and three (3) schedules:

Clauses 1 to 3 provide for the protection of vulnerable individuals in society, including the chronically poor, those economically at risk, the socially vulnerable, and those affected by national or local emergencies. The clauses seek to reduce poverty and vulnerability among these groups, and promote their overall wellbeing.

Clauses 4 to 9 outline the Ministry's role in social protection, and empower it to coordinate programmes and interventions through the Social Protection Directorate. The clauses also provide for the Ministry's collaboration with specialised agencies, flagship programmes, and oversight institutions for local authorities.

Clauses 10 and 11 establish the National Household Registry and outline its functions, which include collection and maintaining relevant data on non-poor, poor and vulnerable individuals and households.

Clauses 12 and 13 relate to methods for targeting beneficiaries for social protection interventions.

Clauses 14 to 27 deal with social protection interventions, and establish the Livelihood Empowerment Against Poverty Management Unit to, among others, manage cash transfer programmes. The Clauses also mandate the Ministry, in collaboration with other entities, to provide social protection support including social assistance, productive and financial inclusion as well as emergency support. Clause 27 provides for the implementation and effective management of the Ghana School Feeding Programme.

Clauses 28 to 31 focus on complementary social services and social protection interventions including education, health and other social assistance programmes such as psychological support for vulnerable persons. Clause 31 prohibits divulgence of beneficiary information without recourse to established legal requirements.

Clause 32 provides for the role of the Ministry of Finance in respect of funding social protection interventions, with particular emphasis on institutionalisation of systems to ensure continued access to funds for support programmes and elimination of wastage in service delivery.

Clauses 33 to 39 deal with the establishment of the Social Protection Fund, which seeks to provide

financial resources to develop, coordinate and implement social protection initiatives and related activities.

Clauses 40 to 45 establish the twelve-member National Social Protection Committee to oversee the effective and efficient implementation of the law.

Clause 46 designates the Social Protection Directorate as the Secretariat for the National Social Protection Committee.

Clauses 47 to 57 deal with coordination and monitoring of social protection interventions at the decentralised level. The Clauses highlight the functions of the Inter-Ministerial Coordinating Committee established in section 204 of the Local Government Act, 2016 (Act 936) and the Regional Coordinating Council established in section 192 of the Local Government Act, 2016 (Act 936).

Clauses 58 to 61 relate to grievances, appeals and case management. The Clauses make provision for the operational manual of the social protection programme to incorporate a complaint and case management mechanisms.

Clauses 62 to 67 cover miscellaneous provisions. The Clauses provide for, among others, allowances for members of the various Committees, and addresses the issue of conflict of interest.

Observations and Recommendations

The Committee made the following observations and recommendations during its deliberations:

Provision of a Legal Framework for Social Protection Programmes

The Committee lauded the continuous efforts of the Ministry of Gender, Children and Social Protection to provide a legal framework for social protection programmes introduced by successive governments over the years. The Committee took cognisance of various attempts to promulgate a social protection law, since the formulation and launch of the Ghana National Social Protection Policy in December, 2015. The Eighth Parliament of the Fourth Republic took decisive steps to pass the Social Protection Bill, 2024; but was unable to do so prior to the expiration of its tenure. The Committee, therefore, urges the House to commit to the expeditious enactment of the Bill into law to facilitate effective management of social protection initiatives, promote accountability and protect the rights of the vulnerable in our society.

Utilisation of Existing Institutional Structures

The Ministry informed the Committee that the Bill aligns with the Local Government Act, 2016 (Act 936), which already establishes the framework for the Social Services Committee at the district assembly

level. The Bill also provides expressly for collaboration among the Ministry of Gender, Children and Social Protection with other sector ministries and entities, thereby reducing the need for establishing parallel structures that may increase administrative cost of delivering social protection services. The implementation of current policies and interventions could, therefore, be leveraged on existing institutional arrangements to avert duplication of functions among various agencies involved in social protection activities.

Impact of Inadequate Funding on Provision of Social Services

The Committee noted with concern, the persistent inadequacy of annual budgetary allocations to the Ministry of Gender, Children and Social Protection for the provision of social services. Inadequate funding of social protection activities impedes accessibility to social services by vulnerable groups and adversely affects the effective discharge of the Ministry's mandate. The Committee recommends, therefore, that the Ministry of Finance reconsiders increasing budgetary allocations to the Ministry of Gender, Children and Social Protection to ensure that the Ministry is well resourced to effectively carry out its mandate, which includes the implementation of social protection programmes and interventions.

Inclusion of Social Protection Measures in National Development Plans and Fiscal Policies

The Committee observed that a conscious effort to include social protection measures in national development plans and fiscal policies was critical to building a resilient and inclusive society. Such an arrangement would reduce poverty by diminishing exposure to vulnerabilities and strengthen the capacity to manage economic and social risks including unemployment, disability and marginalisation. The Committee advocates strongly, therefore, that institutions such as the National Development Planning Commission and the Ministry of Finance develop plans and budgets with due regard to social protection considerations.

Committees of Parliament are, therefore, urged to consider the budgets of Ministries, Departments and Agencies as well as other public entities through a social protection lens, thereby shifting focus from financial allocations to the impact of projects and programmes on the public. This approach would improve oversight of executive actions, engender enhanced accountability and address disparities in the distribution of national resources.

Conclusion

The Committee acknowledges that providing a legal framework for social protection programmes and

policies is necessary to improve accessibility, accountability and equity in the delivery of social services to underprivileged persons in the Ghanaian society. The promulgation of a statute in this regard would, therefore, ensure protection for the socially disadvantaged, and establish institutional frameworks to support economically handicapped persons and individuals affected by national or local emergencies.

The Committee, after careful examination of the Social Protection Bill, 2025, recommends to the House to adopt its report in accordance with article 106(6) of the 1992 Constitution.

Respectfully submitted.

Question proposed

6.03 p.m.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Member, you have the floor.

Mr Nana Osei-Adjei (NPP — New Juaben North): Mr Speaker, your Committee met and discussed a lot of clauses in this Report. The Committee has put together a comprehensive Bill that will actually stand the test of time. This Bill is in consonance with Chapter 6 of the 1992 Constitution, which guarantees the well-being of citizens through the provision of adequate means of livelihood. The Bill is also in sync with the African Union's Social Policy Framework for Africa which

encourages Member States to develop comprehensive social protection policies that address the needs of vulnerable groups, especially children and women.

Mr Speaker, the Bill also aligns itself with the United Nations (UN) Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs). Not only one; it aligns itself with SDG 1, that talks about no poverty; SDG 5, gender equality; and SDG 8, decent work and economic growth. Social protection programmes in Ghana have, over the years, been implemented without the right legal framework. The passage of this Bill into law, therefore, provides a legislative framework to regulate the delivery of social protection services. Mr Speaker, the passage of the law will ensure protection for the socially disadvantaged and support economically handicapped persons affected by national or local emergencies.

Mr Speaker, with these few words, I urge the House to support the hard-working Minister for Gender, Children and Social Protection, the Chairman of the Committee, and the Ranking Member, so that this Report will be accepted for the passage of the Bill.

Mr Speaker, I thank you for the opportunity. [*Hear! Hear!*]

Mr Isaac Boamah-Nyarko (NPP — Effia): Thank you very much, Mr

Social Protection Bill, 2025 — Second Reading

Speaker, for allowing me to comment on the Report before this House.

As I indicated earlier, there is no objection to the need for this House to pass this particular Social Protection Bill. Due to the fact that this Bill, as the Leader of the House indicated, has been promulgated or brought before the Eighth Parliament, but unfortunately it could not be passed and it is before us today.

Mr Speaker, reading the Report, the Bill seeks to promote access to social protection services by chronically poor and vulnerable persons through specific institutional arrangements. One thing I have realised from this particular Bill is that the Bill is providing a legal framework that seeks to protect the interests of the poor and vulnerable in our society, so it is important that we give it a consideration.

Now, from the summary of the provisions in the Bill, when we consider clauses 10 and 11, it speaks to the establishment of national household registry and outlines the functions, which include collection and maintaining relevant data of the non-poor, the poor and the vulnerable individuals. One thing we lack as a country is data on the citizenry, particularly when it comes to who is poor and who is vulnerable, so that when we want to provide national interventions, we target it to that group so that they become proper beneficiaries of the laws that we are passing. So, clauses 10 and 11 is key.

When we consider clause 33 to 39, it speaks to the establishment of a Social Protection Fund to provide financial resources to develop, coordinate and implement social protection initiatives. When we pass the law and there is no funding to support such a laudable initiative, then we will be coming to square one because the Ministry will not be able to provide the needed oversight and the needed support for the poor and the vulnerable. I will be interested in seeing the provisions of the law that speaks to where the funding would come from and whether we have innovative ways of providing that social protection fund to support them.

Mr Speaker, as I wind up, I would like to also comment on clause 58 to 61, which relates to grievances, appeals and case management. It is important that when we deal with social protection, concerns that will come up would have to be properly dealt with and that comes through proper grievance, appeals and case management processes, so that would also be an interesting area to look at.

Mr Speaker, with that said, I want to also support this House in coming together to support the Minister in passing this particular Bill, so that the poor and vulnerable of this country will be properly protected.

Mr Speaker, I thank you for the opportunity.

Mr Shaibu Mahama (NDC — Daboya/Mankarigu): Mr Speaker, thank you very much for the opportunity to lend my support to the Motion on the Floor.

Three key things come out as we work towards social protection and these are implementation of social protection programmes by Government to improve the living conditions of the chronically poor, socially vulnerable and economically at risk persons. Indeed, a legislation will couch out the various modes that these things can be solved.

Mr Speaker, your Committee met and we went through the various clauses, very comprehensive clauses. Indeed, we are confident that the few loopholes that we anticipate may be part of what some Colleagues raised there, will be raised on the Floor.

But clearly, I think that we have done a very good job to the referral that was made to us and I will implore this House to approve it.

Thank you so much, Mr Speaker.

Mr Kwame Anyimadu-Antwi (NPP — Asante Akim Central): Mr Speaker, this is a very important Bill and should have been passed as early as yesterday. Unfortunately, it has been in this House for a long time. It has lapsed from the last term when we did a lot of work on this.

Mr Speaker, there are a lot of things that we need to take into consideration

as a country. Various governments have made an attempt at making an intervention so far as social protection is concerned. I can think of the Livelihood Empowerment Against Poverty (LEAP), School Feeding Programme and a lot of things. There are a lot of vulnerable ones in the society.

Every Member of Parliament here would testify that in his or her constituency, there are vulnerable ones. Therefore, we can conclude that as a nation, we need to do such an intervention. I would urge the Minister—

6.13 p.m.

I am wondering and would borrow the words of Hon Boamah-Nyarko on what he just said that the money to prosecute this policy is what we are looking at and I am sure the Minister for Gender, Children and Social Protection will do well to make sure that we find the money to make sure that we execute this law.

Mr Speaker, I know we are hard-pressed with time, but this a very important Bill and I believe all of us as Members of Parliament will support this Bill for us to prosecute it. Thank you, Mr Speaker.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon James Enu?

Mr James Enu (NDC — Tema West): Thank you very much Mr Speaker for the opportunity. Mr

Social Protection Bill, 2025 — Second Reading

Speaker, I also rise to support the Report of the Committee on Gender, Children and Social Protection on the Social Protection Bill, 2025. Mr Speaker, this Bill is targeted at the vulnerable, the marginalised, the economically-at-risk, the poor among others.

Mr Speaker, I believe that this Bill is long overdue. If you look at our constitutional provisions, particularly in Article 35 and 36 on the directive principles of state policy, it makes provision that the state should be able to provide for such interventions for the citizenry. Mr Speaker, I will refer you to Article 36(1) particularly and it says that:

“The State shall take all necessary action to ensure that national economy is managed in such a manner as to maximize the rate of economic development and to secure the maximum welfare, freedom and happiness of every person in Ghana and to provide adequate means of livelihood and suitable employment and public assistance to the needy”

Mr Speaker, what is also remarkable about this Bill has to do with the fact that it creates for emergency support in terms of local or national emergency for communities and I think this is very remarkable. Mr Speaker, I pray that the House supports the adoption of this Report.

Thank you, Mr Speaker. [*Hear! Hear!*]

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Thank you.

Hon Zuwera, be brief.

Ms Zuwera Mohammed Ibrahimah (NDC — Salaga South): Thank you very much, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity.

Mr Speaker, I rise to support and urge the House to support the passing of this Bill in order to streamline and facilitate the effective delivery of social services to the vulnerable people in Ghana.

Mr Speaker, the Bill seeks to outline the beneficiaries of social services and social intervention and the beneficiaries is quite comprehensive. It includes the disabled, the homeless, and those chronically plagued by poverty are all considered in the Bill. But clause 14 to 27 is actually what makes the Bill very important, in that this clause seeks to establish a unit that will manage the Livelihood Empowerment Against Poverty (LEAP) programme. This programme has been in existence for some time, but clearly, because there has not been a mechanism to manage it properly, there have been a lot of lapses and gaps. With the coming into effect of this management unit, clearly, the activities of LEAP will be streamlined to enable accountability and transparency.

Mr Speaker, with these few words, I want to urge the House to support the Minister for Gender, Children and Social Protection to pass this Bill into law to enable the effective delivery of social services to the people of this country. Thank you very much, Mr Speaker.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Thank you, Hon Member.

Question put and Motion agreed to.

Social Protection Bill, 2025 accordingly read a Second time.

Hon Members, we then turn to page three of today's Order Paper, Motion numbered eight, continuation of the debate.

Hon Members, I will proceed to give the floor to Hon Dominic Aduna Nitiwul. Hon Member, you have 15 minutes.

MOTION

Mid-Year Budget Review, 2025

[Resumption of Debate from Monday, 28/07/25]

Mr Dominic Bingab Aduna Nitiwul (NPP — Bimbilla): Thank you, Mr Speaker. I am very grateful for the opportunity to add my voice to the 2025 Mid-Year Fiscal Review Policy of the Government for the year 2025.

Mr Speaker, I do not intend to speak on too many topics, but right after the economic team has dealt extensively with economic matters, Mr Speaker, you would agree with me that issues of our safety and security are issues that the people of Ghana will want to listen to us and find out what the government has been doing over the last seven months.

Mr Speaker, on page 58 and 59 through to 60 are the pages where the Minister tackles the Ministry of the Interior and Ministry of Defence. Mr Speaker, on page 58, on behalf of the President, the Minister says that:

“Ghana Police Service intensified visibility patrols and traffic management with 1,000 officers deployed across Accra and other Regions. More than 3,500 motorbikes were distributed to enhance community engagement and response time”

Mr Speaker, I will not go further than this, but just to say that the Minister of State in charge of Government Communication should draw the attention of the Minister for Finance that this statement is not true. This government over the last seven months has not provided the police with 3,500 motorbikes. So, the Minister for Finance should expunge this particular statement from this presentation. It is not true.

In fact, Mr Speaker, the last time the police received large numbers of motorbikes was in December 2024. It

was presented by the Minister for National Security and they were 200 motorbikes. In fact, not 200, 1500 motorbikes and 300 pickups were presented in December 2024.

Mr Speaker, after December 2024, the then Minister for National Security left behind for the incoming Government 10 land cruisers, 30 pickups and 200 motorbikes. If there was any distribution, it is these 200 motorbikes, 30 pickups and 10 land cruisers that was distributed. The Government has not distributed any 3,500 motorbikes.

There is a reason I am bringing this point. Mr Speaker, I am saying that the Minister for Finance is not releasing resources to the two Ministers to work. The Minister for the Interior and the Minister for Defence have no money to work. Especially for the Ministry of Defence,

6.23 p.m.

He says that work is ongoing at the Ezinlibo Forward Operating Base, and we all know the importance of it, the Forward Operating Bases, 12 of them in the North. Sadly, not a cedi or a pesewa has been paid to the contractors since 31st December, 2024.

Mr Speaker, if the Minister for Finance is refusing or is unable, for whatever reason, to release funds to the Ministers in charge of security, the only, unfortunately, outcome will be

that there will be insecurity. And it is clear for everybody to see that there is insecurity everywhere today.

In fact, Mr Speaker, today, if one goes to Ashaiman, Tulaku, ask the Hon Member for Ashaiman sitting right there—They killed people in Ashaiman. In Asawase, the constituency of the Minister for the Interior, they killed people there. In fact, Mr Speaker, in the constituency our good Friend, Hon Collins Adomako-Mensah, two people were shot and killed in a moving vehicle. Yesterday at Nima, Mr Speaker, there were six gunshots in Nima.

I can continue counting. I am yet to go to the constituency of my good Friend, the Majority Leader. Mr Speaker, two years ago, the Majority Leader was concerned that he thought the Ministers for Defence and the Interior should have visited Bawku to assess things for themselves.

Majority Leader, I am sorry, the two Ministers have not visited Bawku for seven months. What is he saying about that? They have not come. No Minister, apart from him, the Majority Leader, who is the Member of Parliament, has visited Bawku. The Minister for Communication has not gone there. He was there in the first week when he was not yet Minister. When he became Minister, he has not visited. No Minister. Mr Speaker, not a single Minister.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Nitiwul, why do you choose to answer instead of addressing the Chair?

Mr Nitiwul: I am sorry, Mr Speaker.

But, Mr Speaker, I am saying that the Minister for Finance should release money to the Minister for the Interior and the Minister for Defence, especially the Minister for the Interior. They are suffering. There is no money, and because of that, the security agencies are not able to do what they are supposed to do, to keep all of us safe. If he does not do that, there will be a problem.

Now, Mr Speaker, let me come to Bawku. The Minister of State, Government Communications released a statement stating that the Government has directed the Armed Forces to move from peacekeeping to peace enforcement. I am sorry, we have never had peacekeeping in Ghana. The Ghana Armed Forces have not undertaken peacekeeping duties in Ghana. It has always been part of the internal security arrangements, not peacekeeping. I would advise that he takes out the word “peacekeeping” and insert “internal security duties” because we do not have peacekeeping in Ghana.

But the worse is for the Government to intimate, or to indicate to the people of Ghana, especially the areas in Bawku, that they are going to do peace enforcement. Peace enforcement simply means that, unfortunately, one is going to use military force and coercion to get people to accept peace. I do not think that the people of Ghana, especially

those around the Bawku area or around the North East, are ready for peace enforcement from the men and women of the Ghana Armed Forces.

So I would urge the Government to withdraw that statement and tell the people exactly what they intend to do. Because the conflict in Bawku and its environs is spreading across Ghana. And it is dangerous for all of us. It is not good for all of us. I say that the previous Government, for which I serve, was spending close to GH¢11 million every month to secure the northern part of Ghana. Why is the Minister for Finance refusing to release money to the people? Why? The minimum the Minister can do for Operation Cow Leg, Operation Conquered Fist, the soldiers in Bawku, the police, the immigration, and all of them, is to release resources to the Ministers so that they can give this money to the commanders on the ground to do the job.

I can tell that the professionalism of the armed forces and the police service, as well as the various security services, is top-notch. The entire world knows it. I remember visiting the United Nations Secretary-General, and he said he was giving Ghana two missions: one in Sudan and one in the Central African Republic, because I know that the professionalism of the Ghana Armed Forces and the police service is top-notch. So, they can do the job, but without resources, they will not be able to do the job.

The duty of every government, Mr Speaker, is to provide security for its people. That is the first duty Government needs to perform: to keep her citizens alive. So if the Minister for Finance is refusing to release resources for them, then we are living in dangerous times. And I do not think that it is good for all of us. So I am asking the Minister to change his course over what he has done in the last seven months. Because unfortunately, Bawku is spreading, and it is spreading fast.

Mr Speaker, I do not believe that people down south, to the west and east can wait to experience one quarter of what is happening in those areas. I do not think they want to do that. And if it is spreading down south, to the middle and every part of Ghana, and if we do not take care, it will spread. It is not something that will help us. That is why when the President went there in the first week of his presidency to promise the people that he would resolve the problem; we were all happy and elated to say that he tried to do it. But without resources, he cannot do it.

Mr Speaker, the second matter I want to address is the issue of *galamsey*. *Galamsey* is getting worse.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Nitiwul, ordinarily, we will not entertain a point of order. But you keep on mentioning Bawku, and the Member of Parliament for Bawku is up. So Hon Leader, let me hear you.

Mr Mahama Ayariga: Mr Speaker, ordinarily, I have tried to avoid a discussion of Bawku in this Chamber. I have tried very hard for several months now. I have restrained people, and I have restrained myself. I have refused to discuss Bawku in this Chamber. So I am pleading with the former Minister for Defence, who knows better the situation that he bequeathed to us in Bawku that we are trying to put an end to.

When he says the first time that Bawku is spreading outside, that is not true. Mr Speaker, he can ask the former Minister for the Interior. Before the elections, during his regime, there were shootings in Ashaiman. There were shootings at the railway here. I was the one who got the then Minister for the Interior to go and convene a meeting of all the sites to restrain them from shooting each other. He should go and ask the Minister for the Interior. So please, he should not talk as if this thing started seven months ago.

We are very confident that we will bring an end to the problem in Bawku—[*Hear! Hear!*]
—I am very confident, and we will bring it to an end in a lasting manner. We can choose to be populist, but we do not want to be populist. We are taking all the hits because we want to take our time and solve it once and for all.

6.33 p.m.

This is a problem that started as far back as 1957. So please, do not try to politicise Bawku. Just talk about the Budget.

We can discuss the financing of the Defence and Interior sectors, but I beg you, we are at a very critical stage in Bawku. I do not think that we should use this platform, this Chamber, to inflame passions. I plead with you. I have restrained myself for several months now.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Mr Nitiwul, let me plead with you, let us veer from Bawku.

Mr Nitiwul: Mr Speaker, but where is the politicisation in what I said? I am telling the Majority Leader what is happening in his own backyard.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, due to the sensitive nature.

Mr Nitiwul: I am telling him what is happening in his own backyard.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Mr Nitiwul? [*Uproar*]

Mr Nitiwul: Mr Speaker, we have all been in this Chamber. He was the one who regularly —

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Mr Nitiwul, be guided. Veer off Bawku.

Mr Nitiwul: But he was the one who regularly talked about Bawku in this Chamber.

Mr Speaker, I said to him, he should go and ask the people of Bawku, who politicised the Bawku issue, whether it is me or them. But I

will leave it at that. We all want peace in Bawku. I am happy he says that the issue did not start today. So it is not me or us who gave him that problem. It has always been there.

Secondly, as I said, he knows my views about Bawku. He knows how passionate we have always been about Bawku. He knows the discussions I have held with him about Bawku. He knows how I want the issue in Bawku to be resolved and he knows that issues about Bawku have never flared up more than it has now.

Mr Speaker, as for shooting at Ashaiman or other areas, it has always been happening. But this is the first time that we can directly link it to Bawku. There are two differences. It has been happening. In 2009, there was shooting at Agbogbloshie. We never linked it to Bawku. It has always been happening, but I will leave it at that. All I am saying is that, Government should give the Minister for Defence and the Minister for Finance resources to resolve the Bawku matter. The Minister for Defence and the Minister for the Interior should visit the places. All I am saying is that the 3,500 motorbikes they are saying they gave to the Minister for the Interior [*Expunged by order of Mr Speaker*]. All I am saying is that the Minister for Finance —

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, withdraw the word —

Mr Nitiwul: Mr Speaker, I withdraw that word immediately. I withdraw it. But I am saying that it is not a true thing. That is all I am saying. It never happened.

Mr Speaker, *galamsey* has become worse over the last seven months. I will tell the Minister for Finance the same thing. The Minister for Finance should release money, resources, to the Minister for Lands and Natural Resources to be able to fight the *galamsey* menace. Where is the state of emergency they asked for? They asked for state of emergency. They asked for the repeal of Legislative Instruments (L.I.). Why are they not doing these things? What has changed? The other day, I heard the Minister of State, Government Communications, trying to change the stance of Government. Listen, they made promises to the people of Ghana, so they should follow those promises. I believe that if they do, things will be better.

Mr Isaac Adongo (NDC — Bolgatanga Central): Mr Speaker, I rise to thank the Minister for Finance for the presentation of the Mid-Year Budget Review.

Mr Speaker, we promised the people of Ghana to be responsible in managing this economy. We promised the people of Ghana that the days of reckless expenditure are gone. When they come here and they say that the Minister is not spending and that he should give money to the Minister for Defence, Mr Speaker,

they should know that in managing the economy, we spend according to the Budget. We do not spend because somebody wants us to spend. We spend because there is a Budget with an Appropriation that is before us and the Minister has made it very clear that he has spent GH¢114 billion so far.

So when there is a government where the Minister for Finance has spent GH¢114 billion, that does not include the wage bill. It does not include the moneys that he collects at the end of every month, yet the Minister has spent GH¢114 billion out of a Budget of GH¢169 billion. Clearly, the Minister is being responsible. The Minority Side had a government where, as a matter of fact, by this time, they were still counting to get 125 Ministers. We were in this country when the appointed Ministers were more than their people sitting over there, and they want that to be repeated because they are used to that. No.

Mr Speaker, when I listened to the Minister for Finance and I looked at what he has done with the economy in seven months, it appeared to me that the economy was being managed as though we had some level 100 sociology students who were experimenting with our economy and messing everybody up. If they think that they will have a Government that will sink money in the name of National Cathedral, it will not happen. If they think that they will still have a Minister for Finance who will spend US\$5 billion in five months, it will not happen.

Mr Speaker, we are managing this economy to develop a country based on a sustainable path and the records are there for everybody to see. I wish to reiterate that no matter how many times they repeat an untruth, it will not metamorphose into the truth. That, even when they have read all the things that the Minister has stated and enumerated as his expenditures for the period, they still want to climb on top of the hills and shout that we are not spending and hope that somehow that will metamorphose into the truth; it will not happen.

Mr Speaker, I have heard people say that the gains that we are experiencing now in the economy is because of policies they implemented. How do the policies that could not turn the economy around when they were there suddenly be performing magic when they are gone? It simply means that their own policies feared their leadership. *[Laughter]* That their policies failed to perform when they were sitting there and when they disappeared, they became friends with H.E John Mahama and made the economy to perform. Please, they should go and tell that to class one children and not the people of Ghana.

Mr Speaker, the truth is that building a National Cathedral does not turn the economy around. The truth is that running a government of 125 Ministers does not turn the economy around. The truth is that when they print GHC80 billion as if they are “yahoo” boys, it does not turn the economy around. It is concrete

policies that turn the economy around. We are demonstrating that we do not need to be doing very big slogans. What we are doing is that we are going back to the basics. We are going back to the basics that they refused and decided to cut their coat as if they were living in a king’s paradise. No, resources are limited and they must be used judiciously.

Mr Speaker, when we have a Government that within seven months, has moved the inflation from 23 per cent to 13.7 per cent, they should begin trooping to the Ministry of Finance to learn from Dr Cassiel Ato Forson on how he did that.

6.43 p. m.

When we have a Minister who, in just a matter of seven months or even less, moved the exchange rate from where it was to where it is today, should they not be going for tutorials? And instead of going for tutorials, they are busy holding press conferences. At the last count, they have already held 58 press conferences; *ekwan no ware o!* Four years and counting, they will get tired. But I want to tell them to consider what they see as a relationship between monetary policy and fiscal policy which they failed to anchor.

Today, when we realised that we are going to have a heated economy and inflation would sour, what we did was that monetary policy and fiscal policy agreed that the cost of managing excessive liquidity should

be dealt with by the Bank of Ghana. So, you would realise that the Bank of Ghana was aggressive in mobilising and mopping up excess liquidity. The reason was if they allowed the fiscal side to do that, we were going to have a very high interest cost and they will not have space within the budget. So, you would have noticed that fiscal policy was borrowing at slightly lower rates, so that we can contain it in the Budget, while monetary policy was beginning to mop up the excess liquidity.

Mr Speaker, now, we have come to a point where we believe that we must begin to tilt the balance, so that monetary policy is solvent. We must be efficient in delivering monetary policy to stabilise prices and what we do is to ensure that the revenues that we generate out of monetary policy are enough to meet the cost of delivering monetary policy. So, today, one would see that the Bank of Ghana is now borrowing on 56 days at a rate of less than 15 per cent. What does that mean? It means that we are moving towards monetary policy in monetary policy at the Bank of Ghana and the Minister for Finance is also containing interest costs within the fiscal space. That is what has led to what we are seeing.

We also knew that, with the success of the Gold Board, there will be a lot of cedi liquidity as we turn dollars into cedis to buy gold and the small-scale miners would get a lot of cedis; those cedis will lead to inflation, so we must begin to whip

those cedis back into the vault at the Bank of Ghana. That is why monetary policy is aggressively pursuing tighter monetary policy. When they were there, all they did was to simply go to the vault, print the money, and dump them. And they are saying that they cannot see a policy that is anchoring inflation. Simply put, they do not even understand Ghana's inflation-targeting framework. If they understood, they would have seen that there is a concrete and deliberate attempt to try and mop up excess liquidity and ensure that, in doing that, inflation and the exchange rates are stabilised to move towards improving interest to the business community.

For those of them who do not know, interests at the moment for businesses are dictated by two things: the first one is the Ghana Reference Rate which is what they used to call the Base Rate in those days. Now, we do not have base rate; we have Ghana Reference Rate. The Ghana Reference Rate is calculated through a weighted average of the treasury bill rate: take 40 per cent of the treasury bill rate, 40 per cent of monetary policy rate, and then take another 20 per cent of treasury bill rate to be able to get the reference rate. What that means is that if treasury bill rates are going down, then the reference rate is also going down; then, we are affecting the cost of borrowing by the average Ghanaian. It also means that if policy rates are going down, then, eventually, we are also bringing down the cost of borrowing and helping businesses to grow and the signaling is very clear.

Mr Speaker, today, one can see that when the Central Bank is borrowing, it is doing so at a lower rate, which means that there is a signaling that policy rates may come down. If policies come down, what it then means is that one can now borrow at a lower rate, expand businesses, and grow the economy. These people brought in people who we do not know where they learnt Economics. All that they knew was to come here and quote the Bible—[**Some Hon Members of the Majority:** Oh! Oh!]
—But when they sat here the last time, I am sure they were surprised that this is the Ato Forson they sat here with who is a member of the NDC, where there are brains. So, please, for those who are still holding press conferences, we are ready to put them into a classroom and teach them how we are doing it. We are making sure that we are taking care of inflation, exchange rate, and interest rates.

Mr Speaker, I would like to emphasise that we have not even started implementing the Big Push Programme. We are in this House wanting to do what they never did for eight years. The Public Financial Management Act, under section 33(2), says that one cannot commit the state to any multi-year transactions unless it is approved by Parliament. For eight years, because of their careless and reckless attitude, they never came here. They never came here for multi-year commitment. For the first time, the Minister for Finance came here and

began to rewrite the wrong, so we are now managing our commitment and making sure that we would to be reckless in our expenditure.

Mr Speaker, they say, “book no lie”. The international community is very proud of Ghana. When they turned Ghana into a laughing stock and managed our issuer credit by the rating agencies into a junk status, today, Ghana’s issuer credit is not C or C+ as they had, it is B-. [*Hear! Hear!*]

Mr Speaker, that is a sign of the fruit of economic development and progress. Please, those who have been doing press conferences should be kind enough to quote Fitch and tell the people of Ghana that they are masters of managing junk economies and that their only success was to run Ghana into a bankruptcy and they celebrated bankruptcy. And when they decided to tell the whole world that when they borrow, they do not pay—*Wɔfa nono, ɔgye a, ɔntua*; to wit, *killer ntua*.

So, when you have a Government that is as responsible as we are, we know that when we borrow, we have to pay and the Minister has listed the Eurobond coupons that he has paid. He has paid the DDEP that they left behind and they are still saying he is not spending. Why? Do they want him to throw money into that hole? Or do they want him to start another PDS? Do they want him to become a reckless manager of the economy? Certainly, we were not trained to be reckless in the management of the

economy. We are ensuring that when we decided to manage this economy, we did so to ensure that we anchor fiscal sustainability and our external environment is now very sustainable—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, conclude.

Mr Adongo: Mr Speaker, the people of Ghana miss the mockery that they used to bring to them; those days that, anytime Ghanaians mentioned them, they went home crying; that is what they miss. But we will make sure that they keep them where they are and never come back into government.

Thank you very much, Mr Speaker.
[*Hear! Hear!*]

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, it is now the turn of Hon Ntim Fordjour. You have the floor and he is speaking for 15 minutes.

The Second Deputy Speaker to take the Chair.

6.52 p.m. — [HON SECOND DEPUTY SPEAKER, MR ANDREW ASIAMAH AMOAKO, IN THE CHAIR]

Rev John Ntim Fordjour (NPP — Assin South): Mr Speaker, I thank you for the opportunity and I rise to comment on the Motion numbered 8 that this House approves the Mid-Year Review of the Budget Statement and Economic Policy of the

Government of Ghana for the Financial Year 2025 and, in so doing, to indicate how Ghanaians feel disappointed in the Mid-Year Budget that was presented.

6.53 p.m.

Mr Speaker, my good Friend and respected Colleague, Hon Adongo, can wax lyrical about all macroeconomics theories, but what he must be reminded of is that the spare part dealers are disappointed—[*Hear! Hear!*—because they made a promise to them, but they have deceived them and they are disappointed. Farmers have been disappointed.

At the time their Minister for Finance and Minister for Food and Agriculture were in opposition, they promised Ghanaian cocoa farmers GH¢7,000 per bag of cocoa. It did not find expression in the first Budget, they thought that it would find expression in the Mid-Year Budget Review, but it was 419.

Students are disappointed. When the President of the Republic, President Mahama, during his rounds and campaign promised students that he would send remittances straight to their headmasters to go to the market and buy them *aponkye* to do *aponkye nkrakra* for them, he sent it for just two weeks. After that a letter was sent to them that no money will be sent, but they will buy the things and bring it to the headmasters.

Mr Speaker, market women have been disappointed. The NDC promised them the Women's Development Bank and the expectation was that, truly, about GH¢800 million minimum capital was going to be given to the bank, only for them to hear in the Budget that it was GH¢51 million which cannot even open a microfinance and the women are even still expecting this money to be released.

They can deceive all the sectors of the economy, but security is one sector that we would have thought that this Government would have taken more seriously because our peace, security and public safety is all we have. Therefore, even when they have kept Ghanaians hungry, all that Ghanaians expected was that they would keep their homes, streets and schools secure. But what do we see? We are seeing growing insecurity in this country because the Minister for Defence and the Minister for the Interior and all their agencies are starving. They are starving the public safety sector of releases of common goods and services.

Mr Speaker, before 2025, from 2022 to 2024, consistently, Ghana was ranked the second most peaceful country in the sub-region, even in Africa. But in less than seven months, we have dropped the ranking in all the notable international rankings because the insecurity of Ghana is on the rise. We talk about sporadic shooting, people getting missing and sadly being found dead. It is very sad.

Every life matters, so we expected that in the Mid-Year Budget Review, when the first Budget was ailing and failing, there would be hope and prioritising of the public safety sector. What we saw was that there was no inspiration at all. There was no assertive commitment even to prioritising financing into our public safety sector.

Mr Speaker, our Ministry of Defence is our military. As hardworking and formidable as they are within the sub-region and highly reputed over the world, sadly, they are the most underfunded military in the sub-region. Even the military of Togo has more funding than the budget allocation of President Mahama to our military. La Côte d'Ivoire, Burkina Faso, Niger and all our neighbours have more budgetary funding than our military.

So, when we expected that some US\$1.2 billion would be released to the Ministry of Defence to retool and equip them, to get additional fighter jets, to be able to have additional armoured personnel carriers, additional ammunitions, additional drones for surveillance and curb the rising insecurity, they have done the Ministry of Defence 419.

Mr Speaker, the matter is so serious because, as we speak, every Ministry and every agency, even the Ghana National Fire Service (GNFS), Ghana Prisons Service, Ghana Police Service, Narcotics Control Commission and the National Disaster Management

Organisation (NADMO) are suffering. Then, in the early part of June, we saw on the front page of the *Ghanaian Times* President Mahama announcing an amount of GH¢1 billion to retool security agencies.

My Colleagues and I on the Committee on Defence and Interior have visited almost all the security agencies. Wherever we go, we ask them, *na sika no wo hen? Omo se* 419. Nobody knows where that GH¢1 billion is. Even that amount of GH¢1 billion, Mr Speaker, is so inadequate for one particular security agency. So, when he even promised that across all the security agencies, the expectation was that he would just give that out while they wait for the major release.

As we speak, the National Identification Authority (NIA) is so vulnerable that, perish the thoughts, if there should be any cyber-attack on the security operations centre, there will be no alerts and all our database and all our Ghana cards which we use for bank transactions will be wiped off because the US\$14 million which NIA needs to be able to pay for their cyber protection fees has not been released to them; they do not have it. NIA is suffering.

As we speak, my Colleagues on the other Side, all the moneys they have in the bank that they expect to use their Ghana cards to go and cash, if there should be any attacks on their server, all their moneys will be locked. Even US\$14 million, they are not able to release.

Mr Speaker, today, as we speak, they have starved our brothers and sisters in all our prisons. They feed them on GH¢0.60 a meal, that is rather regrettable. We are in 2025 and President Mahama is feeding our brothers and sisters in prison on GH¢0.60 meal. How much do we even give? How much do we even spend on our pets? But we are expending only GH¢0.60 a meal on our fellow human beings in prison.

Mr Speaker, the growing insecurity we see is so terrible. Our security services: our police, armed forces, immigration service, fire service, and prisons services are all very competent. They are looking for budgetary allocations and releases. This Government is starving our security agencies and expecting our security to decline and degenerate. I do not know the unfortunate thing they are waiting to happen.

Mr Speaker, the Bawku matter is very sensitive and we on this Side will resist every temptation to politicise the matter. As a matter of fact, we will not toe the line of our Brother's, NDC, in parliament when they were in opposition. We will be extremely circumspective and sensitive to the plight of our brothers and sisters within the Bawku zone.

Mr Speaker, more than ever before, this is the time the Government must not turn their backs on the Bawku crisis. This is the time that we expect the critical logistical needs that the security agencies require to be

released to them to equip them to adequately contain the situation. This is because every Ghanaian is concerned about the development and situation in Bawku and we all pray that, one day, there will be lasting peace. Our hearts and sympathies go to all those who are suffering and to all those who have lost their loved ones. Mr Speaker, they did politics with it, but we will not do politics with it.

Mr Speaker, on *galamsey*, our Brothers on the other Side went around various rivers and fetched water in bottles, but, today, they are not able to go and fetch water in bottles because of the turbidity of those rivers, so they cannot. They may have to use shovels to fetch the water and put in the cups.

Today, *galamsey* has moved from being an environmental threat into a criminal enterprise with apparatchiks of the ruling Government, NDC, scrambling for sites. Yet, when the Ghana Police Service and the Ghana Armed Forces asked for adequate budgetary allocation to be able to fight head on, they chose to rather starve the Ghana Armed Forces and the Ghana Police Service to appoint river guards who have no weapons and are always doing all kinds of content on TikTok.

7.03 p.m.

They chose to rather starve the Ghana Armed Forces and the Ghana Police Service to appoint river guards who have no weapons and are always doing all kinds of content on TikTok. That is the resort of this Government

and that is an indication of their lack of commitment in addressing this matter.

Mr Speaker on narcotics, a few months ago, we invited the Minister for the Interior before this very House and asked him why he has not procured narcotic detection scanners to be installed at the airport and various ports across the country because all of them are broken down. He said that indeed it is a priority, but where is the cash to buy them? Today, at the airport, cocaine can easily pass through, cannabis can easily pass through and all kinds of narcotics and illicit substances can easily pass through because our narcotics detection scanners are broken down. Instead of the NDC Government, President Mahama, and the Minister for Finance to prioritise funding these critical installations, they are starving Narcotics Control Commission.

Mr Speaker, in conclusion, they can do politics with all sectors, starve all sectors, but when they begin to starve the security sector and the public safety sector, they are plunging this country into a reckless situation, a situation that later no amount of billions can restore. Therefore, we are urging the President and the Minister for Finance to prioritise funding of our public safety sector and our security agencies to enable them secure this country and to ensure that every Ghanaian will continue to feel safe as they felt some two or three years ago. Every Ghanaian will feel safe in their school and know that two

weeks to WASSCE preparation, they will not have anything to worry about. That they will wake up in this country knowing that they will not be missing and a few days later their bodies will be found somewhere. That in this country, we will not have people wielding guns all over our water bodies in the name of *galamsey* under the era of NDC, because they know that our security agencies have been rendered underfunded and helpless and rather river guards have been engaged.

Mr Speaker, they must not shirk their financial responsibility. They must do what is right and needful and stop starving the Ghana Police Service, Ghana Armed Forces, Ghana Immigration Service, Ghana Fire Service, Narcotics Control Commission and the National Disaster Management Organisation (NADMO). Today, as we are even in rainy season, when one goes to NADMO warehouse, the person would not find a single relief item. For seven months now, they have not even released money to NADMO even for one roofing sheet. They have not released money for even one bale of *obroni wawu*. They do not have any money at all and yet NDC is saying that we should clap for them and that they have goodwill. The goodwill they claim and tout is shrouded in their shirking of financial responsibility and in protecting lives. If for nothing at all, they should remember some 6.3 million voters voted for them; they should prioritise their security and safety and release funding to the Ministry of Defence,

Ministry of the Interior and all their agencies to keep the security of this country.

I thank you very much Mr Speaker.
[Hear! Hear!]

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Thank you very much. It is now the turn of Hon Nikyema Billa Alamzy.

Hon Member, are you a Deputy Ranking Member?

Mr Alamzy Nikyema Billa: 10 minutes—[Laughter]

Mr Speaker, it is on the paper as 10 minutes.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: No, I want to know. They have written 5 minutes, so I want to know?

Mr Nikyema Billa: No, I am a Deputy.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Are you a Deputy? Deputy of?

Mr Nikyema Billa: Member.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Alright.

Mr Nikyema Billa: Mr Speaker, it is 10 minutes that they gave me.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: If you are a Deputy Ranking Member, it is 10 minutes.

Mr Alamzy Nikyema Billa (NDC — Chiana-Paga): Mr Speaker, our second colonial masters, what are they saying? They were not even here. What are they debating on? Speculations? No!

Mr Speaker, there is a maxim, that *nemo dat quod non habet* which means you cannot give what you do not have. I was not even expecting that their Side would come and debate. But it has become their habit. If they are not demonstrating, they are petitioning. If they are not petitioning, they are walking out. Mr Speaker, please tell them to centralise. If not that, they will soon go to Auntie Naa and complain.

Mr Speaker, the innovative leadership that we are seeing today was as a result of a prophecy from Nana Akufo-Addo. During his last days as President, he was asked, “how are you going to fix this economy?” He said “a new leader will come and fix the economy”. And the new leader is the pragmatic His Excellency John Dramani Mahama. It was then that I realised that Akufo-Addo would have been a prophet than a President—*[Uproar]*—Mr Speaker, probably he would have been a senior prophet at Agrada’s Ministry.

Mr Speaker, as a Member of the Committee on Education, we went round on a fact-finding mission. We realised that infrastructure is a problem for all schools. The infrastructure that we have at our very own second cycle institutions, if they

are not stalled, they are uncompleted. So, I was very happy, and I am still happy when the Budget indicated to us that GETFund is finally uncapped. That means we will be having dedicated funds for other programmes, especially the Free SHS which they messed up. Mr Speaker, today, our students will not go home because of inadequate food or shortage of food.

Mr Speaker, today, I am very happy. Always, I have been sitting here thinking of how I am going to fix the roads of my people. I am running a rural Constituency, that is Chiana-Paga Constituency. I do not have a single tarred road. When I was campaigning, wherever I go, they will tell me that they do not have roads. I said I will fix it when I win. I thought it was easy. When I go, they say they do not have bridges and I said I will fix it. But I got here and the reality dawned on me that I might not be able to fix the roads. But I was very happy when it was indicated here that 166 constituencies that are in dire need of roads will be taken care of by the Road Maintenance Trust Fund. I am sure whether rain or shine, my constituency will be part of it. So, I want to thank the Minister for Roads and Highways for introducing innovative ideas like this.

They are here talking about Gold Board and comparing it with Gold for Oil. How can they compare innovation with redundancy? They can never compare Gold Board with Gold for Oil. For Gold for Oil, they

concentrated on one industry; the oil industry. But the oil industry is not the only industry that we have in Ghana.

7.13 p.m.

Mr Speaker, Gold Board has enabled us to appreciate the cedi by 42 per cent. When they are comparing Gold Board with the Gold for Oil, the latter was doing better trade. Is it today we stopped doing better trade? They sent gold and brought in oil. What of the manufacturing sector? Where will they get dollar from? So that is redundancy. They cannot compare it with the innovative Gold Board we have. *[Hear! Hear!]*

Mr Speaker, joy is coming. *[Uproar]* The No-Fees Stress Initiative is an innovative idea.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, I came to the seat with the list and the time allotted to each Member so that is what I am going by. *[Uproar]*

Mr Matthew Nyindam: Mr Speaker, let us respect the rules we set for ourselves. The fact that you have a list in front of you does not negate what we are about saying, because we all agreed that if you are a Ranking Member, Vice Chairperson and a Chairperson, you are entitled to 15 minutes. If you are a Deputy, you are entitled to 10 minutes. All other Members have five minutes.

So, in what capacity is the Hon Member speaking? *[Uproar]*

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Majority Leader?

Hon Members, I have already granted him the 10 minutes. Please let him finish. *[Uproar]*

But Hon Members, for the rest, I am not just going to go by the time allotted to the list, because I see some of them as Hon Members and the time allotted to them is 10 minutes so I think we are going to work on that. So, Hon Member, just finish it up.

Mr Nikyema Billa: Mr Speaker, thank you very much. As I said initially, joy is coming. The No-Fees Stress Initiative is a brilliant idea. For the first time, all our first-year students are not supposed to pay school fees. If you can remember, there was a provision of GH¢499.8 million. Out of that provision, Government has released GH¢300 million to the Student Loan Trust Fund and it is for 100,000 students.

Mr Speaker, *alawa oo alawa*. As I am talking to you now, the nursing and teacher trainees have received all allowances that are due them up to date from January to June and from now, we will be paying them promptly. Every month, they will receive their allowance.

Mr Speaker, I want to end by reminding my Colleagues from the other Side that Ghana's school feeding programme is currently feeding 4,231,059 pupils. So, my Colleagues from the other Side said

Mid-Year Budget Review, 2025

that we are not seeing the benefit of the depreciation of the dollar. One thing is that businessmen do not take into consideration what goes on when it comes to pricing. Their concern is that they want to maximise profits. So, as at the time the Hon Minister met them, they said they could not reduce the prices of their goods but with time, when they bring in new products, they would definitely reduce their prices.

Mr Speaker, we were all in this country – All the arguments they have been doing, they have never talked about corruption. That means corruption is at its minimal. We were all in this country when US\$2 million was given for SkyTrain. *[The Hon Member spoke the Akan language]* Mr Speaker, relying on Order 63, to wit “where is the SkyTrain?” *[Laughter]*

Mr Speaker, the Pwalugu Multi-Purpose Dam —

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, begin to wind up please.

Mr Nikyema Billa: Mr Speaker, US\$12.99 million, not even a brick or sand. *[NPP mo aye bi oo]*

Mr Speaker, I will conclude by thanking you very much for giving me this time to debate on the Mid-Year Review.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, it is now the turn of Hon Alexander Agyare. He is a Deputy Ranking Member and entitled to 10 minutes.

Mr Alexander Agyare (NPP—Kade): Thank you, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity to comment on the Mid-Year Budget Review. I quickly want to take you to page 23 of the Budget Review. As our Colleagues on the other Side keep asking, what did we leave behind? Our Colleagues ask as if nothing was left behind. I take you to 129 of page 23 and I read:

“Gross International Reserves reached US\$11.12 billion by June 2025, covering 4.8 months of imports, up from US\$8.98 billion in December 2024, equivalent to 4.0 months of import cover.”

Mr Speaker, this means that US\$8.5 billion of import cover was left behind. This is what I want Colleagues to know that something was left behind. So, as you keep asking what we left behind, there was something which they added on.

Mr Speaker, let me quickly take you back to page 65, paragraph 452 which also says that the Gold Board brought in US\$5 billion so if we left behind US\$8.9 billion as gross reserve and the Gold Board now brought in US\$5 billion, then it means that it is supposed to be more than the US\$11.12 billion recorded in this Mid-Year Budget. My question to the Hon Minister for Finance is that how come US\$8.9 billion plus US\$5 billion is giving us US\$11.12 billion?

Mr Speaker, thank you so much. Hon Colleagues keep talking about the exchange rate. If anybody from

our Side gets up, my Colleagues from the Other Side keep saying “exchange rate”. Now, my question is that we are all here. What is the exchange rate for today? Who knows the exchange rate for today? Now the Bank of Ghana is talking about 10.43. The commercial banks are talking about over 10.8. And now you go to the roadside, you are talking about over 12.7. Now the individuals with the dollars are also talking about different rates. So, my question is, what is the actual rate? Nobody knows the actual rate.

Mr Speaker, coming to work today, I called my bankers to find out the availability of the dollar if one wants to transfer for business. And for your information, Colleagues in this House, it takes three weeks with your own money in your account to be transferred if you want to use it for transaction.

7.23 p.m.

So, Mr Speaker, imagine Christmas is coming and importers are planning to buy. If only the transfer would take three weeks— And I know it has just started—Very soon it will be one month or more. So, if transfer takes three weeks and now our shipment is going to take six weeks, then it means that importers who are expecting to bring in goods into this country and sell them in December should start with their transfer now.

Mr Speaker, what am I trying to say? All I am saying is that, the current rate given by the Bank of

Ghana is artificial because they give rates that people cannot access and they still sit here and talk about what is on the paper. This is not by the book value. Mr Speaker, we are not talking about the book value; we are talking about the reality. So now what we are saying is that, yes, enough of the artificial, enough of pumping money in just to sustain the cedi. Let the cedi stay at its own value. This is my advice to the Minister for Finance.

Mr Speaker, now my senior Colleague Adongo, who is unfortunately not here, said we are saying that the Minister for Finance is not spending. Yes, that is what we are saying, that they are not spending. Then Hon Adongo said that they spend on what they have budgeted for. So, if they spend on what they budgeted for, they have so many programmes that they introduced in March, and we expect them to spend on these programmes. That is what the Minister is not spending on and that is what we are talking about. We are not talking about new things; we are talking about their own programmes that they are not spending on. They fail to spend on their programmes, and they come and ask, what the inflation is?

Mr Speaker, when they talk of inflation being 13 per cent and lending rate being 27 per cent, how does it work? This does not work. If one goes to my Constituency, and one goes to the market and tells the market woman that inflation has gone down to 13 per cent, it does not work with

Mid-Year Budget Review, 2025

them. We were all in this House when we had Colleagues come in here to talk about the size of a ball of kenkey and at the time, the size of a ball of kenkey was GH¢3.00. Today, the same size is between GH¢5.00 to GH¢7.00.

Mr Speaker, over the weekend, I tried to buy a tuber of yam and to my surprise, it cost GH¢7.00. The women here go to the market and then come here and want to talk about book values. Ghanaians are no longer interested in what is happening in the book. They are interested in what is happening on the market.

Mr Speaker, a bottle of water, which used to be GH¢28.00 is GH¢36.00 today, as I speak. I do not know what kind of water Colleagues buy, but what I am saying is that, a bottle of water which used to be GH¢28.00 is now GH¢36.00. This is what Ghanaians are going through, so Ghanaians expect that if exchange rate has come down and if inflation is low, then they want to feel it in their pockets.

Ghanaians are talking about the power of the cedi. Now, they have the cedi getting its strength. They are boasting about it, but how much cedi do we use to buy items? The prices of items have not changed. The purchasing power is what we are talking about. We are not talking about inflation; we are talking about the purchasing power.

Mr Speaker, agriculture grew by 6.6 per cent, industry also grew by 3.4 per cent and the manufacturing area also recorded 6.6 per cent. What I am saying is that, Colleagues must not harvest from where they have not sown. They have not invested anything in agriculture. I remember that in the main Budget, we criticised the amount invested in agriculture and the industrial sector. All we were pleading with the Minister was for the Budgetary allocation to be increased in the Mid-year Budget and we are not seeing any increment in the Budgetary allocation of the agricultural and the industrial sectors, yet we are recording growth. Where did they get the growth from?

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Agyare, please, begin to wind up.

Mr Agyare: We have to give credit to efforts that was made by the NPP Government because we are enjoying today and talking about increase in various sectors because of the good foundation the NPP Government left behind—*[Uproar]*—We took the dollar from 14 and now we are talking about a rate we do not even know. If the dollar should be less—

[Hear! Hear!]

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, I plead with you, it will be very unfortunate sitting here and you cannot hear anything. Please, let us respect ourselves and at least, be quiet to listen to our Colleagues. It will

come to your turn. You will also make your comment, please.

So, it is now the turn of Hajia Ayamba. Hajia, you have 10 minutes.

Hajia Ayamba: Mr Speaker, I am a Ranking Member. I am not a Deputy Ranking Member.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: You are Ranking of which Committee?

Hajia Ayamba: Committee on Chieftaincy, Culture and Religious Affairs.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: But you cannot be a Ranking Member of the Committee on Chieftaincy, Culture and Religious Affairs.

Hajia Ayamba: I cannot be a Ranking Member in Committee on Chieftaincy, Culture and Religious Affairs?

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Yes, Committee on Chieftaincy, Culture and Religious Affairs is chaired by the Majority Side. It is here. Alright, then you have gotten it right.

Hajia Ayamba: So, Mr Speaker, I have 15 minutes?

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Yes, if that is the case.

Hajia, your time starts now.

Hajia Laadi Ayii Ayamba (NDC — Pusiga): Thank you, Mr Speaker, and thank you for the opportunity for me to associate myself with the Mid-Year Fiscal Policy Review, 2025, Budget Statement and Economic Policy of the Government of Ghana, ably led by His Excellency John Dramani Mahama, and presented by Hon Cassiel Ato Baah Forson. He is actually forcing. He is someone who is actually forcing, and we are seeing it.

Mr Speaker, is it not interesting that our Colleagues on the other Side have that energy, power, and the guts to come and argue and debate when they actually refused to sit in? I do not know how they are even debating. I do not know what they listened to that they have come to debate with us. I am surprised. We are only in the seventh month after we have taken over power from the Minority Side and not any other persons, the same people, and we have some of them who were here. And today, they sit here and tell us how to govern this country. Where were they and what were they doing? Did they forget that they were in governance?

7.33 p. m.

Mr Speaker, in this country, we really do not have enough food. The Minister for Food and Agriculture brought plantain to the Ministry and was selling it to people; where was it from? Was it only from Accra or the Ministry? Even if they took Accra alone, how many people could have

got that plantain? Today, they are saying the NDC Government is not releasing money. They taunted the issue of decentralisation and district assemblies. How did it end? They did nothing. The moneys have been released; today, the assembly members, including their own people, who they want to say are their members, are receiving allowances at the district assemblies and I think that is a major factor that they all need to appreciate.

Mr Speaker, we were seated here in this same Chamber when the issue of the Pwalugu Dam was brought up. If one goes there, it is very interesting. The stones that were picked from the same community, lined up and painted that it is the route leading to the dam have finally become brown, black, yellow and green because there is nothing there except 120 blocks that were moulded and put there and the contractor took not less than US\$11 million. Mr Speaker, where is that money? Where is the contractor? What happened?

Mr Speaker, the Walewale watermelon factory—Today, we have a lot of watermelons getting rotten along the route there and the farmers are suffering. The women are suffering and some children who even had to stop school and farm for watermelon cannot even sell it because, at that place, a very big watermelon is sold at about, say, GH¢10, Mr Speaker. And, today, they are telling us we are not releasing

money after their assemblymen are taking allowances?

Mr Speaker, an amount of US\$2 million were paid out for a sky train. It is interesting that they had not even finished with the train on the ground and they were talking about the sky train. On which rail? Where? And who brought that? Mr Speaker, it is very interesting. Sometimes, it is nice to listen to people say whatever they want to say.

Mr Speaker, an amount of US\$52 million for a very big hole that nobody is interested in that is being referred to as a cathedral—That is the money they spent, but, today, they are saying that there is no money. That is the money that would have helped, so I will tell them and let them understand where the money has gone. Corruption was one of the highest things and US\$20,000 each was being paid at the seat of government for seats. They never said anything. All scandals were cleared.

Today, they talk about roads and every single person, after they have left their home, even if they will not even drive their car into their house, knows that roads are important and crucial. And that everybody needs road; even if one is a bicycle rider, they need roads. Today, we have seen a litany of roads, yet, Mr Speaker, it is interesting that our Colleagues on the other Side are saying that we are working on old roads. If they did not work on those roads, used the taxpayers' money and left it halfway,

do they want it to be left uncompleted? I said definitely no and that is the best response that they can get. And that is what we are doing because we are reasonable; we are for the people; we are by the people, and we are interested in the people. So, we must do it.

So, if they asked about my road, I have the Bolgatanga-Bawku-Pulmakom Road, which when they came into power, in less than one month, they stopped it and the constructors carried away everything of theirs. It has come back and it is there; they should check the list of roads and they will find it if they are interested. Mr Speaker, it is very interesting that, today, we have our Colleagues on the other Side talking about moneys not being paid. Meanwhile, decentralisation has taken centre stage; not less than GH¢1.3 million has been paid to the various district assemblies.

Mr Speaker, about 25 per cent of the 80 per cent of the District Assemblies Common Fund (DACF) released to the assemblies is meant to build markets for the 24-Hour Economy, where our women and business people can do their turnaround and ensure that they buy and sell and it will enhance our economic situation. Nobody sits in Accra again to say they are giving this market or they are doing A or B. It is going to be done by the district assembly and we will have to see to it that it is properly done. You and I are those who will monitor and evaluate

to ensure that the works are properly done. So, they should not say that there is no money that is being released.

Mr Speaker, out of that money, 10 per cent is meant to build two Community-based Health Planning and Services (CHPS) compounds. We know about our health issues; even when we go to the villages, our men and women, especially the children, are struggling. We need these CHPS compounds in the various areas to enable us to support our people. We should not think that because we are in Accra or living in a more developed place, others should continue to suffer. So, the Government has found it prudent that, health-wise, we need to continue constructing CHPS compounds and the budget has already been released and they are to start building the two CHPS compounds in every district assembly.

Mr Speaker, about 10 per cent is supposed to be used in building one KG block, one primary school block, and one junior high school in every community. Mr Speaker, we need to appreciate that there are most of us here whose children are sitting in very high-quality classrooms. Meanwhile, in some of the places, it is still being seen that rafters, grass and mud are used to construct and children have no places to sit. If the Government has come out with this innovative activity and the money has gone, I do not see why we should sit here and say no money has been released. Mr

Speaker, if moneys have not been released, how are we getting our salary? We, as MPs, how are we getting our salaries? Moneys have been released; that is why we are being paid.

Mr Speaker, water is very important and our people need water. If we go to the village, some people are still drinking from the dams. It is very bad. We need potable water and 10 per cent of that money would be used in constructing not less than 10 boreholes in every district. So, my Colleagues should keep an eye and ensure that those boreholes are drilled for our people to have water. *[Hear! Hear!]*

Mr Speaker, on furniture, when we go to our schools today, some of them either sit right on the floor or pick stones or even take blocks to sit on to read and even write. And we can see the teachers standing and not knowing how to even supervise or assess these children. About 10 per cent of that money would be used in procuring furniture. It is all in the Budget.

Mr Speaker, a whopping 20 per cent to complete all the abandoned projects or the legacy projects that they started. They started and left them and refused to continue and it is the taxpayers' money that is sitting there. It is going to be worked on.

7.43 p.m.

Mr Speaker, let me come to the Women's Development Bank. It is

very interesting; our locals have got a saying that, if one has small and gives to a person, the person expects that when one has more, they would give to him. Let me tell them that it is unfortunate that after counting all these things and saying that they are centralised, they like women and support women, they have never thought of even building a toilet for women. They have never done it. If we have set aside GHC52 million for the start of the Women's Development Bank, hooray, we are grateful that, at least, we have started.

Mr Speaker, girls in schools were buying sanitary pads at GHC25; today, it is GHC15. Some people even sell it for GHC14. His Excellency John Dramani Mahama has made sure that girls in senior high and junior high schools are getting free sanitary pads, so that those girls do not go, excuse my language, to sleep with men simply because they want to buy sanitary pads.

Mr Speaker, on the School Feeding Programme, there were hundreds of schools that were not getting food; yet, it was mostly taunted that we have a School Feeding Programme. Today, all schools are being fed, that is at the basic level. In the senior high schools, our own children went to school and returned within two weeks and sometimes, after one week, because there was no food. All the moneys have been sent to the senior high schools and they purchase their own food. Nobody has any problem with that. Nobody will ask anybody for any money.

Mr Speaker, it is unfortunate that our Colleagues on the other Side, most of them, most probably men, will not go to the market to shop, so they have not seen that the price of a bucket of tomatoes, which used to sell at GHC200 is now selling at GHC70. Yes, that one alone is something to write home about. Let us buy a bag of *kokonte* and we will see how much it costs. Then we can come back and blame the Government. Let us appreciate what this Government has done.

They talked of exchange rates. Was it everybody who could go to the market—

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hajia Laadi, please, your time is almost up; wind up.

Hajia Ayamba: Was it everybody who could go to the market or the bank to get dollars? No. So, please.

Mr Speaker, I appreciate the time you have given me and for taking the trouble to listen to me till this time, but my Colleagues on the other Side, please, let us ensure that we work in harmony and pass this fiscal policy review as expected. Then we can go along—*[Hear! Hear!]*

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Thank you very much, Hon Laadi Ayamba.

Hon Members, we now turn to Mr Akwasi Acquah. Hon Member, I

understand you are a Ranking Member; is that not the case?

Mr Acquah: Yes, Mr Speaker, I am a Ranking Member.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Yes, so you are entitled to 15 minutes.

Mr Alexander Akwasi Acquah (NPP — Akim Oda): Mr Speaker, there is an Akan saying that goes like, *wo de woano dɔ nnwere a, ebi nnwo wo*. To wit, if a farmer gets up in the morning, stands in his house and gauges the acres of farm that he wants to weed for a day, I will weed here and there, in just about five minutes, he would have finished weeding without any of the shrubs affecting him. This is exactly the case of our Friends on the other Side.

They talk as if we are still on the campaign trail. They are in Government, for God's sake, and all the indices they are trying to get us to understand, we have to feel them in our pockets. It is not just about figures and jargons; we need to experience the kind of economic change that they are talking about. This is a House of records, I just checked with my assembly members, they have not received any allowance—*[Interruption]*—All of us have assembly members, so let us pick up our phones and check. This has been the mantra of this Government. When the Minister for Finance came here to announce that he is sending moneys to the local authorities, it took over two months before the money hit the

Mid-Year Budget Review, 2025

account. So, it is so serious that our Friends on the other Side will come and talk about figures that are not real. That is just by way of introduction.

Mr Speaker, as a growing concern and how critical the health sector is, I am surprised it did not find space and expression in the Mid-Year Budget Review. The sector was treated like any other sector and that has actually generated some uneasy calm within the health sector.

Mr Speaker, we know that our nurses and midwives went on strike. Your Committee, the Committee on Health, took it upon itself and intervened. Now, meetings after meetings, we were told that whatever we have agreed upon in those meetings would be in the Mid-Year Budget Review. I am told and I have read that the Minister had not come here to ask for an increase in expenditure.

Meanwhile, at the peak of the strike, we were told that the Government needed GH¢2 billion before they can meet the demands of these nurses. Now that the Minister did not come to ask for any increment in expenditure, how would they make sure the nurses work and do not think about going back to the strike? We on the Minority have told our Friends that if they do not handle this situation that well and they go back, we would not be part of any mediation team because we have done our best.

Mr Speaker, very recently, there was a launch of a 24-Hour service in the Ghana Health Service. I want to put on record that the Ghana Health Service has always operated on a 24-Hours basis, but if one wants to go to the sub-district units, like the CHPS compounds and the health centres which close at a certain time, there are certain things that we need to put in place to make them work 24-Hours. These things have not been done.

Most of the nurses who work in the CHPS compounds and the health centres do not live close to the facilities. We want them to work 24-Hours, but we have not thought about giving them any accommodation to make it easier for them to go to work 24-Hours.

7.53p.m.

Mr Speaker, in my other world, when I was the Deputy Minister for Health, we tried so hard to manage the Mpox. There were no deaths recorded. As I speak to you now, Mr Speaker, I want to share some staggering data with you. Mr Speaker, the total number of confirmed cases as of today for Mpox is 282 and one death has been recorded. The total number of cases in home isolation is 94. The total number of cases recovered is 187. The cumulative number of contacts identified is 1,987. The total contacts who have completed 21 days' follow-up is 1,498. And Mr Speaker, this is the most staggering one; the number of regions that recorded confirmed cases

is 14 Regions out of 16. And nobody is talking about Mpox. The Minister for Health needs money to embark on aggressive campaigns so that people will know exactly what we are talking about.

If you are a father of a house and you want to manage your resources and attribute it to the fact that we have spent recklessly, should we die? Should all of us die? Instead of releasing money? *[Interruption]* You see, I just gave statistics that out of the 16 regions, 14 have recorded Mpox and they think if it is getting everywhere, I am the only person going to be affected? All of us are going to be affected, Mr Speaker. The Minister for Health needs money. They need to release money to the Minister for Health so that he can embark on aggressive campaigns to let people understand what Mpox is. Because there is no money for release, they have decided to keep quiet and this virus is spreading. Mr Speaker, it is spreading. So I thank you that I have this opportunity to let Ghanaians know that this is what is happening and the Government is refusing to talk about it. The Government is refusing to release money for us to embark on an aggressive campaign so that people will know that Mpox is everywhere.

Mr Speaker, the main Budget in paragraph 687 said that Government was going to continue the Agenda 111 Programme. Mr Speaker, I am so surprised that in spite of this promise, when Government said that it was going to take into consideration those

that are far advanced so that they work on them, it did not find expression in the Mid-Year Budget Review. What it means is that we are going to allow these audacious projects to lie and deteriorate all because they do not want Ghanaians to enjoy the good deeds of Nana Addo Dankwa Akufo-Addo. The spread of hospitals all over, such an ambitious project — They are refusing to go there and now they have given money to district assemblies to build CHPS Compounds. They have given money to build CHPS compounds when these hospitals are there and these moneys could have gone into it and then we do it bit by bit. Mr Speaker, why? Why? Why should this happen? Why should this happen? Why should I not cry? Ghanaians have given them this mandate; they gave them the mandate for them to govern and ensure that all of us are comfortable. Because they came lying to us, now they do not know how to govern. The expectations are so high. The expectations are so high and all they are doing is to tell us stories and tell us that they have sent the money and the money is gone. Assemblymen are telling me to tell them that they have not received any money. The assemblymen have not received any money.

Mr Speaker, my time is running but there is this information and inconsistencies that must be exposed. Mr Speaker, before the Minister for Finance came to this House, a week earlier, the Minister for Health had met the press in the Government's

Accountability Series. The Minister for Health stated that the Health Insurance coverage now stands at 15 million as of 2024 and that this Administration has added over 670,000 additional citizens to the scheme. Mr Speaker, that is a lie. That is a lie. They said 15 million but the main Budget that was read says 18.5 million. Mr Speaker, if we cannot reconcile simple statistics, if the Minister for Finance's statistics is so different from that of the Minister for Health, why should I believe any of the figures? These are figures that have gone to the IMF; the IMF knows this figure as 18.5 million. So how come the Minister for Health stated 15 million people? Is it the case that they want to just kill Health Insurance because of the MahamaCares Initiative? Why would they quote 15 million when the statistics given is that it is 18.5 million? Hon Ato Forson missed that opportunity to have clarified this position. He missed that golden opportunity. And if you check Manasseh Azure's Facebook post— which is which? Which one should we take? The Minister for Finance says the coverage of Health Insurance is 18.5 million and the Minister for Health, the one in charge, says it is 15 million. Mr Speaker, you see the inconsistencies? Mr Speaker, have you seen the exposure? They do not know how to manage this economy. So the figures that have been handed over to them, they are just juggling around with the figures. Why would the Minister for Health say the health insurance coverage is 15 million while the Minister for

Finance in the main Budget stated 18.5 million? Mr Speaker, why are they treating us this way? Why are they treating Ghanaians this way?

In fact, three years is just around the corner. We have just about three more Christmases and Ghanaians will now have the opportunity to decide whether they should continue living under this Administration that is full of lies and dishonesty. Deceit— They came to power through deceit so they are doing everything to maintain that status quo. Health insurance has always been 18.5 million. Now the Minister for Finance meets and says it is 15 million. Where are the 3 million people? And these are records that the IMF has captured.

I thank you very much for this opportunity for Ghanaians to know that we cannot trust this Government. We cannot trust this Government. 15 million— 18.5 million— *Asemsebe*.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, it appears the Chamber is too cold. Is it all right?

Let me now turn to Hon Rev Ntoso. Hon Ntoso, I guess you are Chairperson or a Ranking Member? You are entitled to 15 minutes.

Rev Helen Adjoa Ntoso (NDC— Krachi West): I will do less than that.

Thank you, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity given me to contribute to the Motion on the floor.

Mr Speaker, before I do that, I want to commend the Minister for Finance for the heartwarming Budget Review that he presented under the inspiration of His Excellency John Dramani Mahama. We are so grateful to him for this wonderful budget review.

8.03 p.m.

Mr Speaker, before I continue, I would like to correct what an Hon Member on the other Side said that prisoners are fed with a sum of GH¢0.60 a day. Mr Speaker, that is not correct. Prisoners are fed with a sum of GH¢1.80 a day, so I just want to correct that.

Mr Speaker, for the first time, from the budget that was allocated to the Ministry of Gender, Children and Social Protection, from January to June, the Ministry has received 50 per cent of the total amount; this has never happened. Mr Speaker, I have been on the Committee for 12 years, and mostly what happens is that at the end of the year, we would realise that there is a great negative variance. So, if from January to June, they have received 50 per cent of the amount that has been allocated to them, then we have got to pat the Minister for Finance on the shoulder. He has done very well.

So far, an amount of, GH¢895 million has been disbursed to the Ministry to be able to cater for over 34,000 caterers in this country, which is good news for everyone. This is because we know that caterers used to go to the Ministry picketing because

they have not been paid. But now, we hear that they are quiet because they have been paid. So, the Minister for Finance has done very well.

Mr Speaker, it used to be that for school feeding, school children were fed with one GH¢1.50. Mr Speaker, it has been increased to GH¢2.00, which is 33.3 per cent which is also good news. Then, Mr Speaker, I also want to let Members know that GH¢728.8 million was allocated to LEAP in 2024. But in 2025, an amount of GH¢953.5 million was allocated to LEAP, and that is a 31 per cent increase, indicating how the government is resilient to help eradicate poverty.

Mr Speaker, again with LEAP, before 2025, one-member household was paid GH¢128 but, now one-member household is paid GH¢512. Mr Speaker, two-member households before 2025 were paid GH¢152, now, they are receiving GH¢608. Three-member households before 2025 were receiving GH¢176 Mr Speaker, now they are receiving GH¢704 Mr Speaker, before 2025, four or more member households were receiving only GH¢212, now they are receiving GH¢848, more than 100 per cent increase. So, this is good news for those who are poor.

Mr Speaker, when it comes to sanitary pads, we know that girl child absenteeism was partly as a result of lack of sanitary pads. That is because sanitary pads were so expensive. Now, quality sanitary pads that were

sold at GH¢120 Mr Speaker, now has been reduced. So, this is good news for the girl child, to reduce girl child absenteeism.

Mr Speaker, we all know for a fact that His Excellency the President talked about the Big Push, so, we should all be happy. With the Big Push, I am so excited that—Because I drive through Atimpoku—The Atimpoku to Asikuma junction road is bad. Under the Big Push, this road would be rehabilitated. Then from Dodo Pepesu to Nkwanta, that road would also be rehabilitated. From Dodo Pepesu to Nkwanta then to Damango, that is the eastern corridor road. Mr Speaker, if that road is constructed from Nkwanta to Damango, and to Bimbilla, the former Minister for Defence's constituency, travellers from the Northern Region will stop passing through Kumasi, and will pass through Bimbilla to Damango to Nkwanta, Jasikan, Hohoe then to Accra. Mr Speaker, I am saying that the road would be constructed through the constituency of the former Minister for Defence and that is good news.

Mr Speaker, the people of Oti region are so excited. The bridge over Oti River is under the Big Push, but we see it as the biggest push because if that bridge over Oti River is constructed, it will boost economic activities, and travel time will also be reduced. Because all the constituencies in the Northern regions, will no longer pass through Kumasi when they are travelling to

Accra. They will pass through Dambai, and Mr Speaker, it is several kilometres shorter, so travel time will be reduced. So, the people of Oti region are also happy.

Mr Speaker, His Excellency John Dramani Mahama has also promised that he would put up a technical university for the people of Oti region, which we are also excited about. Mr Speaker, I get a bit disappointed—I am a security person—When we are to debate on the Mid-Year Budget Review and we are talking about security issues that we are not supposed to talk about on the Floor; it is so disappointing. Mr Speaker, we have to take this very seriously.

There are certain issues that we do not have to talk about when we as Members of the Committee on Defence and Interior are privileged to visit the security agencies and they give us certain information. Mr Speaker, it is very wrong as a security person to discuss those issues on the floor of Parliament. So that will have to be corrected.

Mr Speaker, I wonder why our Colleagues are saying that this government is not spending or the Minister for Finance is not spending. I am a bit surprised because I do not know whether because they were not in the Chamber, they did not hear the Minister for Finance talk about the releases. Mr Speaker, if GH¢300 million was released for no-fee stress policy, is it not spending? Mr

Mid-Year Budget Review, 2025

Speaker, GHC191.70 million as teacher training allowance has also been paid; is it not spending? Mr Speaker, GHC462.60 million as nursing training allowance has been paid; is it not spending? [**Some Hon Members:** It is spending]. Mr Speaker, GHC25 million was paid to Assembly members as allowance; is it not spending? Mr Speaker, GHC21 million for the National Apprenticeship Programme has been released; is it not spending? [**Some Hon Members:** It is spending]

8.13 p.m.

Mr Speaker, GHC1.4 billion for national health insurance claim has been paid; is it not spending? Mr Speaker, GHC252 million for vaccines and essential medicines has been paid; is it not spending? Mr Speaker, I can go on and on. Is it not spending? Mr Speaker, if Members are now not too worried because they have also received something, is it not spending? So, my Colleagues on the other Side should stop saying that Government is not spending and that the Minister for Finance is not spending.

Mr Speaker, I also want to say that we will commence the selection of new bookrunners to assist Government in the reopening of the domestic market who will focus on the banks and investment dealers with the ability to achieve a wider market distribution and advice on policy and structuring. Is it not a good policy?

Mr Speaker, Colleagues have spoken and I do not want to repeat what Members have already said. But I just want to say that this is a very good thing the Minister for Finance has done, so we should all encourage him. He is a very smart guy. What H.E. former Vice President, Dr Bawumia, could not do is what has taken him less than six months to do. So, we should encourage him, so that the next time he comes with another Budget, most of the issues that for eight years, the NPP could not solve, he will be able to solve them in just two years. We should stop playing politics. Too much politics is not good. Too much partisan politics is no good. We should call a spade a spade, not a spoon. When the person is doing well, we should encourage the person. When the person is not doing well, we do not even condemn. What we have got to do is that, we have got to inspire the person, so that the person will do better.

Mr Speaker, thank you for the opportunity. [*Hear! Hear!*]

Mr Akwasi Gyamfi Onyina-Acheampong (NPP — Kwabre East): Thank you Mr Speaker for the opportunity to contribute to this debate. Mr Speaker, having gone through the main Budget and this Mid- Year Review, I have a few observations.

Mr Speaker, I have observed that the Budget and the Mid-Year Review preach possibilities but offer mirages. They preach hope but offer despair.

They mask realities and offer vanities. This Budget flatters to deceive because it promises plenty but delivers on just a few.

Mr Speaker, in fact, this is an *ɔdo adaada me* Budget. I say so because there is an adage in the Akan language which says that, to wit, if one finds the big head chewing the palm nut, one would think it is soft. When they were on the sidelines, they were thinking it is easy to govern and so their promises kept on flying left, right and centre.

Mr Speaker, they promised a 24-Hour Economy and we find that there has been no single Budgetary allocation to 24-Hour Economy. In fact, Mr Speaker, 24-Hour Economy is embedded in the system. It is not really a policy. They have to stimulate it by demand. So, the See Ghana, the Grow Ghana and the Wear Ghana initiatives, if all these initiatives come into being and there is no demand, where will be the sustainability? Mr Speaker, let us do the first things first and do the right things right. They should stimulate the demand and they will get the results. Which is why former President Kufuor initiated the Friday wear in an attempt to stimulate Wear Ghana. This is a proper attempt and a proper approach to the 24-Hour Economy.

Mr Speaker, this Government promised that it was not going to impose any other tax burdens on the country. Let me outline just a few. We have 17.2 per cent electricity tariffs,

2.5 per cent increase in water tariffs, GH¢4.5 on every gallon of fuel, extra 2 per cent on the Growth and Sustainability Levy. Mr Speaker, between 30 per cent to 40 per cent increase in all statutory fees, including passport fees. The Hon Minister for Foreign Affairs who just walked in, was here a while ago and he was saying that there will be no increment —

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Did you see him before mentioning his name?

Mr Onyina-Acheampong: He said passport fees will be reduced. Mr Speaker, the Minister for Finance has just come back to tell us that there is going to be a 30 per cent to 40 per cent increment on all statutory fees, including passport fees. Communication Service Tax is still here. It has not been abolished. The Minister said if the Government does not introduce the abolishment of this tax in the first year, he is going to criticise his own Government. He is now mute. Mr Speaker, the tiger has turned into a cat and has been muted.

Mr Speaker, this Government, at every turn, is sabotaging Ghanaians and at every turn, is short-changing Ghanaians for their own benefit. Why do I say so? The treasury bill rate has reduced from 27 per cent to 14.5 per cent. Meanwhile, if I want to borrow money to do business, I am going to pay 27 per cent. So, there is a wide disconnect. Are we encouraging

investment? No. So, Mr Speaker, it is short-changing us at every turn.

Mr Speaker, now the dealers of Gold Board are receiving GH¢8,000 out of a possible GH¢12,000 or GH¢13,000. Apart from that, Gold Board operations are shrouded in secrecy. Now, we do not know where Gold Board is going to apply the margins that it would be earning and what they are going to use the margins for. We do not know. In terms of COCOBOD, we know they are going to pay Licensed Buying Companies (LBC) margins, transporter margins and the lot. But for Gold Board, it is shrouded in secrecy. We do not know what they are going to use this money for.

Mr Speaker, cocoa farm gate prices. This Government promised heaven to cocoa farmers. They knew Ghana cocoa is traded based on the future and not on spot. But in the wee hours of 2024, they promised Ghanaians that they were going to increase the price of cocoa to GH¢6,000 based on the spot price.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Acheampong, your time is up. You have gone past it. Alright, conclude.

Mr Onyina-Acheampong: Mr Speaker, let me conclude by quoting from one Martin Niemöller. He was a prominent German pastor and at some point, he was an advocate for Nazis and when Hitler assumed office, he started criticising Hitler. Let us see what he said:

“First, they came for the socialists, and I did not speak out—because I was not a socialist. Then they came for the trade unionists, and I did not speak out — because I was not a trade unionist. Then they came for the Jews, and I did not speak out — because I was not a Jew. Then they came for me —and there was no one left to speak for me.”

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Thank you.

Mr Onyina-Acheampong: Everybody is quiet. Ghanaians have to speak against this Government.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: My Friend, Hon Member for Yunyoo, do you want to speak?

Mr Sulemana Alhassan: Yes.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: He is a friend I found.

8.23 p.m.

Anyway, you can do that tomorrow; today, your name is not on the list, so I will give you the opportunity tomorrow. I will give you a special time, so do not worry. No, he is my Friend, so, tomorrow, I will give him a special time. It is now the turn of Hon Nokoe.

Mr Kofi Arko Nokoe (NDC — Evalue-Ajomoro-Gwira): Thank you, Mr Speaker, for what I want the *Hansard* to capture as one of the most

profound gratitude to contribute to this Mid-Year Review Budget which will go down in history as one of the best, brilliant and outstanding Mid-Year Reviews. Why am I saying so? I am saying so because this is a Mid-Year Budget Review that has brought relief, hope and air of optimism from Axim, my home town, all the way to the north.

Mr Speaker, from start to finish, the indicators show that, indeed, in a space of just six months, we have done what the NPP could not do in eight years—[*Hear! Hear!*]*—*A lot has been said about the indices, but I would want to bench my debate on food inflation. It is sad that, as of last year, it was a known fact that on the stretch of the west coast, Ghana happened to be one of the most expensive places to live when it comes to even purchasing of food. When you travel to La Cote d’Ivoire where you can just come up with some few CFA, you can have enough food to eat. It is amazing how food inflation was able to decline from 27.8 per cent as of December 2024 to 16.3 per cent as at June 2025. And when the outstanding Minister for Finance was mentioning food staples that have reduced in price, the people in Nzema want me to say and also add to the record that, because of prudent management, a sack of corn dough for *acheke* has reduced from GH¢960 in December 2024 to GH¢520.

Mr Speaker, *mbor*, to wit, corn dough—The people of Cape Coast for *etew*—The price of corn dough has

reduced from GH¢1,500 as in December 2025 to GH¢1,000. I am a teacher by profession; I was saddened last year when a colleague teacher of mine told me that, due to the depreciation in the value of their salaries, at the end of the month, all they could purchase was corn dough. So, it was *koko* in the morning, skipping lunch, and then *etew ne ntsenam*, to wit *etew* and fried fish in the evening. But due to the prudent management of this economy, he called me just two days ago that, now, in addition to the *mbor*, he is able to buy rice for jollof. So, this is what happens. In the morning, it is rocks, “*aburo* rice water”; then in the afternoon, it is jollof and, in the evening, it is *banku* and this shows that we need to pat the back of this Government for a wonderful job done.

Mr Speaker, I want to diverge into the area of energy. I am so much happy that, due to prudent management, it is covered in this Budget that negotiations have started with regards to Power Purchasing Agreement (PPA). The difficulties we have had as a nation is because of some agreement that we did that is still costing us and for the Minister for Energy and Green Transition to take the bold step to go and renegotiate with Early Power, Cenpower Generation Limited, and Twin City Energy shows that we mean business and we, as we promised to keep the light on, is something we are going to do.

Mr Speaker, to the ordinary man, what is the price waterfall mechanism about? The Government of President Mahama has ensured that Electricity Company of Ghana (ECG), which happens to be at the end of the value chain—What it does is that, after collecting revenues, the price waterfall mechanism should ensure that everybody on the value chain gets its share and there has been a lot of effort in that regard.

Mr Speaker, I want to move you to page 50, paragraph 341 and I am so happy that with regards to making way for the private partner to join in the management of ECG; it is a laudable thing that we should comment on. What it means is that if, in Osu area, bulk power is given to Kojo Armah to manage, it will be like MTN, which never used to print credit load-up cards but used to sell it in bulk to people to print. And if we should involve the private person, it should ensure that efficiency would be inculcated in the management of our energy sector and, in the end, power will be stable because the 24-Hour Economy will be benched on stable power.

Mr Speaker, I proceed to paragraph 347. This is a bold initiative of the Ministry of Energy and Green Transition to establish a renewable energy authority; for eight years, this one was just a table that was at the Ministry. When we talk about carbon capture, there is so much money in it because there are companies that are producing so much carbon dioxide,

but are willing to invest in economies that will put up mechanisms to sop up the carbon. And with this authority, Ghana would yield billions in cedis and dollars to help the economy.

Mr Speaker, I am with joy to hear and also to bring to the floor of this House that, just this year, Afena X made a viable discovery. For eight years, when the NPP was in government, we were dwindling with regards to our fossil carbons because these people failed to invest in drilling holes in discoveries. And I am happy that under the able leadership of President Mahama and the Ministry of Energy and Green Transition, we have viable commercial wells.

Mr Speaker, to conclude, I do not want to speak much or I have about three minutes more for the good news to go on. The problem with this country, especially with regards to energy stability, is to expand our energy mix and that is why it is with joy that we have been able to secure this partnership with Tullow, which is a US\$2 billion facility. What it means is that there will be more wells to be drilled, where there will be more gas to power the Atuabo and the second phase of the Ghana Gas plant.

Mr Speaker, because we, as a country—They ask of the 24-Hour Economy. We want to put good measures in place to ensure that, once it is rolled, it will yield to the benefit of every Ghanaian. We will never rush the way they rushed the Free Senior High School (FSHS) policy.

Mid-Year Budget Review, 2025

We will never rush the way they rushed the Planting for Food Jobs policy, which might be good, but achieve nothing in the end.

Mr Speaker, I thank you for the opportunity and I want to call on Ghanaians to give us the benefit of doubt and support us in full strength because we will deliver. Thank you, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity. *[Hear! Hear!]*

8.33 p.m.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Let me now turn to Hon Tweneboa Fokuo. Hon Member, you have 10 minutes.

Mr Tweneboa Kodua Fokuo (NPP — Manso Nkwanta): Mr Speaker, the Mid-Year Budget Review that was read to us confirms the outcry of the public about the focus of the Government in expenditure restraint, rather than focusing on economic growth. We realise that the Minister for Finance is focusing just to control expenditure rather than moving on in growing the economy.

Indeed, Mr Speaker, the Minister spoke about having been able to control primary balance, moving it in surplus of 1.1 per cent of GDP. The Minister was also full of praise for having reduced fiscal deficit, moving it to 0.7 per cent of GDP, but what he failed to do was to talk about what he had done with revenue, because revenue, as we have now, is well

below the expected target of 18 per cent of GDP. Ghana, as we speak now, is among the lowest when it comes to revenue to GDP across the continent and the Minister failed to talk about this, which is crucial.

Mr Speaker, the issue about fiscal discipline should not just be about cutting expenditure. It should be part of a planned economic transformation programme, not just about cutting expenditure, because cutting expenditure is very easy to do, but is that what we want to do as a country?

Mr Speaker, if we look at what the Minister presented, he made it seem as if he is spending. So, he is spending money and making certain payments, but if we look at these payments that he is making, we would realise that these are actually payments that he has to make anyway. These are statutory payments. They are not payments that the Minister has any discretion, so should we tout this, when he is making payments that he has to make anyway?

Mr Speaker, you asked a question, why did the Minister not tell us how much he has spent on some of the key programmes of the Government? Women's Development Bank, how much has he spent on it? What payment has he made towards it? No mention of it. Mr Speaker, the Big Push Programme, how much has been paid towards this? We do not know. The Agriculture for Economic Transformation Agenda (AETA), how much has been paid towards this?

We do not know. The 24-Hour Economy, how much has been paid towards this? We do not know. So, Mr Speaker, all the payments that the Minister mentioned, and I will go over them, they are statutory payments.

Mr Speaker, the other issue about payments to contractors was entirely missing in the presentation. What is happening? Cash has to flow. We need cash flow for the country to run. We cannot just cut back. That is not how you run an economy.

Mr Speaker, I will just highlight some of the 23 items that the Minister carefully spoke about that he spent so much money on and Ghanaians will understand the Minister has no choice than to spend on these items. These are statutory. He talked about payment of loans, bond holders and the District Assemblies Common Fund (DAFC). If he pays DAFC, should we clap for him? Social Security and National Insurance Trust (SSNIT), if he pays SSNIT, should we clap for him? If he pays GETFund, should we clap for him? If he pays National Health Insurance Scheme (NHIS), should we clap for him? If he pays LEAP beneficiaries, should we clap for him? All these are statutory; he has to pay. He has no choice.

Mr Speaker, the last item on the list, the 23rd item, I have interest there. The Minister said he has paid GH¢2 billion to National Investment Bank. As a former Managing Director of National Investment Bank, I have

interest here because the bank was really restructured by the previous Administration and the Minister should have given credence where it is due. Mr Speaker, I have to thank the Minister for completing the recapitalisation, but on record, this was started by the previous Administration. This is a fact; so the Minister should give credence to those of us who transformed the bank. After all, the new Administration has been in place for just a few months. The board was appointed just a couple of weeks ago.

Mr Speaker, I will just highlight some of the achievements that have led to what we have at the bank now, so that the Minister will hear and next time, I believe, he will give credence.

First, development of a strategic plan which transformed the bank, development of a comprehensive business analytics and financial reporting tools, development of comprehensive reports on all aspects of the business, implementation of a robust ARCO process that eliminated revaluation losses of GH¢2 million a month on record, development of an enterprise risk model in the bank, development of 80 new policies and procedures to guide the operations of the bank, and trimming of excess staff numbers from 1,597 to 910. Thus, reducing the staff strength by 43 per cent to ensure we get to an optimal level. This is the 900 staff that the Minister said he had saved. This was saved far back in 2019. We reduced it by 43 per cent. He should give credence to us.

Increasing deposit from GHC3.2 billion to GHC6.2 billion. This is what the Minister said he had protected; we did that years ago. Enhancing the IT system of the bank to prevent cyber-attacks and ensuring efficient service delivery, and renegotiation of service contracts and other costs initiatives has also resulted in reduction in costs. Then last but not least, elimination of the overhang of the Eland international lawsuit against NIB, which could have cost the bank in excess of US\$100 million. This is on record. If this had gone through, the bank would have been gone. We spent days and nights achieving this, so, Mr Speaker, a lot has been done.

I will talk about one last point and I will be done. Mr Speaker, aside the strength of the cedi that we have seen, and my Colleagues have spoken about that, the item that has been spoken about the most is inflation and I want to touch on that. Mr Speaker, the Minister was quick to talk about inflation and said inflation had reduced to 13.7 per cent.

It is good that inflation has reduced to 13.7 per cent, but then ask yourself, what has been the contribution of the Government to this reduction? On the contrary, one will realise that where the Government has control, inflation has actually gone up on those items and I will give you an example, Mr Speaker. If we look at the food segment, inflation is actually not 13.7 per cent. With the food basket, inflation is 16.3 per cent. So, when we

talk about 13.7 per cent, we have to clarify.

Mr Speaker, let me talk about items that the Government has control over in the inflation basket and those items have seen their inflation actually rocketing in the non-food basket.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, you should begin to descend for landing.

8.43 p.m.

Mr Fokuo: Mr Speaker, in conclusion, items that have had their inflation going up in the non-food basket, Mr Speaker, electricity, water, and gas—Who controls these? It is the Government.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Thank you.

So, Hon Members, we now turn to Hon Emmanuel Drah. Hon Member, you are entitled to five minutes.

Mr Emmanuel Drah (NDC — Upper West Akim): Thank you, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity to debate on the Motion on the Floor.

The presentation that was made by the Minister for Finance was evidence-based. The Minister made the presentation to us on 24th July, 2025 in the House. In the first seven pages, he tried to enumerate the shortfalls we inherited from the previous administration. But the young man has been very tactical,

strategic and professional in handling the economy for the past six months.

I must say to the fact that when he took over in the last week of January 2025, the first month of his performance indicated that treasury bill rates started descending. In the third month of his office, interest rates started coming down. Exchange rates followed in that order. Mr Speaker, it has appeared in this House that we are not spending. But most of the presentations from other Colleagues have shown that the Minister has really spent.

Our Hon Minister was mentioning areas of huge expenditures we have incurred over the past six months. But I must add to it that the Minister presented to this House that he has spent GH ₵9.1 billion in the Energy sector for us to have a constant power supply and that is what we are enjoying now.

Mr Speaker, as part of his performance, the man has been able to uncover payroll fraud totalling about 67,000 ghost names on the Government of Ghana payroll. If by arithmetic we try to average each ghost name at GH₵5,000 multiplied by 67,000, over the next six months ahead of us, look at the amount of money we are going to save. The man is doing prudent spending. He said he is being disciplined. And we said we are not only looking at prudence. Mr Speaker, what I am trying to explain here is that when one does prudent spending, one does not touch its

reserves, one does prudent spending and fiscal consolidation plans are intact. Do you understand? Mr Speaker, let me go back to some of the key economic indicators that will expose them.

Mr Speaker, in 2024, as of December, GDP growth was 4.9 in quarter one. Comparatively, in 2025 GDP growth is 5.4. Mr Speaker, when we do the calculations, we will see that we are doing very well, as the key performance indicators are showing.

Mr Speaker, let us move on to consumer price inflation. In December 2024, it was 23.8, but as of May, we have recorded 18.3. Mr Speaker, we are doing very well, and I want to pray that this House hurriedly approves the projections for the next six months to take us to December 31, 2025. Thank you for the opportunity. *[Hear! Hear!]*

Mr Second Deputy Speaker:
Thank you very much.

I hope next time your leadership will give you more time. So, we will turn to take the last round of debate. We will ask Hon Isaac Boamah-Nyarko to take the last one from my left. You have 10 minutes.

Mr Isaac Boamah-Nyarko (NPP — Effia): Thank you very much, Mr Speaker.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: I know he is the Deputy Ranking. Hon Member, which Committee?

Mr Boamah-Nyarko: Mr Speaker, do you not worry, they know. We can proceed.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: No, I am asking you.

Mr Boamah-Nyarko: Mr Speaker, on record, it is the Committee on Energy. Deputy Ranking Member on record, it has not been changed on the floor.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: No, for the Energy Committee, I do not think—

Mr Boamah-Nyarko: Mr Speaker, the point I am making is that, on the records of this House which is a House of Records, you can let them check which Committee I sit on as Deputy Ranking. That is all I am putting to you.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: No, I know he is Deputy Ranking, but it is not the Energy Committee because I am a Member of the Committee and so I know that you are not. Anyway, let us move on. We do not need to—Leader, do not worry.

Mr Boamah-Nyarko: Mr Speaker, thank you for the opportunity. And importantly, this is a House of records.

A few months ago, the Minister for Finance came here to present his Budget Statement for the year 2025. Ordinarily, in July, when he submits a Mid-Year Budget Review Report, one

would not expect a lot of debate and criticisms, because it is still early days yet in terms of the ability of the Government to execute the issues that it has raised in the Budget. But it is also important for us to state on record that the Financial Year of the Government is January to December and there is a popular saying in Akan that *agɔ besɔ a ɛfri anɔpa*. So, if we have the opportunity to review half year, then it is important for us to take stock.

What did the Government promise at the beginning of the year in its Budget? What have they delivered? What did they promise? What have they not delivered? And what are the challenges that we foresee in terms of the management of the economic space for the year 2025? As a responsible opposition, as always, if we need to proffer some recommendations, we offer them to the Government.

Mr Speaker, no one will contest the fact that the macroeconomics of this country, the outturn looks positive. We all know the rate of inflation has gone down. We know that the interest rates have gone down. And even when one takes the cedi's appreciation against the foreign currencies, one will acknowledge that it has stabilised. But the reality is that the stabilisation of the cedi as we see it today is very artificial.

8.53 p.m.

When the Minister for Finance came to this House, he said that the the exchange rate of Cedi to Dollar is

1:10.5, but when we check the interbank interest rate as at yesterday, it is going for GH¢11.7, and my reference is *Citi Business News* for last two days, a day after the Minister had laid it. Now, when we take, — *[Interruption]*— you can handle that as a matter of record, I have told you.

Mr Speaker, this is just an attempt to destabilise the conversation on the score of their promise they delivered in terms of the macro-economics, partially, because as I said, the future of the cedi does not look bright.

Mr Speaker, what did they promise that they have delivered over the first half of the year? One big issue, and I stood here and sang a song, *Mahama adaada me a*. They thought it was a joke. Now, reality is catching up on them, because Women's Bank, that Government initiated and promised GH¢50 million as seed capital. It is as if it does not exist in the books of Government. Nobody has commented on it.

Mr Speaker, many people have commented on the Coders Programme that Government initiated. As we speak, Government has not released even a dime for the Coders' programme. We have talked about the Big Push. Government is now bringing the contracts or the agreements that is going to generate the Big Push. As at July, nothing has been released for the Big Push. So, as

Hon Fokuo said, the releases so far are more of statutory releases than releases that goes to cushion and push the economic development of this country.

Mr Speaker, I would want to place emphasis on our tax revenue position, since that is an area, we have been overlooking as a House. The Minister came to this House and illustrated that Government was not going to introduce any tax policy or any taxes for the year 2025. They said they were going to abolish all the nuisance taxes. And the Minister came here at the first Budget reading in March and said they have abolished the e-Levy, and we sang praises for them. He said they had abolished Betting tax; we sang praises for them. He said they had abolished the Emission Tax but what did we see thereafter? Only three months after the Government Budget, eight different taxes have been introduced, and Government has never said anything to the people of Ghana, to try and explain to Ghanaians why they have introduced those taxes. So, they promise Ghanaians one thing, removal of taxes, and then they go by the back of Ghanaians and introduce other taxes. I think that is dishonesty on the part of Government and the Minister for Finance.

Mr Speaker, when we take away the tax revenue issues, we are also looking at the position of our revenue

Mid-Year Budget Review, 2025

performance for the year, as at July that the Minister came to this House. If we read the Minister's statement, he said that corporate tax was performing very well by GH¢533 million as at the end of June 2025 and he also indicated that customs duties have fallen by GH¢1.6 billion, meaning that if we check the difference between the gains of revenue as against the losses or the lack to generate GH¢1.6 billion, Government is at a deficit. It is for this reason that Government is looking for various options by increasing and bringing in place the “D-Levy” and the rest to cushion the economy.

Mr Speaker, it is interesting to note that as we speak now, Value Added Tax (VAT), which is an indirect tax that is supposed to cushion and push the economy; the revenue generation base of Ghana Revenue Authority (GRA), is underperforming by 17 per cent; reference is Ghana Revenue Authority revenue performance as at June, 2025. One can check. The GRA Board Chairman is there and so I am putting it to him and he knows that VAT is underperforming by 17 per cent. He went to a board meeting just two days ago. He has the facts. When we check rent, rent is underperforming and so there are other Government revenue handles that are underperforming, and Government is not coming up with innovative ways to meet those revenue expectations but then comes

by another door to increase taxes. That is a lazy way of generating revenue. That is not the best approach because Ghanaians expected the National Democratic Congress (NDC) Government, and Dr Cassiel Ato Forson to maintain the position that they are not increasing taxes or going to bring new taxes, but what we see now are increases in taxes.

Mr Speaker, if we check the VAT refund account, we remember the Minister was here telling us that refund accounts, which stood at 6 per cent, is going to be reduced to 4 per cent and that is supposed to—Hon Member, you remember, right? Good. He said Government was going to generate over GH¢2 billion plus from the Refund Account, the reduction from 6 to 4, to be able to cushion its budget. I have the Board Chairman here and I put it to him again—Go and check as at half-year, the tax revenue refund that has gone into GRA. GRA has exceeded revenue refund close to 6 per cent. It is in excess of 5 per cent. Now, we gave them 4 per cent, they are paying over 5 per cent. Where did they get the money to pay the difference of the refund when they capped it at 4 per cent. So, there are certain things that happens on this Floor when Government is introducing policies and from our end, we criticise them, it is not for criticising sake, but it is to guide Government that when it is taking

certain decisions, they need to consult broadly and widely.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Boamah-Nyarko, wind up.

Mr Boamah-Nyarko: Mr Speaker, with that, I want to end by appealing to Government that Gold Board, has generated so much, but it is leading to more *galamsey*. Our lands and forest are being destroyed. Civil Societies have come out and have spoken—

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, we will take the very last from Mr Atta Issah. But you should wait, how many minutes?

Mr Issah: At least, it will only be fair that because you gave him the last bite at 10 minutes, if you give me a similar one, I will be very—

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: 10 minutes. Just go ahead.

Mr Issah: Mr Speaker, let me use this opportunity to thank the Minister for Finance.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: With this Mr Acheampong will not talk—[*Laughter*]—

Mr Attah Issah (NDC — Sagnarigu): I want to thank the

Minister for Finance for presenting the Mid-Year Fiscal Policy Review and Economic Policy of the Government of Ghana.

Mr Speaker, the IMF has summarised as to who deserves the credit when it comes to the macroeconomic performance that we are seeing and I quote from the executive summary of the fifth review, and I quote,

“In the mid-year review, the monetary and fiscal policies of Government and the Central Bank has reported a stronger than expected economic trajectory for Ghana, leading to a narrow fiscal deficit forecast, robust disinflation, exchange rate stability, and solid fiscal discipline. And they continued by saying that it signals renewed investor confidence in alignment with IMF objectives.

Mr Speaker, let me also go to page 8 of the policy statement, with a quote from the Deputy Managing Director of the IMF, Mr Bo Li, who said this, and it is very profound, that “the Programme had deviated substantially from its target by the close of 2024.” So, it means that the country was already in reverse gear as at the last quarter of 2024. In fact, the executive summary proceeded by saying that:

“The new Government, which is the NDC Government, was faced with large policy slippages and reform delays at the end of 2024.

Mid-Year Budget Review, 2025

And they commended the new administration for the bold correction actions to maintain the programme on track.”

These are the words of the IMF Director and the Board.

Mr Speaker, when we are analysing an economy, there are basic issues that we look out for to know the health of the economy. So let us take it from this angle, macro and micro.

9.03 p.m.

At the macro level, we are looking at the GDP growth. Mr Speaker, in March, 2025, I spoke when the Budget was presented and I said that it is not just the number of growth or the quantum or the percentage; we look at the source of the drivers of the growth. In the first and second quarters, Ghana grew by the real GDP growth of 5.3 per cent. That is not my interest. My interest is that what led to this growth is not the usual service sector in terms of telecommunication, but it grew because of agriculture.

Mr Speaker, non-oil growth, which is the best measure of how an economic activity is progressing in the country, grew by 6.8 per cent. Inflation, I see my Friends trying to pooh-pooh the impact that it is making. The purpose of disinflation is to guarantee price stability and make business and consumers plan

properly. The Government had an end year inflation target of 11.9 per cent. Currently, we are already doing 13.7 per cent in just six months. If they do not praise the Minister for Finance, what again?

Mr Speaker, on food inflation, I heard the former Managing Director for National Investment Bank (NIB) state that food inflation has increased by 16.3 per cent; that is not true. At the end of year, food inflation was around 27 per cent. Currently, it has decreased to 16.3 per cent and that is why we can see that it reflects in the market of rice and bags of sugar and all those things. It is not true.

Mr Speaker, let us go to the exchange rate, which is the second macroeconomic indicator. Let us not underestimate the impact of exchange rate stability for businesses and the Government. When we borrow more of external debt, which is dollar rated, a significant drop in the dollar prices or a performance of the cedi simply means the exchange differentials will become negative. The NPP Government suffered this problem. It was not that they borrowed a whopping sum of GHC761 billion. What drove the debt was because of exchange differentials, because they could not manage the exchange.

Mr Speaker, the reserves position—They always say that it is because of the Gold Board. We anchor the economy on gold and my point is that, it was during their time that we saw *galamsey* taking over the

country, yet we did not see these reserves. So please, let us give credit when it is due.

Let us now come to the fiscals. Mr Speaker, I hear them saying Government is not spending. Let us do a little education here. Any little study, or if one has knowledge about public expenditure, as propounded by Harrod-Domar, Solo Model, Keynesian or Classical, they will tell one that growth in quarter one and quarter two are almost not possible or slower than quarters three and four. The reason is because in quarter one and quarter two, that is when governance structures are being put in place and that is when procurement methods are being outlined. So, one does not expect the Big Push Programme to happen in quarter one because even this Budget was approved in March, 2025. So, it tells us that after quarter one, that was when this Budget was approved. In one month, we do not expect procurement processes to be completed.

Mr Speaker, not only that, when we come to the Budget itself, the Government had a programme expenditure on cash basis, which is the best measure of total expenditure because on commitment basis, it includes multi-year commitments. We do not use it as a measure for 2025 expenditure. The Government cash expenditure for the year was GH¢206 billion. As we speak, inside this review, Government has already spent GH¢109.6 billion, which represents about 53 per cent of total

spending. How can a student who has 53 per cent be classified as someone who has failed? Yet in the first two quarters of 2024, they spent less than 39 per cent. Who deserves credits?

Mr Speaker, let me now come to this before my time runs up. When we come to the banking sector development—We were in this country, a certain government, under the guise of a banking sector cleanup, spent a whopping sum of GH¢30.3 billion to clean up a bank that they were supposed to spend only GH¢9 billion on. And this, I quote the asset quality review that was done by the IMF and the World Bank on page 53, that stated that the total bank deposit that was at risk was only 9 per cent. And even the assets at that time for various banks were in good shape. Yet, what did these people do? They spent GH¢30.3 billion, collapsing it, yet nonperforming loans increased. In fact, NIB, that the former Managing Director was talking about, had a capital adequacy ratio of negative 53 per cent. Upon all these developments that he mentioned, they left the bank on its knees.

Mr Speaker, not only that, look at the net capital inflow that has flowed into this country as a result of Dr Ato Forson. From March to June, the total net inflow of capital, that is what goes out of Ghana and what comes in, is US\$792 million. That shows that investors are once again having confidence in the Ghanaian economy.

Mr Speaker, let us now come to the economic outlook. People underestimate the importance of having investor confidence. Currently, the Government is in the process of issuing book runners to make sure that we return to the capital market to borrow at lower cost. That is the significance. But the issue is that, people complain that the private sector capital is going downwards because Government has reduced Treasury Bill (T-Bill) rate to ensure that they crowd out businesses. I beg to differ. If we read the statement very well, we would realise that access to credit capital for the private sector has grown by 31 per cent. So, it means that credit capital is also still available on the market.

Mr Speaker, I want to commend the Minister for Finance on one thing: his humility, candour and trust. In fact, he has already said that the wage bill poses a significant fiscal risk to us. He has talked about ballooning public debt in most State-Owned Enterprises (SOEs) like COCOBOD, Electricity Company of Ghana (ECG), and the rest. He has also talked about the marine oil gas diversions and its impact on the market. What did we see in the New Patriotic Party (NPP) regime? Despite all these positive strides, it is not graced with grandstanding *kenkey* party. This humility was not graced in the e-Levy cake. This was not graced in opulence, wearing white and quoting Bibles. The National Democratic Congress (NDC) Government is a Government of the

people and that is why we see that it is reflecting in the livelihoods of people. [*Hear! Hear!*]

Lastly, I will sum this all up with the Bank of Ghana's release that suggested that the incidence of poverty, that meant that four out of every 10 Ghanaians as of December 2024 was poor. Four out of every 10 Ghanaians has reduced to two out of every 10 Ghanaians, which means that our policies are trickling down to the grassroots and if they do not learn more, we have four more Christmases for them to go. And after that, they will go for four more Christmases that will make it eight and beyond. So please, the Minority Side should come to the Chamber and let us debate and they should not be holding press conferences because they will be badly exposed.

Thank you for the opportunity, Mr Speaker. [*Hear! Hear!*]

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, this is where we draw the curtains for today's debate on the Minister for Finance's Statement.

Leadership, any indication?

Mr Ricketts-Hagan: Mr Speaker, we have been here beyond five hours, so we are actually in your hands. But as you rightly said, this is the close of the debate for today and we will continue tomorrow. But we are hoping to be here tomorrow at 12 noon as it has been communicated.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker:
Very well. Minority Leadership?

Mr Shaib: Mr Speaker, that is subject to your further directions. I was thinking that closing at this time, we would rather come at two o'clock because we are tired. I spoke to my Leader about it, but we are in your hands, Mr Speaker.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker:
Very well. So, Hon Members, I guess we have to come here at two o'clock. Is that alright?

Mr Ricketts-Hagan: All right, Mr Speaker. We can arrive at a compromise and then reduce the number of debaters for tomorrow because we have to complete the debate tomorrow actually and have some other Government Business to do. So, if we can arrive at that compromise, then I am alright, otherwise—

Mr Second Deputy Speaker:
Very well. I am inclined to go by two o'clock because, apart from Hon Members, those at the Table are now going to work till midnight, and then have to come back tomorrow to prepare for us. At times, we only consider we the Hon Members without actually thinking about those at the Table. So please let us do the two o'clock.

Mr Ricketts-Hagan: On that human basis, we can agree on that.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker:
Very well. On that note, let me thank you. We have sat in for quite a long period, so we will accordingly adjourn the House till tomorrow two o'clock in the afternoon. The House stands adjourned.

ADJOURNMENT

The House was adjourned at 9.14 p.m. till Wednesday, 30th July, 2025 at 2:00 p.m.

Editor's Note

This *Official Report* was corrected by the House on 21st October, 2025 as follows:

- (a) Column 17, paragraph 2, line 9,
“Mohamed” was corrected to
“Mohammed”
- (b) Column 179, last paragraph, line 6,
“of” was inserted after “Review”.